

**A Traveler's Companion to the
Mazes of Menace**

Do not read this guide aloud. The dungeon is listening.

Contents

Before You Read Further	2
Before You Set Out	3
Choosing Your Expedition	4
What to Pack	9
Your First Descent	11
Dungeon Sights	15
The Lay of the Land	16
Field Guide to Dungeon Fauna	22
Points of Interest	28
Branches and Landmarks	34
Traps and Hazards	42
Feelings and Sounds	52
Survival	54
The Art of Combat	55
Ways to Die	60
Yet More Ways to Die	67
Divine Relations	80
Making Friends	86
Gear and Provisions	90
A Practical Identification Strategy	91
Provisions and Dining	104
The Apothecary	109
The Scroll Rack	113
Wands and Staves	117
Rings and Amulets	124

Tools of the Trade	128
The Armory	133
Curses and How to Break Them	137

Mastery 140

Spellcasting	141
Luck and Fortune	145
Enhancing Skills	149
Wishes and Wishing	155
Artifacts	158

The Deep Dungeon 166

The Castle	167
Gehennom	170
The Ascension Kit	177
The Ascension Run	179
The Elemental Planes	182

Appendices 185

Advanced Controls	186
Sokoban Solutions	190
Voluntary Challenges	200
Shopping and Shopkeeper Pricing	208
Weapons Tables	215
Armor Tables	226
Spell Tables	231
Bestiary Tables	234
What Changed Since Last Time	272
Acknowledgements	277

For more than forty years the NetHack community has grown Jay Fenlason's "first-semester programming project" into the most unforgivingly intricate and emblematic roguelike, and a thriving culture of fun and community beyond the game itself. We hope this companion helps bring the joy of NetHack to a new generation of players.



Before You Read Further

You are holding a guide to the Mazes of Menace, the vast and ever-shifting dungeon complex that sits beneath a place the locals just call “the dungeon entrance.” What lies below is one of the oldest and most treacherous adventure destinations in existence: dozens of levels of corridors, vaults, and special chambers, stretching from the relatively tame upper mines all the way down to the molten depths of Gehennom and beyond.

People have been descending into these depths for more than four decades. Most of them died. The ones who made it back brought stories, and some of those stories eventually got written down. You’re reading the latest edition of that accumulated lore.

A word of caution. This guide will change how you experience the Mazes. Once you know that a floating eye can paralyze you with a glance, you can never un-know it. Some adventurers prefer the thrill of discovery over the comfort of preparation. If that’s you, close this guide now and go learn things the hard way. There is real joy in that.

Looking for the manual instead? If you’re just looking for game commands, item lists, and mechanics without spoilers, you want the [Guide to the Mazes of Menace](#) instead. That’s the reference manual that comes with the game. This document is a *strategic* guide. It assumes you already know how to play and want to know how to *survive*.

But if you have perished under the deadly gaze of just one too many floating eyes, or if you are tired of the gods abandoning you to starve with no food rations on level four, read on. We will do our best to keep you alive.

Prefer to read offline? Print the book-format PDF (285pp, 5×8 trim, cover).



Before You Set Out

Choosing Your Expedition

The first decision you'll make, before you even set foot on the stairs, is who you are. In the Mazes, this means three things: your **role**, your **race**, and your **alignment**. Together, these determine your starting equipment, your natural abilities, which gods hear your prayers, and which artifacts you can safely handle.

Don't agonize over this choice too much on your first few trips. You will die regardless, and each death teaches something. But if you'd like a recommendation for a first expedition, read on.

The Roles

There are thirteen roles available to adventurers. Each comes with different starting equipment, different intrinsic abilities gained at various experience levels, and a different quest to complete in the mid-game.

Archeologist. You start with a bullwhip, a pickaxe, a tinning kit, and a touchstone. The pickaxe is the kit's workhorse: it lets you dig through walls and create your own escape routes from the very first level. The tinning kit lets you preserve corpses for later, and the touchstone is your gem-identification edge: rub a gem on it and the game tells you whether it's the real thing or worthless glass. Useful for unicorn negotiation and shop pricing. Archeologists are capable and flexible, though a bit fragile in early combat. *Alignment: Lawful or Neutral.*

Barbarian. You start strong. Literally. A two-handed sword and good starting strength mean you can hack through early monsters with ease. The downside is that two-handed weapons prevent you from using a shield, and Barbarians are not known for their finesse. You do get poison resistance from the start, which saves you from several common early deaths. A straightforward role for players who like straightforward solutions. *Alignment: Neutral or Chaotic.*

Cave Dweller. You start primitive but tough, with a club, a sling, and a pile of flint stones for it. You gain speed by mid-game and your hit dice are generous. The Cave Dweller's simplicity is a virtue: fewer tools means fewer things to manage. *Alignment: Lawful or Neutral.*

Healer. You begin with a stethoscope, four potions of healing and four of extra healing, a **wand of sleep**, three **blessed spellbooks** (healing, extra healing, stone-to-flesh, all guaranteed to read), and poison resistance. The stethoscope lets you check a monster's hit points and your own internal state; the wand of sleep makes Healers a stronger early-game combatant than the medical kit suggests. You're also **immune to sickness**, so unknown potions of sickness become a free quaff-test (dip a unicorn horn into them to convert to fruit juice). *Alignment: Neutral.*

Knight. You start mounted on a saddled pony, with a +1 long sword and a +1 lance among your gear. The pony is a decent combatant early on and the basis of your unique trick: jousting from horseback with the lance is devastating when it connects, though the lance is largely useless on foot. As a Lawful character with a starting long sword, you also have the best odds in the game at Excalibur. Dip your long sword in a fountain at experience level 5+ and Knights get a 1-in-6 chance per dip, far better than the 1-in-30 every other Lawful role faces. Knights follow a code of conduct that imposes alignment penalties for attacking fleeing or helpless monsters, so pick your fights carefully. Knights also have intrinsic jumping, which lets you reposition without spending an attack. *Alignment: Lawful.*

Monk. You fight best with bare hands and start with no weapon at all. Monks gain martial arts abilities as they level, eventually becoming formidable unarmed combatants. You start with sleep resistance and see invisible, and you should avoid eating meat if you want to maintain your spiritual discipline. One of the more unusual roles, rewarding for experienced players. *Alignment: Any.*

Priest. You start with a mace, four potions of holy water, and the ability to intuitively sense whether items are blessed, cursed, or uncursed, so you know on sight whether that cloak you just found is safe to wear. Competent fighters with access to clerical spells. Your first sacrifice gift is guaranteed: Demonbane (now a silver mace), which aligns with your weapon skill — sacrifice early and often. *Alignment: Any (matches your god).*

Ranger. You start with a bow, a generous supply of arrows, a dagger, and a **+2 cloak of displacement** — one of the strongest defensive starts in the game. You're unmatched as an early-game ranged threat. Rangers gain Searching at XL 1, Stealth at XL 7, and See Invisible at XL 15. Your elven racial option grants sleep resistance at XL 4. If you enjoy picking off enemies from a distance, this is your role. *Alignment: Neutral or Chaotic.*

Rogue. NetHack's thief class: lockpicking and stealthy assassinations. You start with a short sword, six daggers for throwing, leather armor, a lock pick, a sack, and a potion of sickness (toss it at an enemy, or save it to coat any darts, shuriken, or arrows you find — only missiles can be poisoned). Your lock pick makes every locked door, chest, and box openable from turn one. You get stealth from the beginning, which lets you walk up to sleeping enemies without waking them, and your backstab ability deals extra damage (+1 to +your level) when you hit a monster that's fleeing or helpless. *Alignment: Chaotic.*

Samurai. You start with a katana, which is one of the better one-handed weapons in the game, plus a wakizashi backup and a yumi bow with arrows. Samurai get speed early and have a strong martial kit overall. The katana's damage output carries you through the early game with ease. *Alignment: Lawful.*

Tourist. You start with a Hawaiian shirt, a credit card, an expensive camera, a truly absurd number of +2 darts, two potions of extra healing, and **four scrolls of magic mapping**. Tourists have weak combat and a fragile early game (this is the hardest of the standard roles), but the mapping scrolls take the edge off exploration and the darts train ranged skills fast. The camera blinds monsters in a pinch. A good role for players who have ascended before and want a real challenge. *Alignment: Neutral.*

Valkyrie. The standard recommendation for a first serious attempt. You start with a spear, a small shield, and cold resistance; strong combat stats and good starting equipment do the rest. **Mjollnir** (+d5/+d24 war hammer that returns when thrown at Strength 25) drops as your sacrifice gift regardless of alignment, and is what you'll wield by the late game. *Alignment: Lawful or Neutral. Female only.*

Wizard. You start with a quarterstaff, a **cloak of magic resistance** (an endgame-quality item from turn one), a wand, two rings, three potions,

three scrolls, the force-bolt spell plus a random spellbook, and a high-enchantment magic marker. Physical combat is terrible, so spells are the answer: fragile early, overwhelming late. Advancing a spell-school skill (new in 5.0) also identifies spellbooks of that school by appearance, so you get free book-ID just by casting (see Spellcasting). *Alignment: Neutral or Chaotic.*

The Races

Your race affects your starting and maximum attributes, and which intrinsics you get. All stats range from 3 and higher; the table below shows the maximum each race can reach for each attribute.

Race	Str	Int	Wis	Dex	Con	Cha	Intrinsics
Human	18/100	18	18	18	18	18	—
Elf	18	20	20	18	16	18	Infravision; sleep res at XL 4
Dwarf	18/100	16	16	20	20	16	Infravision
Gnome	18/50	19	18	18	18	18	Infravision
Orc	18/50	16	16	18	18	16	Infravision, poison res

Human. No infravision, no poison resistance, no special talents. On the bright side, every role is open to you and nobody in the dungeon singles you out for being one. Perfectly serviceable.

Dwarf. Sturdy fighters with the best Dex and Con caps and matching human Strength. Infravision (the ability to see warm-blooded creatures in the dark) from level 1. Available for: Archeologist, Cave Dweller, Valkyrie.

Elf. Infravision plus sleep resistance at XL 4. Fragile compared to humans but with the best Int and Wis caps. Elf Priests and Wizards get a free musical instrument. Available for: Priest, Ranger, Wizard.

Gnome. Small but resourceful; slightly higher Int cap than a human. Available for: Archeologist, Cave Dweller, Healer, Ranger, Wizard.

Orc. Poison resistance from level 1 is genuinely useful. Lower stat caps overall, and humans, elves, and dwarves are race-hostile to orcs (shopkeepers, priests, watchmen included); other orcs aren't automatically peaceful either. Available for: Barbarian, Ranger, Rogue, Wizard.

Alignment

Your alignment (Lawful, Neutral, or Chaotic) determines which gods you worship, which artifacts you can safely use, and how certain actions affect your standing. It's tempting to think of these as "good," "balanced," and "evil," but it's more nuanced than that.

The key thing to understand about alignment is that it's a number. Every action that matches your alignment's expectations increases it; actions that violate your alignment's code decrease it. Your alignment record affects your relationship with your god, which in turn affects whether prayer will save you or smite you.

Lawful characters should avoid attacking peaceful creatures and should never murder. Sacrifice frequently at co-aligned altars. Lawful has the advantage of access to Excalibur, a top-tier melee weapon obtainable as early as experience level 5.

Neutral characters have the most flexibility. You can get away with more than a Lawful character, but your god still frowns on truly chaotic behavior. Neutral has access to some excellent quest artifacts.

Chaotic characters can kill with relative impunity but should avoid pious behavior that doesn't match their dark patron's expectations. Chaotic is often paired with Rogue for thematic consistency.

For your first game: **Valkyrie, Human or Dwarf**. Strong combat, cold resistance, and Mjollnir waiting at the first co-aligned altar you can sacrifice on. It's the closest thing to an easy mode the Mazes offer, which is to say it's still very hard.



What to Pack

Your starting kit is fixed by your role and suited to its strengths, but you'll want to improve on it. In the early game, keep an eye out for these items as you descend. They'll shore up most roles' weaknesses.

The Early Shopping List

A source of nutrition. You will get hungry. It happens faster than you think. But your main food source isn't going to be the rations in your pack. Unless you're playing a vegetarian role, **most of your food in the early dungeon is the corpses of the things you kill.** Eat fresh kills as you go, and rations become emergency backup rather than the main course. Grab every food ration you see, sure, but two or three is plenty to carry; you don't need to hoard. Tripe rations are for your pet, not for you.

A way to identify things. In the early game, your primary identification tools are altars (drop items to see if they flash blessed/cursed), your pet (it won't step on cursed items), and experimentation. A scroll of identify is valuable, but you might not find one for a while. A touchstone (a gray stone that identifies gems) is helpful but not urgent.

Armor improvements. Whatever you're wearing, you can probably do better. Look for cloaks, helmets, gloves, and boots to fill empty equipment slots. Even basic items like a helmet or pair of gloves provide armor class benefits and can protect against specific attacks.

A ranged attack. Daggers, darts, or a bow with arrows. Fighting from range is almost always safer than melee, and some monsters (like floating eyes) should never be fought in melee.

Supply chests. Some of the large boxes and chests you find on the levels above the Oracle are special supply chests. They are usually locked but stocked with useful magical items: healing or gain-energy potions, enchant-weapon or enchant-armor scrolls, sometimes a wand of digging or a low-

level spellbook. About two-thirds of the early levels have one. Picking or **#forceing** them open is almost always worth the time.

Restraint. New adventurers pick up everything they find. Veterans pick up everything they need. The difference is about forty pounds and the ability to outrun a gnome lord. If your status line reads “Burdened,” you’re carrying more than you can use.



Your First Descent

You step down the stairs. The air is cool and damp. A corridor stretches before you, branching into darkness. Your pet trots beside you.

Welcome to the dungeon.

The first few levels of the Mazes are designed to ease you in, which is a relative term. Monsters are weaker, but you are too. Your gear is minimal, your hit points are low, and you don't yet have the resistances that make the mid-game survivable. Levels one through five are where the most characters die, not because the threats are the greatest, but because you have the fewest resources to deal with them.

The Golden Rules of Early Survival

Rule 1: Don't fight what you can't beat. This sounds obvious, but it's the single most violated principle in the Mazes. If a monster is too tough for you, walk away. Use corridors as chokepoints. Funnel enemies so you fight them one at a time. If you stumble into a room full of monsters, step back into the corridor and force them to come to you in single file.

Bad: fighting in the open	Good: corridor chokepoint
<pre> ┌·Z·Z·.....┐ ┌·Z·@·Z·Z·...┐ ┌····Z·.....┐ ┌·Z·.....┐ </pre>	<pre> ┌·Z·...Z·.....┐ ┌·Z·Z·.....┐ ┌Z·.....+##@┐ ┌·Z·.....┐ </pre>
You're surrounded.	They come to you one at a time.

Rule 2: Don't eat things you don't understand. Monster corpses can grant powerful intrinsics, or they can poison you, give you food poison-

ing, or worse. Until you know what a corpse does, leave it on the ground. (Kobold k meat, for example, is poisonous and confers nothing.) The exceptions: you can always safely eat food rations, lembas wafers, cram rations, and fruits. Lichen corpses are safe and never rot. Lizard corpses are safe, never rot, and cure petrification. Always carry one if you can.

Rule 3: Your pet is your friend. Your starting pet is more useful than it appears. It will fight alongside you, pick up items (which tells you they're not cursed, since pets avoid cursed items on the ground), and can even be trained to steal from shops. Keep it fed by dropping tripe rations or corpses near it. A healthy, well-fed pet is one of your best early assets.

Rule 4: Learn to pray. If you are about to die (hit points critically low, starving, turning to stone) you can pray to your god for help. In the early game, with decent alignment, prayer will almost certainly save you. But you can only pray about once every thousand turns or so, and praying at the wrong time (when your god is angry, when you're in Gehennom, or when you've prayed too recently) can make things much worse. Think of prayer as an emergency button with a cooldown. Don't waste it on minor problems (see Divine Relations for the full mechanics).

Rule 5: Explore thoroughly but move purposefully. Every turn you spend in the dungeon costs nutrition. If you stand around for hundreds of turns, you'll starve. But rushing past rooms means missing items you need. The sweet spot is to explore each level fairly completely (check rooms, open doors, look for hidden passages) but don't grind. When you've found what the level has to offer, move on.

Rule 6: Build your defenses. In the first half of the game, your real goal isn't accumulating treasure. It's acquiring the resistances and protections that will help you survive the late game. The three most important are **magic resistance**, **reflection**, and **poison resistance** (plus a **lizard corpse** in your pack for petrification emergencies). Poison resistance can be acquired as an *intrinsic* by eating the right corpse, like a killer bee, a cave spider, a yellow mold, or a black pudding kicked from a sink. Magic resistance and reflection come from gear: dragon scale mail (gray for MR, silver for reflection), an amulet of reflection, or an artifact granted by your god, won on the Quest, or bestowed by a wish.

Things That Kill You (And How Not to Let Them)

Here's a short list of common early deaths and how to prevent them:

Starvation. Eat when you're Hungry (the status message), not when you're Weak or Fainting. If you're Fainting, pray immediately. Pick up every food ration you find.

Floating eyes. They're the e on the map. Small, blue, and seemingly harmless. If you hit one in melee, you'll be paralyzed, and every monster in the vicinity will take free shots at your frozen body. Use ranged attacks, or just walk around them. They are very slow.

Rotted corpses. If you eat a corpse that's been on the ground too long, you'll get food poisoning, which is lethal without treatment. Eat corpses fresh — within about 30 turns of the kill for a guaranteed-safe meal. Past that, the rot roll turns random; past ~175 turns an uncursed corpse is certainly tainted. If you do get food poisoning, pray immediately.

Falling down stairs while overburdened. If you're carrying too much, taking the stairs can make you tumble for 1–3 HP. Annoying rather than dangerous, but a habit worth avoiding: drop items before descending or manage your inventory.

Killer bees. They come in swarms, they're fast, and in the early game, a group of them can overwhelm you. If you see one bee, expect more. Use a corridor to fight them one at a time.

Your own pet. If your pet is between you and a narrow corridor, you might accidentally swap places with it repeatedly instead of moving. Worse, if you attack it (because you got confused or forgot it was there), you lose alignment and trust. Be aware of where your pet is.

Supply Containers

New in NetHack 5.0: somebody has been leaving care packages.

Every level above the Oracle has a 2/3 chance of hosting a “supply chest”: usually a chest (sometimes a large box), usually locked, seeded with at least one survivability item. The contents pool: potion of healing (about a 50%

chance per chest, sometimes a pair), or otherwise potion of extra healing / speed / gain energy, scroll of enchant weapon, enchant armor, confuse monster, or scare monster, wand of digging, or spellbook of healing. There's also a 2/3 chance of an extra random item, biased toward low-level spellbooks. The Mines branch level gets a different gift: a guaranteed food ration, cram ration, or lembas wafer.

These look like ordinary containers, no special marking. On your first ten levels, check every chest and large box you find. A locked one will yield to a credit card, a key, a wand of opening, or you can **#force** the issue with a weapon you don't mind breaking. An orcish dagger off the first orc you kill is a perfect tool (pet-test it first: could be cursed). The contents aren't guaranteed to change your run, but finding a stack of healing potions on level 4 before you've learned the hard way how much you need them is the dungeon's act of goodwill.



Dungeon Sights

The Lay of the Land

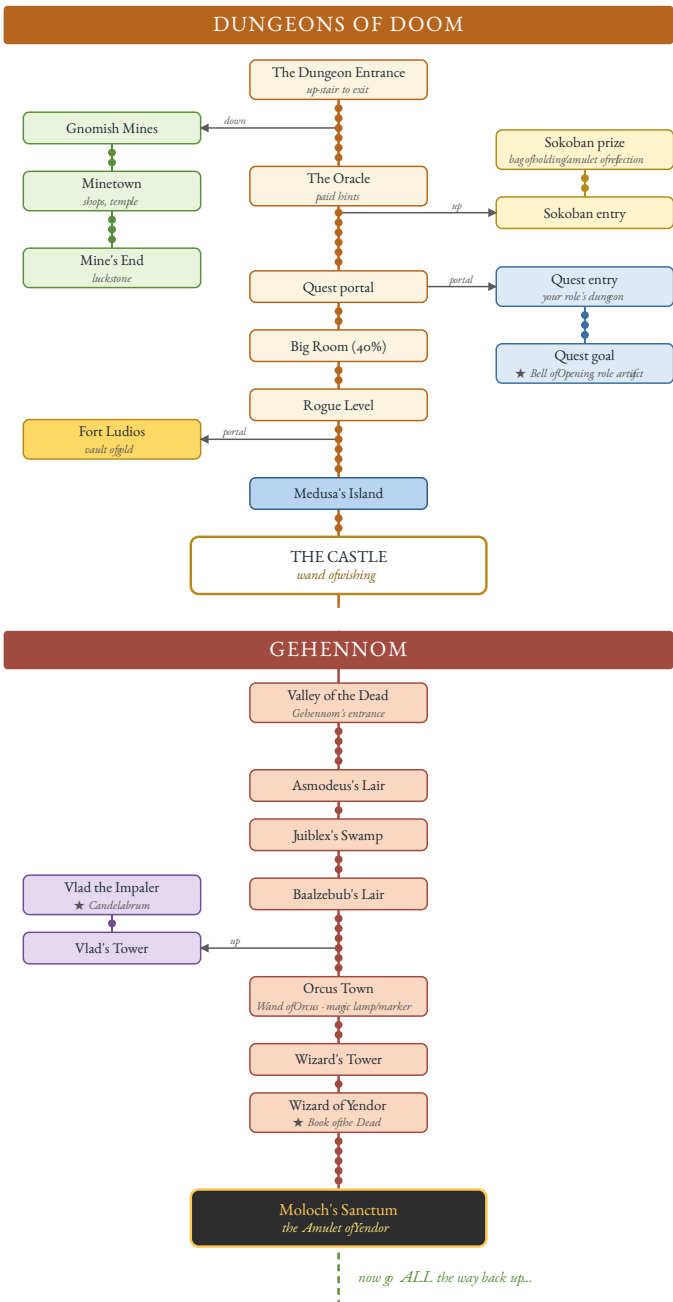
The Mazes are procedurally generated. No two visits are quite the same. But the dungeon follows patterns, and understanding those patterns is the first step toward navigating them effectively.

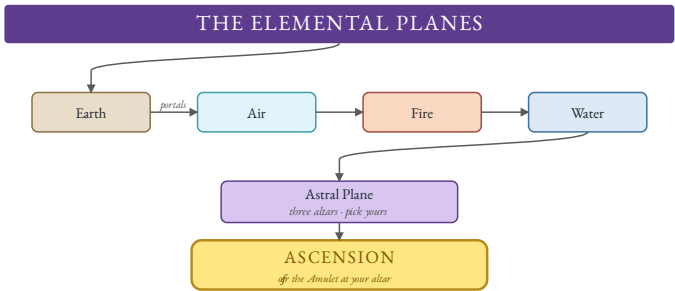
The Big Picture

Before we talk about what the symbols mean, here's the overall shape of the place. The dungeon is a branching tree with a main trunk (the Dungeons of Doom) and several side branches. The diagram nearby shows the full layout. Knowing where you are in this tree helps you plan your route and know what's coming.

The **Dungeons of Doom** form the upper half, roughly levels 1 through 27. Along the way you'll find branches leading to the **Gnomish Mines** (luckstone, shops), **Sokoban** (a prize at the top), your **Quest** (your role's special dungeon), and optionally **Fort Ludios** (a vault full of gold). The main trunk ends at **The Castle**, which guards the entrance to Gehennom.

Gehennom is the lower half: maze levels, demon lords, and the ultimate objective: the **Amulet of Yendor** at the very bottom in Moloch's Sanctum. Once you have it, you climb all the way back up and pass through the **Elemental Planes** to reach the **Astral Plane**, where your god awaits your offering.





Dungeons of Doom, Gehennom, and the Elemental Planes. Branches extend left and right of the main trunk. Pearls (small colored dots) indicate the approximate number of intervening dungeon levels. ★ marks the three Invocation items (Bell of Opening, Candelabrum, Book of the Dead) needed to enter Moloch’s Sanctum and claim the Amulet.

The typical trip: go down through the Dungeons, detour into the Mines for a luckstone and Minetown’s shops, clear Sokoban for a prize, do your Quest, reach the Castle, descend through Gehennom to get the Amulet, then climb all the way back up and through the Planes. Simple enough on paper. Surviving it is another matter.

The Map Symbols

Everything in the dungeon is represented by a symbol on the screen. Learning to read these symbols quickly is important:

Symbol	Meaning
.	Floor (room)
#	Corridor
-	Wall (horizontal, vertical)
+	Closed door (or spellbook)
<	Stairs up
>	Stairs down
{	Fountain (bright blue) or sink (white)
-	Altar
\	Throne
^	Trap (once revealed)
@	You (or a human-type monster)

Letters represent monsters: d for dogs, D for dragons, Z for zombies. Colors help distinguish within a class: a red D is a red dragon, while a gray D is a gray dragon (see Field Guide to Dungeon Fauna).

Color memo: branch staircases turn yellow. Staircases that lead into a sub-branch (Mines, Sokoban, the Quest, and so on) display in yellow once you’ve used them. Ordinary main-trunk stairs stay default-colored, so on a level with several stairs the yellow one is your way back into the branch.

Item symbols are punctuation marks:

Symbol	Item Class
)	Weapons
[	Armor
%	Food (comestibles)
!	Potions
?	Scrolls
/	Wands
=	Rings
"	Amulets
(	Tools
+	Spellbooks
*	Gems and stones
\$	Gold (zorkmids, abbreviated zm)

Room Types

Most rooms in the dungeon are ordinary, empty or with a few items and monsters scattered about. But some rooms are special:

A shop:

..[.?.!.

...@...

!..) ./.

#

@ = shopkeeper
Items for sale.

A zoo:

Z..Z\$Z..

\$Z...\$Z.

.Z\$Z..Z\$

#

Z = sleeping
\$ = gold piles

A throne room:

..Z.Z.Z.

.Z.\...Z.

..Z.Z...

#

\ = throne
Monsters guard.

Shops. Identified by the shopkeeper standing in the doorway (or inside). Shops sell items of a particular type: general stores, armor shops, weapon shops, scroll shops, potion shops, and more. Items on the shop floor belong to the shopkeeper; pick one up and you'll be quoted a price. You can sell items too. Shopkeepers are extremely powerful in combat, so don't steal unless you have a plan.

Temples. A room with an altar and a priest or priestess tending it. The altar's alignment matters: if it matches yours, you can sacrifice here for good effects. If it doesn't, the resident priest won't be friendly about your attempts. The priest will also accept gold donations in exchange for clairvoyance or a permanent AC bonus — see Donating to Priests.

Throne rooms. A room with a throne (\) and usually surrounded by monsters. Sitting on the throne has random effects, sometimes wonderful, sometimes terrible. See Points of Interest.

Zoos. A room packed with sleeping monsters and gold. They wake not from opening the door (which is silent) but from the noise of you fighting the first few. Fight from the doorway so they wake and approach one or two at a time, not all at once.

Barracks. A room full of soldiers. They're organized and armed, but they're also carrying good equipment. Worth clearing if you can handle the fight.

Beehives. A room full of killer bees and royal jelly. The bees are dangerous in numbers, but royal jelly is excellent food.

Themed rooms. New in 5.0 and the most visible change to ordinary level generation: scattered through the Dungeons of Doom, you'll occasionally walk into rooms that aren't shops, aren't zoos, and aren't anything else from the list above, but are also clearly not random. They're called **themed rooms**, and there are dozens of them. Some have unusual *shapes* (L-shaped, T-shaped, S-shaped, circular, cross-shaped, four-leaf-clover-shaped, with pillars, with a room-inside-a-room). Some have unusual *contents* (a buried-treasure cache; a buried-zombies field that wakes up when disturbed; a small massacre of statues and old corpses; a mausoleum; a trap room seeded with one kind of trap; a separate teleportation hub of fixed-destination teleporters; an empty room shaped like the Oracle's chamber; a garden; a spider nest; an ice room; a cloud room; a boulder room).

The interesting ones for the player:

- **Light source rooms.** They reliably contain a lit oil lamp. Free torch.
- **Buried treasure.** The floor needs digging, but the haul is real. A pickaxe earns its weight here.
- **Massacre.** Floor strewn with adventurer-role corpses (rogue, ranger, valkyrie, etc.). Useful for sacrifice and for eating the safe ones for intrinsics if you know the role.
- **Mausoleum.** A small interior chamber with one waiting monster (mummy, vampire, lich, or zombie) or a human corpse. Open the door carefully.
- **Spider nest, buried zombies, trap room, teleportation hub.** These are traps in everything but name. Spider nest and buried zombies scale with level difficulty, so what looks innocuous on Dlvl 4 is rough on Dlvl 18. Trap rooms can be anything from arrow traps to anti-magic to land mines; recognize the pattern, retreat, prepare, return.
- **Light-and-frame rooms (pillars, room-in-a-room, blocked center).** Tactically excellent for setting up Elbereth squares or anchoring a polearm fight.

Themed rooms are mixed in with ordinary rooms; you can have several on a single level. They make the early dungeon less predictable in a friendly way: more terrain types to fight in, more item discovery, and the occasional educational ambush.

A room full of one kind of monster is almost certainly a themed room, not a coincidence. Themed rooms have above-average monster density concentrated around a single type, so any room that looks curated deserves more respect than a random room of equivalent apparent difficulty. Retreat, assess, and enter with a plan rather than a direction.



Field Guide to Dungeon Fauna

The Mazes are home to hundreds of monster species, organized into classes denoted by letters. Lowercase letters are generally smaller or less dangerous; uppercase letters are larger or more threatening. Color further distinguishes individual species within a class.

Here is a quick field guide to what each letter means, roughly ordered by how early you might encounter them. For the full level / speed / AC / attack details on every monster, see the Bestiary Tables appendix.

Common Early Encounters

Sym	Class	Notes
a	Ants	Soldier ants are a frequent early-game killer: speed 18, two attacks per turn (bite + strength-draining sting), and they travel in packs. A wandering soldier-ant group on Dlvl 4 can end a careless run. Killer bees, giant ants, fire ants are all the same shape of problem.
b	Blobs	Acidic or gelatinous. Acid blobs have no active attack — they only splash 1d8 acid back when <i>you</i> hit <i>them</i> , and the splash can corrode your weapon. Kill at range, or walk past.
B	Bats	The B class is deceptively dangerous because of speed . Bats and giant bats clock in at speed 22 — nearly twice the player's base 12, so they get roughly two bites per one of your swings. Giant bats bite for 1d6 each; the math catches up fast. Vampire bats are still in the bat class but their second bite drains Strength (not levels).
d	Dogs and other canines	The d class covers your starting pet (little dog, kitten via cat-class) and the most numerous early-game predators. Jackals are the single most common cause of death on the public server — they only bite for 1d2, but they spawn in packs and there are a <i>lot</i> of them on the upper levels. Foxes bite for 1d3 and are faster (speed 15) but spawn alone. Coyotes, dingos, wolves get progressively worse. Tame d (your pet, larger dogs you've fed up) help fight everything else.

Sym	Class	Notes
e	Eyes	Floating eyes paralyze on melee hit. Never hit an e in melee. Use ranged attacks. Spheres (flaming/freezing/shocking) explode in a 3×3 area; also kill them at range.
f	Cats	Like dogs, often starting pets. Felines can be tamed with tripe.
G	Gnomes	The standard inhabitants of the Gnomish Mines. Individually weak, but the Mines have a lot of them — and plain gnomes, gnome lords, and (later) gnome rulers are all in the top fifteen causes of death on the public server, because mid-game players treat the Mines as a milk run and walk into a four-on-one with full-strength enemies. If you're a gnome yourself, most of them are peaceful.
h	Humanoids	Dwarves, bugbears, mind flayers. Wide range of difficulty. Dwarves in particular are dangerously underrated: they hit harder than they look, they're armored, and they're the second most common cause of death on the public server because of how many you meet in the Mines. Don't trade blows with one in melee until your AC is solid.
i	Imps	Minor pests. Weak claw, regeneration, and a stream of insults — annoying but not dangerous.
j	Jellies	Spotted and ochre jellies. Passive acid damage on melee.
k	Kobolds	Weak individually but sometimes carry poisoned weapons.
o	Orcs	Numerous and modest in strength one-on-one; dangerous in packs. Hill orcs and Mordor orcs are the common upper-dungeon variants.
r	Rodents	Rats and rock moles. Rock moles eat metal items, so protect your gear.
s	Spiders	Cave spiders are weak. Giant spiders poison.
x	Grid bugs	The weakest monster in the game; they can't even move diagonally. Free XP — they don't leave corpses. The x class also covers the much-later xan , whose sting cripples your legs (slow movement until it heals).
:	Lizards	Newts, geckos, and iguanas are individually weak — usually not too dangerous if you're paying attention. The class matters mostly for the corpses: lizard corpses cure petrification (always carry one for cockatrice/Medusa insurance), and newt corpses may restore 1–3 mana to spellcasters.

Mid-Dungeon Threats

Sym	Class	Notes
A	Angels	Powerful, usually aligned. Don't fight your own.
C	Centaurs	Fast (speed 18-20). Half spawn with a bow or crossbow, but they'll still close into melee for weapon and kick attacks. Mountain centaurs hit hardest: 1d10 weapon plus <i>two</i> 1d6 kicks per turn.
E	Elementals	Hard to kill. Air elementals engulf; earth elementals phase through walls.
f	Displacer beast	Cat-class, but vicious: AC –10, three-attack melee, and a 50% chance on each player melee to swap places with you instead. Eat the corpse for temporary intrinsic Displacement.
F	Fungi	Yellow mold, green mold, shriekers. Shriekers summon other monsters.
G	Gnome lords/kings	Tougher gnomes. Still fairly manageable.
'	Golems	Built things. Iron golems hit hard and resist nearly everything; clay, stone, and wood golems are softer. Glass golems leave gems on death.
H	Giants	Strong melee, throw boulders. Giants carry gems.
J	Jabberwock	Rare, but if you see one you're in for a fight. Four 2d10 attacks per turn (two bites and two claws) at normal speed.
K	Keystone Kops	The shopkeeper-summoned constabulary. They appear when you steal, refuse to pay, or anger a shopkeeper. Individually weak but they swarm, and they jeer at you.
l	Leprechauns	Steal your gold and teleport away. A single claw can grab up to <i>all</i> of your purse. Hide gold in a sack, drop it elsewhere, or fight at range.
L	Liches	Spellcasters. Arch-liches are among the most dangerous monsters in the game.
m	Mimics	Disguised as items, walls, doors, fountains, altars, or boulders. See the mimics note below.
M	Mummies	Aggressive undead with physical claw attacks. Their corpses are dangerous to eat (age you). Mummy wrappings worn as a cloak block invisibility — usually a downside, but useful if you've gone invisible and need a shopkeeper to interact with you.
n	Nymphs	Steal items from your inventory, then teleport away. Fight from range.

Sym	Class	Notes
N	Nagas	Large serpent-bodied creatures. Red nagas breathe fire, black nagas spit acid, golden nagas cast spells, guardian nagas spit Str-drain poison and have a paralyzing bite. Tough; speeds 12–16.
O	Ogres	Strong melee fighters. Ogre lords and kings are tougher.
p	Piercers	Disguise as stalactites; drop from the ceiling onto whatever walks below. The fall does serious damage. Hard to spot in advance.
P	Puddings	Black AND brown puddings split when hit in melee with an iron or metal weapon (scalpel and tsurugi count). Use a silver or wooden weapon, or spells.
q	Quadrupeds	Multi-attack mid-game bruisers. The rothe is the famous one (three attacks per turn at sluggish speed 9, dangerous in packs); mumakil are solo two-attack bruisers (4d12 butt + 2d6 bite).
R	Rust monster / disenchanter	Rust monsters corrode worn iron armor when they hit you, and your wielded iron weapon when you hit them. Use non-iron alternatives (mithril, silver, dragonhide) or take iron gear off before the fight; iron items kept in your inventory aren't touched. Disenchancers drain enchantment on hit and have their own write-up under Ways to Die.
S	Snakes	Cobras and pit vipers poison. Water moccasins come from fountains.
t	Trappers / lurkers above	Hide in plain sight on floor or ceiling and engulf you when you walk under/onto them. See the engulfment write-up under Ways to Die.
T	Trolls	Regenerate. They come back from the dead unless you eat or tin the corpse.
u	Horses / unicorns	Horses are usually mountable, mostly peaceful in the wild. Unicorns are color-coded by alignment: same-aligned spawn peaceful, cross-aligned hostile. The gem-throwing negotiation playbook is in Luck and Fortune.
U	Umber hulk	Confuses on sight. Avoid looking at them directly.
v	Vortices	Engulfing wisps. Air, fire, ice, and steam vortices each apply their element to whatever they engulf. Kill at range.
w	Worms	Long worms grow tail segments as they move and can be a corridor in themselves. Purple worms swallow you whole (see Things You Don't Want to Meet, below).
W	Wraiths	Drain levels on hit. But their corpses grant a level, so eat them fresh.
y	Yellow/black lights	Explode adjacent. Yellow blinds you; black hallucinates you. Black lights are invisible without <i>see invisible</i> . Kill at range.
Y	Yetis	Tough melee combatants. Corpses may grant cold resistance.

Sym	Class	Notes
z	Zruty	Three-attack mid-game brute. Uncommon but a fair fight if you've geared up.
Z	Zombies	Slow, numerous, come in many varieties. Zombie corpses are old and will rot.

Things You Don't Want to Meet

Sym	Class	Notes
c	Cockatrices	Touch = instant petrification. Never hit one barehanded. Wield their corpse with gloves as a weapon.
D	Dragons	Each color has its own breath weapon, resistance, and scale mail property. See note below.
h	Mind flayers	Drain intelligence on hit. If Int hits your racial minimum (3 for humans), you die. Keep distance or kill fast.
v	Vampires	Drain levels. Vampire lords fly and are fast.
w	Purple worms	The big worm: swallows you whole on a hit, then digests. Cut your way out from inside.
x	Xorn	Phases through walls and floors. Three claws and a bite per turn; hard to ambush and hard to escape from.
;	Sea monsters	Drowning is an instadeath. Don't fight in water without a plan.
&	Demons	Major demons (Orcus, Demogorgon, Asmodeus) are boss-level threats.
@	Humans (hostile)	Includes the Wizard of Yendor, who is the most persistent nuisance in the game.
Q	Quantum mechanics / genetic engineers	Quantum mechanics teleport their target on a hit; genetic engineers (new in 5.0) polymorph their target. The Q class is rare but every one of them is a surprise. See The Genetic Engineer for more information.

Special Symbols

A few map glyphs aren't monsters in the conventional sense, but you'll see them and need to know what they mean.

Sym	What it is	Notes
I	Invisible monster marker	The game remembers the last spot you sensed something you couldn't see. The I stays there until you bump it or step on the square; the monster has usually moved.
~	Long worm tail segment	Part of a long worm's body. Hitting the tail damages the worm and shortens the chain; hitting the head (the w) is full melee.
]	Strange object	Always a mimic. No ordinary item ever displays as] (compare [, armor —] is its mirror). See the mimics note below.
␣(space)	Ghost	Ghosts left from bones files. The glyph is a literal space, which paints over the floor underneath: in a room, a ghost shows as a one-square <i>gap</i> in the floor where a . should be. Walk into the gap to identify it.



Points of Interest

Not everything interesting in the dungeon is trying to kill you. Scattered throughout the levels are fixtures that reward the curious, and occasionally punish them. Learning what to do (and what *not* to do) with each of these is a rite of passage.

Fountains {

Ah, fountains. That gentle bubbling sound has lured more adventurers to their doom than any trap. Every experienced player has a fountain story: the time they summoned a water demon on dungeon level 3, the time they quaffed and got a wish, the time snakes poured out of the basin.

Quaffing from a fountain is a slot machine with these reels:

Outcome	Effect
Water demon	A water demon appears, hostile
Healing	You regain hit points
Attribute boost	A random attribute increases
Attribute loss	A random attribute decreases
Water moccasin	Snakes appear
See invisible	You gain the ability to see invisible creatures
Nothing	"The water is cool and refreshing"

Most of the time, nothing happens. Sometimes something wonderful happens. And sometimes a water demon appears and reminds you that curiosity has a body count. Demons appear about 1 quaff in 30; on shallow levels they may grant you a wish before leaving, working out to roughly 1 wish per 150 quaffs. Past Dlvl 20 the wish odds drop to zero — only the hostility remains.

Dipping in a fountain is a different gamble, and one that Lawful characters should know by heart. If you're at least experience level 5, dipping

a long sword may transform it into Excalibur, one of the finest weapons in the dungeon. Knights get a generous 1/6 chance per dip; everyone else gets a meager 1/30. Otherwise, dipping can rust your gear, summon hostile water creatures, or occasionally uncurse the dipped item.

The conventional wisdom: if you're a lawful Knight carrying a long sword, dip in every fountain you see until Excalibur appears. Other lawful characters should try too, but pack patience. And if you're not lawful? Walk past the fountain. It has nothing for you but wet boots and regret.

Altars _

If fountains are slot machines, altars are the single most useful piece of furniture in the dungeon. Treat every altar like the treasure it is.

Dropping items on an altar reveals their BUC status instantly: - **Amber flash** → blessed - **Black flash** → cursed - No flash → uncursed

This is free, unlimited, and works on everything. In the early game, your first altar becomes your testing laboratory: haul every suspicious piece of gear there before putting it on. Many promising ascensions have been saved by the simple discipline of altar-testing before wearing.

Sacrificing monster corpses on an altar deepens your relationship with your god. The corpse must be fresh (stale sacrifices are an insult) and the bigger the monster, the more your god is impressed. Sacrifice enough and your deity may reward you with an artifact weapon aligned to your cause. See Divine Relations for the full theology.

Converting an altar to your alignment is possible by sacrificing ordinary monster corpses on a cross-aligned altar. Each attempt has a chance of flipping the altar to your god, a chance of doing nothing, and a chance of back-firing (the wrong god notices and punishes you, or worse, *you* get converted). It's a real gamble, but worth it when the dungeon gives you an altar to the wrong god and you need a co-aligned one for sacrifice and holy water. See Altars and Alignment for the gotchas (same-race sacrifice, unicorns).

Thrones \

Sitting on a throne is the purest gamble in NetHack. The list of possible outcomes reads like a wish list shuffled with a hit list:

- A wish (if your luck is positive)
- Genocide of a monster class
- Free identification of one to four items in your pack — or, one time in five, your entire inventory
- A stat boost or a stat drain
- An electric shock
- Full healing
- A crowd of hostile monsters, summoned for your amusement
- Confusion
- A curse on one of your items
- Magic mapping of the level
- See invisible
- All your gold, vanished

About one time in three, something happens, but you won't know which column of the ledger it's going to hit. Sit on a throne when you're strong enough to survive the worst row of that table, and ideally when your luck is positive (for a shot at the wish). Even when nothing happens, the throne may vanish in a puff of logic, so you might get several tries or none at all. (Vlad's throne in the Tower is special: it never vanishes without granting a wish first.)

Sinks {

Sinks are the dungeon’s most underrated identification tool.

Kicking a sink can shake loose a ring (useful!), summon a black pudding (terrifying, but its glob is a triple-resistance snack), summon an *amorous demon* posing as “the dishwasher” (the same incubus/succubus as a seduction encounter — careful!), or just stub your toe. Each non-stub outcome fires at most once per sink. Worth a kick in the early game if you can handle what comes out.

Pouring potions down a sink (by dipping) produces telltale effects — a clever way to narrow down potion identities without risking a sip. Five potions print unique sink-only messages:

Sink message	Potion
<i>“The sink transforms into a fountain/throne/altar/grave!”</i> (or <i>“The sink vanishes.”</i>)	polymorph
<i>“Muddy waste pops up from the drain...”</i> (first time per sink also drops a ring)	levitation
<i>“It leaves an oily film on the basin.”</i>	oil
<i>“The drain seems less clogged.”</i> (blind: <i>“a sucking sound”</i>)	acid
<i>“You sense a ring lost down the drain.”</i> (once per sink)	object detection

For most other potions, the sink instead prints *“A wisp of vapor rises up...”* and then applies the same vapor effect as breathing a broken potion: the side effect normally identifies the potion (sleeping makes you yawn, hallucination starts hallucinating, blindness blinds briefly, healing nudges HP, and so on). Wasted on water, fruit juice, gain level, gain energy, and monster detection: those all just print *“nothing seems to happen.”*

Quaffing from a sink rolls one of 20 random effects. Mostly nothing useful (mild flavor messages, summoned sewer rat, vomit, scalding water), but three outcomes are worth the occasional risk: ~5% chance to gain an experience level outright, ~5% chance to find a ring at your feet (once per sink), and ~5% chance to drink a random unidentified potion. Worth a quaff or two from any sink you encounter, but keep HP and an escape plan in reserve: it could summon a water elemental, or it could polymorph you.

Dropping a ring down a sink produces a message unique to the ring type — the most reliable non-magical way to identify rings. **Most rings are consumed**, but two come back after IDing themselves for free:

Message	Ring	Ring kept?
<i>"You thought your ring got lost in the sink, but there it is!"</i>	searching	yes
<i>"The ring is regurgitated!"</i>	slow digestion	yes
<i>"The sink quivers upward for a moment."</i>	levitation	no
<i>"You smell rotten slime molds."</i> (or your custom fruit)	poison resistance	no
<i>"Several flies buzz angrily around the sink."</i>	aggravate monster	no
<i>"Static electricity surrounds the sink."</i>	shock resistance	no
<i>"You hear loud noises coming from the drain."</i>	conflict	no
<i>"The water flow seems fixed."</i>	sustain ability	no
<i>"The water flow seems stronger/weaker now."</i>	gain strength	no
<i>"The water flow seems greater/lesser now."</i>	gain constitution	no
<i>"The water flow hits/misses the drain."</i>	increase accuracy	no
<i>"The water's force seems greater/smaller now."</i>	increase damage	no
<i>"Suddenly, [items] vanish from the sink!"</i> any other items on the sink square vanish too	hunger	no
<i>"The sink momentarily vanishes."</i> sink moves to a new spot	teleportation	no
<i>"The sink transforms into a fountain/throne/altar/grave!"</i> (or rarely <i>"The sink vanishes."</i> if grave generation fails)	polymorph	no

Vaults

A vault is a tiny walled-off 2×2 room not connected to the rest of the level. Each one holds a pile of gold. You'll usually find one by digging through stone or by teleporting in. The engraving "*ad aerarium*" on a level marks one nearby (see Engravings).

After about thirty turns inside, a guard appears at the doorway and asks "*Who are you?*" The trick: answer *Croesus* (also accepted as *Kroisos* or *Creosote*). The guard takes that as the name of the vault's owner and politely leaves, gold untouched. If you give your real name, the guard escorts you out the long way and the gold goes with him. If you're Lawful, lying costs you one alignment.

If Croesus himself is dead (you killed him at Fort Ludios), claiming his name angers the guard. Use the real-name route then.



Branches and Landmarks

A practical tour of the branches and landmarks, in roughly the order you'll visit them.

Sokoban or Mines first? The Mines entrance shows up first (Dlvl 2 to 4), but the *strategic* suggestion for most beginners is Sokoban. It's a controlled puzzle crawl with mostly trivial monsters, and the prize at the top (reflection or a bag of holding) materially helps the Mines run afterward. Go Mines-first if you specifically want the luckstone at Mine's End early, or if a gnomish race makes most Mines residents peaceful to you.

The Gnomish Mines

The entrance appears somewhere around dungeon levels 2 through 4, as a downward staircase. You'll know you're in the Mines because the walls become rough stone and the corridors get irregular.

The Mines are populated primarily by gnomes, dwarves, and the occasional dwarf lord. If you're playing a gnomish character, most of them will be peaceful, which makes the Mines a relatively comfortable detour. Everyone else will need to fight through a modest but steady stream of hostile gnomes.

Minetown appears a few levels into the Mines. Usually it's a small settlement with shops and a temple, and it's worth visiting early. The shops let you sell unwanted items for gold and buy useful gear. The temple has an altar (check the alignment) and a resident priest. If the altar matches your alignment, you've found a safe place to identify items by dropping them on it. The Minetown priest is also the cheapest source of intrinsic AC bonuses in the game — donating 500 zorkmids at low XL stacks each visit (see Donating to Priests).

Candles spawn often enough that you'll usually have enough by endgame, but you do need to source seven for the Candelabrum of Invocation later.

Izchak's lighting store in Minetown is the clean answer: buy seven there.

If the shop is absent (Orcish Town layout), seven are scattered on that level instead. Wax candles burn longer than tallow but either works, and mixing types is fine.

One in seven times, however, Minetown generates as **Orcish Town**: an overrun settlement with no shops, no priest, and iron bars blocking the entrances. There's still an unaligned altar, but you won't get any shopping done. If you were counting on Minetown for early commerce, this is a rude surprise.

Watch out for the Minetown watch. The guards are peaceful unless you steal from a shop or attack a peaceful creature. If you anger them, they'll call for reinforcements.

Mine's End is the bottom of the Mines. All three Mine's End variants contain a guaranteed (not-cursed) luckstone, so you'll get one wherever you arrive. A luckstone in your open inventory prevents your luck from timing out toward zero, which affects everything from combat to fountain wishes. Grab it and carry it for the rest of the game. (One layout variant also seeds a **fake luckstone mimic** disguised as a luckstone — BUC-test what you pick up before relying on it.)

Sokoban

The entrance staircase appears somewhere around dungeon levels 6 through 10 (one level below the Oracle), and it goes up. Sokoban is a set of four puzzle levels where you push boulders onto holes or into place to open a path. Teleport doesn't work here, and you can't dig down off the entrance level (its floor is reinforced).

The puzzles are fixed (two variants per level, randomly chosen).

Each level has exactly one correct solution. If you push a boulder into a corner where it blocks your progress there is no way to start over. You're left with a few ways to cheat, which might or might not help: **squeeze past** the boulder (drop your stuff to fit), **dig the boulder** with a wielded pick-axe or mattock, or **fracture it** with a wand of striking or a scroll of earth (or polymorph the boulder into something else). Each of these costs a point of Luck and breaks the Sokoban conduct. The walls themselves are non-diggable on every Sokoban level, and pit traps are inescapable — even flying or levitation

won't carry you over an open pit, the air currents pull you down anyway. **Teleport doesn't work here:** the level forbids it.

The prize at the top is either a **bag of holding** or an **amulet of reflection**, both extremely valuable; the Sokoban Solutions appendix documents the per-variant 75/25 weighting. A cursed scroll of scare monster is placed under the prize as bait. A bag of holding lets you carry far more inventory at reduced weight. An amulet of reflection bounces ray attacks back at their casters. Either one is worth the detour.

One important rule: the Sokoban levels penalize you for “cheating.” Breaking or polymorphing boulders, reading scrolls of earth, or squeezing past boulders costs you a point of luck each time. Solve each level honestly if you can.

Strength training side effect. Every legitimate boulder-push exercises Strength. Sokoban is the safest place to grind Str up since the puzzles require dozens of pushes without putting you in combat. Don't try to train Str by walking around Stressed in the rest of the dungeon: the HP penalty isn't worth what you'd gain.

For complete solutions to all eight level variants, see Sokoban Solutions in the appendices.

The Oracle

Somewhere in the mid-levels of the Dungeons of Doom (around levels 5 through 9), you'll find a special room containing the Oracle of Delphi, flanked by centaur statues and four fountains.

The Oracle offers two services:

- **Minor consultations** are cheap (50 zorkmids) and produce fortune-cookie-style messages, drawn from the same true-rumor pool, mostly atmospheric, occasionally useful.
- **Major consultations** are expensive ($500 + 50 \times \text{experience level}$) but pay back the gold in useful intel: hints about monsters, items, and game mechanics.

The Oracle is peaceful and never attacks. Her room is a safe place to rest for a moment, though the fountains are subject to the usual fountain risks.

The Quest

Around dungeon levels 11 through 16, a magic portal drops you onto your Quest. You'll need experience level 14 and a friendly word with your quest leader on the first floor before they'll let you descend. The leader sends you to retrieve your role's quest artifact from a quest nemesis.

Each role has a unique Quest with unique maps, a unique nemesis, and a unique artifact reward. The Valkyrie hunts Lord Surtur for the Orb of Fate. A Samurai's path ends in a duel with Ashikaga Takauji over the Tsurugi of Muramasa. The Wizard descends into the Dark One's stronghold for the Eye of the Aethiopica. The Artifacts chapter has the full per-role list.

Quest artifacts are powerful. Each grants a unique mix of carried or worn intrinsics: protection, luck, ESP, warning, reflection, or stealth depending on role. A few grant magic resistance just by being carried; a few others block magic attacks only when wielded or worn. The Artifacts chapter has the per-role list. Getting your quest artifact is a pivotal moment. The late game starts here.

Two prizes wait on the nemesis's square. The **Bell of Opening** rides in the nemesis's pack and falls when you kill them (one of the three invocation items you'll need for Gehennom). Your role's quest artifact has been sitting under their feet the whole time, placed when the level was generated. Pick both up. The Quest is the only place in the game you can get them.

Most nemeses carry an amulet of life saving, so expect to kill them twice. The portal back is on the first Quest level only. If you descend underprepared you may have a long climb home.

If your alignment record is too low, your quest leader will refuse to send you. Attacking peacefuls is the usual cause. Keep your hands clean.

The Rogue Level

Somewhere in the middle dungeon you'll cross a one-level historical district. "*You enter what seems to be an older, more primitive world.*" The neighborhood is preserved as it was when **Rogue** was the only dungeon-crawl anyone had heard of, and a few details give the era away:

- All the wildlife is in capital letters — lowercase species hadn't been invented yet.
- Armor displays as], food as :, amulets as ,, and gold shares a symbol with gems (in Rogue they were the same thing).
- Doors don't close. Hinges came later.
- Tile mode switches off in favor of plain ASCII characters.
- No fountains, sinks, altars, shopkeepers, or priests — and no spellbooks, tools, or amulets in the natural item pool, all post-Rogue inventions.

Modern mechanics still work; you can engrave Elbereth here even though that was a Hack-era addition. A small and forgivable anachronism.

Fort Ludios

Fort Ludios is optional and easy to miss entirely. It appears as a magic portal anywhere from Dlvl 11 down to just above Medusa, always inside a sealed vault, so you'll need to dig in. The portal leads to a fortified military compound: sixteen soldiers and a lieutenant, with more drifting out of the barracks once the alarm trips. Four guard dragons. A stone giant. Four giant eels patrolling the moat. And **Croesus** on the throne, the vault guardian himself. The level is non-diggable. The level prevents teleportation, so once you're inside the only way out is back through the portal or a scroll of *level* teleportation (a plain scroll of teleportation won't work here). Croesus hits hard in melee, so shoot or zap him from across the moat rather than walking up.

The real prize is the gold. A 60-square treasury holds 36k to 54k gold, with land mines and spiked pits on roughly a third of the tiles. Gem caches in each corner tower (diamonds, emeralds, rubies, amethysts), plus the occasional chest in the barracks. Soldiers carry rations and serviceable weapons. The alarm only quiets once Croesus is dead. Fort Ludios is a good place to

visit for gold, identification scrolls, or shop stock, but it's not essential for victory.

If you can't find the portal, don't worry about it. Fort Ludios is a bonus, not a requirement.

Medusa's Island

Medusa's level sits near the bottom of the Dungeons of Doom, around level 25. You'll know it by the large body of water and the statues scattered around (those used to be adventurers).

The level has three challenges stacked together:

1. **Crossing the water.** The island is surrounded by water. You'll need levitation, water walking boots, or some creative approach (freezing water with a wand of cold, building a boulder bridge, polymorphing into a flying creature). Don't wade in without preparation, because:
2. **Giant eels** (electric eels on one layout). The water is home to giant eels that can grab and drown you on a successful hit, reaching into adjacent dry tiles too. See the eel-survival rules below.
3. **Medusa herself.** Her gaze turns you to stone. You need either **reflection** (a shield of reflection or amulet of reflection bounces the gaze back, stoning her instead) or **blindness** (you can't meet her gaze if you can't see). A mirror also works if you apply it at her. Reflection is the cleanest solution. If you got the amulet of reflection from Sokoban, you're already prepared.

There is a downward staircase on the island itself that leads toward the Castle. The level has four possible layouts (two added in 3.6), so don't rely on memorizing a single map.

The Perseus statue. One of the statues on the island is named **Perseus** — the mythological hero who killed Medusa with a mirrored shield. #loot him for a (cursed) **shield of reflection** (75% in three of the four layouts; 25% in the fourth), a blessed +2 **scimitar** (50%), **levitation boots** (25% in three layouts; 75% in the fourth — the same layout that's stingy with the shield), and a **sack** to put them in (50%). The shield is cursed, so plan to uncurse it before swapping it in. The other statues on the level are intentionally empty.

Arien Malec collected crossing strategies from RGRN posters back in the early 2000s, with input from Pat Rankin, Geoduck, Topi Linkala, and others. This is a condensed version of his guide.

Surviving Medusa's gaze. You need one of the following before entering her level:

- **Reflection** (amulet, shield, or silver dragon scale mail). Her gaze bounces back and stuns her instead. This is the cleanest solution and the one most players use.
- **Blindfold or towel.** Wear it before entering line of sight. You'll need telepathy or monster detection to navigate while blind. Works perfectly but makes the level harder to explore.
- **A mirror.** Apply it at Medusa to reflect her gaze at close range. More dangerous than passive reflection since you need to be adjacent.
- **One-shot kill.** If you have a wand of death, the spell finger of death, or a cockatrice corpse, you can kill Medusa before she gets a turn. Combine with speed or stealth for reliability.

Crossing the water. The island is surrounded by deep water. Your options, from safest to most desperate:

- **Levitation** (ring, boots, potion, or spell). The easiest way to cross. Eels can still grab you from adjacent water (see Drowning in Ways to Die).
- **Water walking boots.** You walk on the surface. Eels can still grab you in adjacent water.
- **Wand of cold.** Zap the water to freeze a path of ice. Ice is safe to walk on. This is reliable and only costs a few charges.
- **Scroll of earth.** Creates boulders that fall into the water, making a boulder bridge. Slow but works if you have nothing else.
- **Polymorph** into a flying or swimming creature. Risky if you lack polymorph control.
- **Jumping boots or the knight's jump.** Can leap across narrow water gaps, but requires careful positioning.

Surviving the eels. The water contains giant eels (and on one of the four layout variants, a kraken) that can grab and drown you. Critical rules:

- An **oilskin cloak** or **greased armor** makes the eel slip off on the grab attempt. Greasing wears off, so it's not fully reliable; oilskin doesn't.

- **Magical breathing** (amulet or polymorph) prevents the drown even after being grabbed.
- **Kill eels at range** whenever possible. Wands, spells, and thrown weapons all work. Don't melee eels in the water.
- Levitation and water walking do NOT protect against being grabbed by an eel in adjacent water. The drown check uses the *eel's* tile, not yours. Only oilskin/grease, magical breathing, or killing the eel first are reliable.

The Castle

The Castle is the last level of the Dungeons of Doom proper, a stone fortress surrounded by a moat with a drawbridge as its only entrance. Inside waits an army of defenders: soldiers in the barracks, dragons guarding the store-rooms, and a court of high-letter monsters in the throne room. Hidden in a chest in one of the four corner towers is the **wand of wishing**.

The Castle is the last step of the dungeon proper and the gateway to Gehennom. For how to open the drawbridge and what to do once you're inside, see The Castle in Part Six.



Traps and Hazards

Traps are invisible until you step on one, detect it with a search (`s` command), or reveal it by other means. Once discovered, they show up as `^` on your map, small consolation after you've already fallen in a pit. Each search of an adjacent square has an independent chance of revealing a trap, but the chance is well under 100%, so search repeatedly in suspicious areas. Your pet, being closer to the ground and warier by nature, will hesitate to step on traps it knows about; watch its movement for clues.

Here are the traps you'll encounter, roughly grouped by how much you'll regret finding them:

Nuisance Traps

Trap	Effect
Arrow trap	Fires an arrow at you (modest damage)
Dart trap	Fires a dart, may be poisoned
Squeaky board	Makes noise, wakes nearby monsters
Rust trap	Splashes water: rusts iron worn armor, soaks cloak/suit/shirt, douses lit lamps

Annoying but rarely lethal. The silver lining: arrow and dart traps produce free ammunition. Veterans sometimes trigger them deliberately to stock up.

Movement Traps

Trap	Effect
Pit	You fall in, take minor damage, can climb out
Spiked pit	Like a pit, but with spikes (more damage, possible poison)
Trapdoor	Drops you down a dungeon shaft — usually one level, but with a 25%-per-level chance to keep falling, so you can land several deeper

Trap	Effect
Teleport trap	Teleports you randomly on the level
Level teleporter	Teleports you to a random dungeon level
Hole	Like a trapdoor, but you can see it
Magic portal	Transports to a different branch (branch entrances)

Trapdoors and level teleporters are the most disruptive: one wrong step and you're separated from your pet, your stash, and your carefully explored map. But with teleport control (from an item or intrinsic), teleport traps become free transportation. **Levitation or flying** both make you immune to pits, holes, and trapdoors entirely — except in Sokoban, where the puzzle levels disable the skip and you fall in regardless.

Dangerous Traps

Trap	Effect
Land mine	Explosion, heavy damage, items can be destroyed
Bear trap	Holds you in place until you escape
Sleeping gas trap	Puts you to sleep (helpless for several turns)
Fire trap	Burns you, destroys scrolls and potions in inventory
Magic trap	Random magical effects (some good, some very bad)
Anti-magic field	Drains magical energy; hits harder if you carry magic resistance
Polymorph trap	Polymorphs you into a random creature
Rolling boulder	Triggers a boulder rolling along a fixed track; takes you out if your square is in its path

Fire traps are the sleeper threat. The fire itself hurts, but the real catastrophe is your inventory: scrolls burn, potions shatter, and that stack of twenty scrolls of identify you've been hoarding is suddenly ash. Fire resistance saves your skin but *not* your belongings.

Polymorph traps are a double-edged sword. With polymorph control, they're a free polymorphing booth. Without it, you become something random, possibly a newt that can't use any of its equipment. **Magic resistance and the Unchanging intrinsic both block the polymorph entirely.** Tcontrol is the only way to *use* the trap; MR or Unchanging let you walk through it untouched.

If you do get caught and polymorphed into a helpless form, your gear drops to the floor on the spot. Don't panic and don't move: random polymorphs wear off in a few hundred turns, and your kit is at the square you're standing on. Defend the square if you can, pray if a monster has you in a corner, and pick everything up the moment you change back. (If you happen to be carrying a wand of polymorph or know the spell, zapping or casting it on yourself lets you reroll the form, but only if your current form can use a wand or cast.)

Sleeping gas is murder in monster-rich areas. You can't fight, you can't run, you can't even wake up on purpose. Monsters line up to hit you like it's a buffet. Sleep resistance (elven blood, the right ring) sidesteps it.

Anti-magic fields hit harder if you're magic-resistant. Counterintuitive enough to mislead returning players. The trap drains spell energy, and having *magic resistance* also triggers an "anti-magic implosion" that costs you HP. The damage is d4 base, plus another d4 if you have half-physical or half-spell damage, plus d4 for wielding Magicbane, plus d4 for carrying any one magic-resistance artifact (only one counts — the check breaks on first match). At worst that's 4d4 damage, quartered (rounded up) if you can pass through walls. The defense is finding the trap first (search) and stepping around it. A wand of cancellation aimed at a magical trap *does* remove the trap, but it triggers a 20 + 3d6 damage blast at the trap's square in the process — not a silent defuse.

Iron footwear (iron shoes or kicking boots) absorbs a surprising amount of trap punishment in 5.0: no leg damage from a bear trap, no spikes from a spiked pit, no polymorph from a polymorph trap (your shoes shift instead), and a positively-enchanted pair eats an anti-magic field's drain by losing one enchantment instead. Useful protection to have on if you haven't found anything better yet.

Searching and Detection

The best defense against traps is finding them before they find you:

- **Search (s)** repeatedly. Each search has an independent chance to reveal each adjacent trap, and Luck improves the odds. (The artifact/lenses search bonus only speeds up secret-door and secret-corridor discovery, not trap finding.)
- **Wand of secret door detection** reveals everything hidden in a roughly circular area around you (radius about eight, blocked by line of sight): secret doors, secret corridors, traps, trapped chests, and concealed monsters. It's not directional.
- **Crystal ball** can reveal traps across the entire level
- **Pets** avoid known traps, so watch their pathfinding for clues
- **Flying and levitation** make you immune to most floor traps (you'll still trigger magic, teleport, and anti-magic traps)

A good time to search is when the dungeon has already hinted that something is wrong: a stray corpse in the middle of an otherwise empty room, a scatter of arrows or darts on the floor, a square your pet refuses to cross, or a themed room whose gimmick is hidden hazards.

Finding Secret Doors

The Dungeons of Doom were designed by architects who believed that every room should have one emergency exit that requires ten minutes of tapping on walls to locate. Secret doors and corridors are the game's passive-aggressive way of saying "you haven't explored *thoroughly* enough."

When to search for secrets:

- **Dead ends** that feel too convenient. If a corridor just stops, and you haven't found what you came for, there's probably a door in the surrounding walls
- **Suspiciously empty rooms** with no obvious exit. The exit exists; it's just been cunningly disguised as a wall
- **After exhausting all visible options.** When you've explored everything reachable and still haven't found the downstairs, it's time to stop wandering and start wall-tapping

The systematic approach:

Type 20s to search twenty times in one spot. For new characters with average Luck, you need 15-22 searches to reliably reveal a secret. Searching once and moving on is essentially announcing your intention to remain lost.

Move three squares along the wall and repeat. Each search reaches one square in every direction, so a stride of three gives complete wall coverage with no gaps and no wasted re-searching. The pattern looks tedious on paper because it *is* tedious, but tedium is cheaper than being trapped on Dlvl 1 forever.

Items that help:

- **Ring of searching** auto-searches every turn while it's worn
- **Excalibur** (or any artifact with the searching aura), wielded, adds its enchantment to your search bonus (a freshly-dipped +0 Excalibur adds nothing)
- **Lenses** worn (and you not blind) add +2 to the search bonus — but the total bonus from Excalibur + lenses caps at +5, so lenses only help if Excalibur's enchantment is below +3
- **Wand of secret door detection** instantly reveals nearby secrets in a radius
- **Blessed scroll of magic mapping** shows every secret door on the level (only the blessed version)

The wisdom of patience:

Secret doors are NetHack's way of teaching you that brute force doesn't solve every problem. Sometimes you need brute force applied methodically to every wall section in sequence. The downstairs you seek is behind one of these walls. Finding it is a matter of systematic elimination. The only mistake is giving up after three searches and declaring the level "impossible."

Engravings

You can write on the dungeon floor with the engrave command (E). Engravings serve a few practical purposes: writing **Elbereth** (covered next), running the engrave-test on an unidentified wand (covered in the wand chapter), or just leaving a note for whoever finds your bones file. The mechanics described here apply to *any* engraving, not just Elbereth.

Methods, speed, and durability. The tool you write with determines how quickly you can finish, how hard the engraving is to erase, and whether your stylus suffers wear.

Method	Speed	Durability	Notes
Finger (dust)	Instant	Fragile	Smudges when monsters step on it
Uncursed athame	Instant	Semi-permanent	Doesn't dull (cursed athame does)
Other edged weapon	Several turns	Semi-permanent	Interruptible; dulls (~1 enchantment per 2 chars — "Elbereth" costs ~-4)
Hard gem or diamond	Several turns	Semi-permanent	Interruptible
Wand of digging	Instant	Semi-permanent	Good middle ground
Wand of fire or lightning	Instant	Permanent	Burns the word into the floor

The three durability tiers correspond to how the text resists ordinary erosion:

- **Fragile** (dust) — a monster stepping on the square smudges one character. In dust, an Elbereth lasts as long as the floor stays clear.
- **Semi-permanent** (scratched into the floor) — monster traffic doesn't smudge it. Random erosion can occasionally chip a character under unusual conditions, but in practice the engraving lasts indefinitely.
- **Permanent** (burned in) — the engraving doesn't erode at all under normal conditions; only ice tiles or magical attacks can damage it.

Engraving is an interruptible occupation. Anything written by hand at multi-turn speed (non-athame edged weapon, gem) takes one turn per letter. If you're interrupted mid-word — by an attack, a monster wandering into view, or anything else that breaks an occupation — you get a partial engraving that does nothing useful. Instant methods (any wand, finger-in-dust, or an uncursed athame) finish in a single occupation action.

Impairment and errors. If you are blind, confused, stunned, or hallucinating, you have a chance of misspelling each letter, and this scrambling applies to *every* engraving method, including burns from a wand of fire. (Only the

dust/blood surface-garble roll is skipped for harder methods.) A misspelled message has no special power; this matters most for Elbereth.

Overwriting and combining. Appending to an existing engraving is possible, but for named-word magic like Elbereth the engraving must read *exactly* that word and nothing else, so the appended text usually destroys the ward. To refresh, overwrite the square or pick a fresh one.

Two engravings worth recognizing. Most engravings you find are random flavor (graffiti, “elbereth” left by someone else, etc.), but two specific messages are *trap markers* placed by the dungeon: “*ad aerarium*” (Latin: *to the treasury*) is engraved near a secret closet containing either a **vault teleporter** (a one-shot TELEP_TRAP that drops you into Croesus’s 2×2 gold vault on the same level — pick up the gold, then escape ahead of the vault guard) or a **level teleporter** (a LEVEL_TELEP that sends you to a random dungeon level, often unwelcome without Teleport control); “*Vlad was here*” marks a secret closet containing a **trap door**. Both are easy to miss in the message log, and worth investigating when you see them — but be ready for what’s on the other side.

Elbereth

Where the word comes from

Elbereth is Sindarin for “Star-Queen,” one of the Elvish names of **Varda Elentári**, highest of the Valar in J.R.R. Tolkien’s *Silmarillion* — the one who set the stars in the sky. In *The Lord of the Rings* the Elves invoke her name for protection against evil: Frodo cries “O Elbereth! Gilthoniel!” on Weathertop and the Witch-king recoils, and Sam invokes her in Shelob’s lair to make the Phial of Galadriel burn brighter. NetHack lifts the conceit directly: writing Varda’s name on the dungeon floor is an appeal to a higher power for safe ground.

The mechanics below are inspired by Kate Nepveu’s Elbereth FAQ. Kate also maintained steelypips.org, the long-running archive that preserved decades of community spoilers.

The ward

Writing the word **Elbereth** on the floor creates a protective ward. Most monsters will not melee-attack you while you stand on an Elbereth square; they mill around, frustrated, instead. The ward applies whether you wrote it or found it already engraved, and the underlying engraving method (dust, scratched, burned) doesn't affect the strength of the protection — only how long the engraving will survive.

Rules of the ward

- **It only works while you stand on it.** Step off and the protection ends. Stepping back on resumes it.
- **It must be the exact word.** “Elbereth,” nothing more, nothing less. Misspellings (from impairment) and combined text don't count.
- **Some monsters ignore it.** Anything represented by @ (humans, elves, player-like creatures), the Riders on the Astral Plane, Angels, minotaurs, unique/named monsters (quest nemeses, Vlad, the Wizard), shopkeepers, guards, and any blind monster will all walk right through. So will cornered monsters with no retreat path: a creature with nowhere to flee will fight rather than stand helplessly. As a rough principle, anything intelligent enough to recognize the misuse, anything that can't perceive the inscription, and anything with nothing to lose disregards the ward.
- **Elbereth doesn't work in Gehennom, on the Elemental Planes, or on the Astral Plane.** Below the Castle, you're on your own.

The defile rule (important)

If you melee-attack a monster while standing on Elbereth (and that monster *would* have feared the ward, or is peaceful), the engraving is **deleted instantly, in full, regardless of how it was made**. Even a burned-permanent Elbereth disappears in one swing. You take an **alignment hit** (“You feel like a hypocrite”) and see the message “*The engraving beneath you fades.*” The hit is a flat -5 if your alignment record is comfortably positive (above +5); otherwise it's a random -1 to -5.

The durability table doesn't show this: “permanent” and “semi-permanent” describe resistance to *passive* wear (monster footsteps, erosion). Your own

hostile action wipes the word regardless of tier. So Elbereth is strictly **defensive**. Use it to heal, drink a potion, read a scroll, swap gear — and step off (or kill at range) when you want to attack.

Practical use

In an emergency, write Elbereth in the dust with your finger: free, instant, and good enough to buy a turn or two. Most monsters will back off and let you act. Once the immediate danger passes, you can either step off the dust ward to keep it for next time (it survives until a monster steps on the square), or upgrade to something more durable.

For a permanent safe spot — useful for stashing items, resting at a fixed retreat point, or anchoring a corridor fight — burn the word with a wand of fire or lightning. One turn, no interruption risk, no impairment penalty, no wear. A semi-permanent engraving (athame, weapon, gem, wand of digging) is the middle ground: durable, but the slow methods can be interrupted mid-word.

While levitating, you can't engrave with your finger or your weapon: the game refuses both. A wand of fire, lightning, cold, or digging still works from above. You'll see "you gesture toward the floor below you" first, but the burn lands anyway. The old finger-in-dust trick from earlier editions is gone, but torching Elbereth into the floor from a wand of fire while floating still works.

Iron Bars

Iron bars look like a barrier but aren't solid: light passes through, you can see what's on the other side, and **tiny** creatures (grid bugs, bats, rats) can squeeze between — kittens and little dogs are already too big. What they resist is almost everything the player can throw at them: pick-axes bounce off ("Clang!"), wands of digging fizzle, weapons swing through harmlessly, and kicking just hurts your foot. Wands and spells of *striking* and *force bolt* pass through the bars without effect. The bars corrode for an acid ray, acid breath or spit (if you are polymorphed into a yellow dragon or black naga), and a **wand of lightning** can melt them too — though only about one zap in ten actually dissolves the bars.

The practical early-game answer is to **dig around** them. Iron bars sit in a niche cut into a room wall, so digging diagonally past the bars (or breaking through the wall to the stone behind and then back into the niche) reaches the contents without touching the bars. Mid-game, polymorph into something that breathes acid or lightning, passes walls (xorn, earth elemental), is **tiny** enough to slip between, or eats metal (rock mole). Starting pets won't fit, but a polymorphed pet can.

What's typically behind them: a scroll of teleportation (unless the level is non-teleport, in which case the niche skips it), occasionally a random item or a previous adventurer's corpse. The scroll is a joke: you'd need one already to read it from outside the bars.



Feelings and Sounds

Much of the most important information in NetHack comes to you as cryptic feelings and sounds. They sound like atmosphere, but most of them are specific signals. If you don't know what they mean, you'll miss the cues entirely. They are worth memorizing.

(Caveat: being **deaf**, **swallowed**, or **underwater** silences the ambient-sound channel completely — Permadeaf conducts in particular lose every level-flavor cue. The feeling-from-corpse messages still come through.)

Message	What it means
<i>"You have a sad feeling for a moment, then it passes."</i>	Your pet just died offscreen.
<i>"You hear someone counting gold coins."</i>	Vault on this level, with gold still in it.
<i>"You hear the footsteps of a guard on patrol." "You hear someone searching."</i>	Vault on this level (the "searching" message means the vault is already empty).
<i>"You hear a strange wind."</i>	Oracle on this level.
<i>"You hear someone cursing shoplifters."</i>	Shop on this level.
<i>"You hear bubbling water." "You hear water falling on coins."</i>	Fountain on this level.
<i>"You hear a bugle playing reveille!"</i>	A soldier just woke nearby soldiers; expect a fight.
<i>"You feel healthy."</i>	Intrinsic poison resistance from a corpse.
<i>"You feel a momentary chill."</i>	Intrinsic fire resistance from a corpse.
<i>"You feel full of hot air."</i>	Intrinsic cold resistance from a corpse.
<i>"Your health currently feels amplified!"</i>	Intrinsic shock resistance from a corpse.
<i>"You feel wide awake."</i>	Intrinsic sleep resistance from a corpse.
<i>"You feel very firm."</i>	Intrinsic disintegration resistance from a corpse.
<i>"You feel a strange mental acuity."</i>	Intrinsic telepathy from a corpse.
<i>"You seem faster."</i>	Intrinsic speed from a quantum mechanic corpse. (If you already had speed, you instead "seem slower" — quantum corpses toggle.)
<i>"You feel a mild buzz."</i>	Eye of newt corpse restored 1–3 mana.

Message	What it means
<i>"You sense a lack of food nearby."</i>	Scroll of food detection, no food on level.
<i>"You feel materially poor."</i>	Scroll of gold detection, no gold on level.
<i>"You feel like someone is helping you."</i>	Scroll of remove curse; worn/wielded cursed items uncursed.
<i>"You move very quietly."</i>	Ring of stealth or elven cloak. (Elven boots give <i>"You walk very quietly"</i> instead.)
<i>"Wow! This makes you feel great!"</i>	Blessed potion of restore ability with no remaining troubles — <i>or</i> a blessed magic fountain hit.
<i>"You feel feverish."</i>	Lycanthropy infection from a were-monster. quaff holy water, eat wolfsbane, or #pray.
<i>"You are slowing down."</i>	You're turning to stone. Immediately eat a lizard corpse, drink acid, or pray.
<i>"You are turning into slime."</i>	Green-slime contagion. Burn it off (read a fire scroll, cast fireball on yourself, or self-zap a wand of fire), or #pray.
<i>"You feel deathly sick."</i>	Terminal illness (Pestilence, Demogorgon). Quaff extra healing, eat eucalyptus, or pray.



Survival

The Art of Combat

The most important combat technique in the Mazes is knowing when *not* to fight. The second most important is making sure you hit really, really hard when you do.

To-Hit Calculation

Every swing of your weapon is a d20 roll, modified by everything the game can think of to make your life interesting:

- Your experience level (the game's way of saying "you've seen things")
- Your weapon's enchantment (a +7 Excalibur hits *noticeably* better)
- Your Luck (the universe literally takes sides; the to-hit contribution caps around ± 5 even though Luck itself ranges further)
- Your Strength and Dexterity bonuses (muscles plus agility, both matter)
- The monster's AC (the lower their AC, the harder they are to tag)

You need to roll at or above (10 + defender's AC - your modifiers). Since some late-game monsters have AC of -10 or worse, this formula can feel like trying to hit smoke. Enchant your weapon. Keep your luck up. And maybe don't try to punch an arch-lich.

Damage

Base damage depends on your weapon and whether the target is small or large. (Most weapons are optimized for one or the other, because apparently dungeon physics care about monster volume.) Added to base:

- Weapon enchantment (+1 per point)
- Strength bonus (up to +6 for STR 18/xx, or more)
- Weapon skill bonus (depends on skill level)
- Special bonuses (silver damage, artifact bonuses, etc.)

- In 5.0, **two-handed weapons** get a 50% bonus to the strength damage component, a deliberate payoff for giving up your shield

This narrows the gap between two-handed builds and dual-wielding considerably. A Barbarian with a two-handed sword and respectable Strength is not just accepting the trade-off of foregoing a shield: they're dealing measurably more damage per swing than a comparable one-handed build. If you've been avoiding two-handed weapons because the math didn't add up, run those numbers again.

AC and Defense

Your AC determines how likely monsters are to hit *you*. The journey from "I die to gnomes" to "nothing can touch me" looks like this:

Stage	Typical AC	Protection level
Starting out	8 to 10	Wearing a good attitude
Early dungeon	2 to 5	Basic armor equipped
Mid-game	-5 to 0	Enchanted armor + cloak
Endgame	-20 to -10	Walking tank

At AC -20, almost nothing hits you with physical attacks. Feel free to laugh at ogres. But many late-game threats use special attacks (breath weapons, spells, gaze attacks) that ignore AC entirely. You can be wearing impenetrable armor and a disenchanter will still ruin your day. AC is necessary but not sufficient.

Two-Weapon Combat

Some roles can fight with a weapon in each hand, which looks impressive and gives more attacks per turn. The catch: each strike takes a flat to-hit and damage penalty determined by your two-weapon skill (−9/−7/−5/−3 to hit, −3/−1/0/+1 damage from Unskilled through Expert), and you can't use a shield. Only **Rogue** and **Samurai** can reach Expert; Valkyrie and Knight cap at Skilled; everyone else lower or none. Rangers don't have the skill at all. If you're not sure, just use one really good weapon. In 5.0, two-handed weapons got a buff (3/2 strength damage bonus) that makes them a good alternative.

Fighting Smart

The dungeon rewards cowardice, cunning, and property damage. Here are the time-tested tactics that keep adventurers breathing:

- **Use corridors.** Monsters can only approach one at a time in a corridor — the single most important tactical principle in the Mazes. Never fight a mob in an open room if you can retreat to a chokepoint and fight them in single file. It turns a suicide mission into a turkey shoot.
- **Fight at range.** Wands, thrown weapons, and spells let you soften up monsters before they reach you. This is especially important against monsters with dangerous melee attacks. A fire ant is scary in melee. A fire ant that you've already zapped three times is just a warm corpse.
- **Know when to run.** The Mazes have no medals for bravery, only for survival. If a fight is going badly, use a scroll of teleportation, a wand of teleportation, or just run. Dead adventurers don't get second chances (unless wearing an amulet of life saving).
- **Use conflict.** A ring of conflict makes monsters fight each other. Walk into a room full of enemies, put on the ring, and watch from the doorway as they destroy each other. Two 5.0 caveats: a monster has to *see* you for conflict to affect it (so blind or out-of-sight monsters keep their wits), and the chance scales with your **Charisma**: high Cha makes it noticeably more reliable, low Cha makes it flaky.

- **Elbereth for emergencies.** Write it, stand on it, recover. The monsters will mill around you looking confused and angry, which is exactly how you want them.
- **Ranged attackers retreat.** Monsters with ranged attacks (archers, spellcasters, anything that can hurt you from a distance) now actively back away when you close to melee range. Walking toward a centaur archer to neutralize its bow no longer works; it will simply back up and keep shooting. The tactical implications: use corners and narrow passages to cut off their retreat, bring ranged options of your own, or use a wand of teleportation to skip past the dance. This change also means monster spellcasters are more dangerous than they used to be: they'll maintain the range they need to cast while you struggle to close.
- **Cornered scared monsters fight.** Elbereth still works, and the engrave-and-regenerate tactic still works, but only when the monster has somewhere to go. A frightened monster that has nowhere to flee will now turn and fight rather than stand helplessly while you recover. If you've carved Elbereth in a corridor and then backed a monster into a dead end, be ready for it to make a decision about that arrangement. Keep an exit behind the monster, or expect contact.
- **The first swing wakes the room.** Sleeping monsters stay asleep while you walk past them, but a hit on one wakes everything around it: the struck monster growls, and the growl wakes any other sleeping monster within roughly seven squares for a level-3 gnome, more for larger creatures. A packed room becomes a simultaneous brawl on swing two. Pull the pack one at a time by *backing away* into a corridor first (so they wake strung out in a line) or write Elbereth and let them come.
- **Watch your alignment around peacefuls.** Knights and Samurai take a special alignment hit for attacking the helpless, fleeing, or peaceful (a caitiff penalty for Knights, a giri-breaking penalty for Samurai). The Quest entrance check requires alignment record at least 20 *and* experience level at least 14. A handful of careless peaceful kills can lock a Knight or Samurai out of the Quest for the rest of the run.
- **Doors and diagonals.** You can't move diagonally through a door: approach and leave orthogonally. **Closing a door** (c + direction) blocks pets and any monster lacking the intelligence or hands to open it; handy when you want to slip away from your pet, or when you need a turn or two of quiet.



Ways to Die

Only about **0.4% of games end in ascension**. The other 99.6% are deaths. NetHack ends in death by default; survival is the exception.

The early dungeon is deadly. The top ten killers are, in order: jackals, dwarves, soldier ants, gnome lords, sewer rats, giant bats, small mimics, gnomes, foxes, water moccasins. Every one of them lives on the upper dungeon levels. None are intrinsically dangerous to a prepared character. They get you because you haven't built HP, AC, or resistances yet and they outnumber you. The strategic takeaway: the early game has been the deadliest stretch of NetHack since 1987. Don't push to descend; spend the turns clearing levels, finding altars, and getting BUC information.

On pacing. A rough rule of thumb: your experience level should be at least somewhere near the dungeon level you're standing on. Going down stairs at experience level 4 onto Dungeon level 12 is how you meet things you can't outrun and can't outfight. The dungeon doesn't wait — every step deeper raises the monster difficulty roll, and a fragile character with 30 HP isn't going to soak even a single bad encounter. There's no prize for getting to Sokoban quickly. Clear, identify, level up, then descend.

On bones. "Bones" levels are levels saved from another adventurer's death and replayed in your game. The game flags them ("This place looks familiar..." or a recognized layout, plus a grave marker in the dungeon overview) but doesn't otherwise warn you. They are dangerous in two ways. First, items on a bones level generate cursed about 80% of the time, so don't put on anything you find there without altar-testing or pet-testing. Second, and much less well known: bones-level *monsters* can be far above the level's normal difficulty. The previous adventurer may have died with a master mind flayer adjacent, or a summoned demon nearby, or in monster form. Those creatures stick around. Treat any above-depth monster on a bones level as evidence to retreat, not to engage. If your character isn't ready for the monster, leave the level and come back when you are.

Common Combat Deaths

Beyond the top ten, certain enemy categories kill more beginners than their depth or appearance would suggest. The shape of the threat is usually pack tactics, surprising speed, or one catastrophic special attack.

The Gnomish Mines is a choice, not a routine stop. Mines residents are G, gnomes, and h, the humanoid class that includes dwarves. Plain gnomes, gnome lords, dwarves, and gnomish wizards all sit in the top fifteen causes of death on the public server, because the Mines funnel four or five armed opponents into a single room and beginners walk in at XL 3 expecting an extra branch. Dwarves hit harder than they look and come armored. Gnomish wizards (a G with spell attacks) can cast sleep at you among other things, and a sleeping adventurer in a Mines room is a dead one. Take the branch when you have HP, a real weapon, and sleep resistance. A positive AC at XL 5 is not enough.

Sleep without resistance is a near-instadeath. A homunculus (i) bite, a gnomish wizard's sleep spell, or later an orange dragon or Nazgul breath puts you to sleep for several turns. If you are alone in a corridor it costs you a couple of rounds. If you are surrounded by anything else, the surrounding monsters chew through your HP while you cannot move. Sleep resistance comes from any elf, elven mummy, or giant corpse, and from several roles' starting kits (Wizard's cloak of MR, Ranger's elven cloak). Eat for it before descending into the Mines or the lower Quest.

Bats and other speedsters (B). Bats and giant bats clock in at speed 22, nearly twice your starting 12. They get two attacks for every one of yours, and a 1d4 bite at double rate chews through low HP fast. Ravens and vampire bats are speed 20 with two attacks each (and the vampire bat's second bite drains Strength). The defense is positioning, not HP totals: fight from a doorway so they cannot kite around you, or kill them at range. Centaurs (speed 18 to 20) and vortices raise the same problem later on.

Ants and other pack travelers (a). Soldier ants are speed 18 with two attacks (bite plus a Strength-draining sting) and travel in groups. A wandering soldier-ant pack on Dlvl 4 can end a careless run. Killer bees, giant ants, and fire ants are the same shape of problem. Treat any chittering or buzzing on an unexplored level as a reason to back up and find a chokepoint before the pack closes.

Quadrupeds (q). Rothes are three-attack pack hunters at sluggish speed 9: a single one is easy to outrun, but three in a room is several real fights stacked together. Mumakil are solo two-attack bruisers (4d12 butt plus 2d6 bite) that hit harder than anything else in the upper dungeon. Both wander mid-level rooms.

Golems ('). Golems are class ' (apostrophe), not P (which is puddings). Most are slow but several hit disproportionately hard. The rope golem grapples on a hugs attack and pins you in place for adjacent friends to chew on. Clay and stone golems deliver 3d10 and 3d8 in a single claw. The iron golem is the endgame model: level 18, 4d10 weapon plus a 4d6 poison-gas breath that drains Strength, and resistant to fire, cold, electricity, sleep, and poison. Most golems leave no corpse, so they cannot be eaten for intrinsics. Kill them quickly and at range when you can.

Water demons from fountains (&). Quaffing a fountain summons a water demon roughly 1 quaff in 30. Water demons are major demons (class &, level 8) who attack first and grant a wish only if you survive. Wish odds also drop with depth, so casual quaffing pays worse the deeper you go. Don't quaff from fountains until you have magic resistance, reflection, or a clear path of retreat.

Deadly Mistakes

Routine mistakes kill more adventurers than exotic instadeaths. The list below is sorted roughly by frequency on the public server.

Eating mistakes. Rotted corpse, poisonous corpse, and choking each rank in the top forty causes of death. Don't eat old corpses. Don't eat while Satiated. Don't finish a heavy corpse if you're already approaching Satiated. Pray immediately if you ate something you shouldn't have.

Reading unidentified scrolls in a shop. A confused or cursed scroll of teleportation level-teleports you out of the shop with the unpaid merchandise still in your pack, turning the shopkeeper hostile when you return. A scroll of fire destroys shop goods you are liable for. Save the price-ID session for outside.

Mount slips and riding accidents. More heroes die slipping off saddled ponies than die to mind flayers. Getting on a steed rolls against your experi-

ence level plus the steed's tameness; on a failure you take 10 to 14 HP. Don't mount while Confused, Fumbling, or Glib, don't mount with a cursed or greased saddle, and don't mount a barely-tame pony at experience level 2.

Pet kills. Kittens, little dogs, housecats, and ponies all appear on the death list, almost always because the player put on a ring of conflict and forgot to take it off. Remove the ring before walking back to your pet.

Boiling and shattering potions. Hot ground in Gehennom shatters any potion you drop on the floor, and the shrapnel is deadly. Keep potions in a bag once you descend below the Castle. Bagging your potion and scroll stash earlier is also wise: a yellow dragon's lightning bolt shatters every loose potion in your pack, and a fire trap incinerates loose scrolls.

Killed by your own wand. Self-zapped attack wands, rays ricocheting off a wall in a narrow corridor and back into your face. Engrave-test wands before pointing them at yourself.

Killed by a grid bug. The weakest monster in the game kills more than 11,000 adventurers per year. They get the last hit on someone who walked away from a real fight at 2 HP, or someone who decided to read a scroll on the turn one was adjacent. Don't read scrolls under threat.

Killed by kicking. Kicking sinks summons a black pudding, a foocubus, or worse. Kicking doors can break your toe. Kicking locked chests can electrocute you, and electric shock is a top-100 cause of death on its own. Stop kicking things.

Wrath of a god. You prayed when your god wasn't willing. See Divine Relations for the prayer cooldown and what counts as "trouble" worth a prayer.

Scroll of genocide while confused. Confused genocide removes your role's own species from the world (Valkyrie, Wizard, Samurai). You become the genocide. Don't read scrolls under confusion unless you already know what they are.

Scroll of earth on yourself. Buried under a pile of boulders you summoned on your own head.

Routine mistakes kill far more adventurers than exotic instadeaths. Floating eyes, cockatrices, mind flayers, and disenchanters all matter (and they're

catalogued in Yet More Ways to Die). But the median death is a preventable swarm of jackals on Dlvl 3.

A note on mimics

You will frequently meet mimics in **shops**, with more as you get deeper. An average shop has one or two mimics sitting in the aisles, masquerading as items. They're slow (speed 3) but their claws hit hard. Small mimics rank in the top ten causes of death.

The visual tell. A mimic appearing as a generic “strange object” renders on the map as] — a mirror of [, the armor class. No real item ever displays as]. A] on a shop floor or anywhere else is always a mimic.

Other contextual disguises (rare in practice but worth knowing): a mimic in a temple may appear as an extra altar, in a Delphi room as a second fountain, in a maze as a lone boulder. So “a single piece of furniture that shouldn't be there” is suspicious.

How to uncover one safely. Search the adjacent square (s) reveals concealed mimics like it reveals traps. Throw a cheap item at the suspected square; the mimic uncloaks and the item lands harmlessly. A stethoscope applied to the square also uncloaks. Telepathy, ESP, astral vision, and a wand of secret door detection see through the disguise and show the mimic as m. Your pet won't step onto a mimic.

Sticking. Large and giant mimics glue you in place on a successful claw hit: you can't move, you can't go down stairs, you can't escape down a hole. Magic cancellation (cloak of protection, amulet of guarding, etc.) reduces the sticking chance — one more reason to secure MC before browsing mid-game shops.

Eating the corpse turns you into a pile of gold (or, while hallucinating, an orange) for 20 / 40 / 50 turns depending on size. Anything that tries to pick “you” up snaps the spell.

A note on dragons

Dragons deserve a full briefing. Each color has its own breath weapon, resistance, scale mail property, and degree of desire to kill you specifically. The summary:

Gray dragon scale mail grants magic resistance, the most important defensive property in the game, full stop. Gray dragons are the ones you most want to kill for their skin, and also the ones most likely to make you regret trying.

Silver dragon scale mail grants reflection. The second pillar of not dying to wands.

Black dragons disintegrate everything you're wearing along with you, including your magic resistance. Carry reflection or eat enough black dragons to grow disintegration resistance before going where they live. Their scale mail grants disintegration resistance plus drain resistance, a rare extrinsic source of the latter.

Yellow dragon scale mail is an underrated pick. Listed power is acid resistance, but it also grants **stoning resistance** — the same outright immunity acid blob corpses give. If you find a yellow dragon and don't already have stone-res, killing it is worth the trip. Yellow dragons are rare, though.

Orange dragon scale mail grants sleep resistance *and* free action (the ring's effect), bundled into one slot.

White dragon scale mail grants cold resistance *and* slow digestion — a useful nutritional save on long descents.

Red dragon scale mail grants fire resistance *and* infravision, the same effect as a ring of infravision or being elven.

Green dragon scale mail grants poison resistance *and* sickness resistance — a pair of niche defenses in one slot.

Blue dragon scale mail grants shock resistance *and* intrinsic **speed** — same tier as speed boots. (Wearing both at once doesn't make you faster; either alone reaches Very Fast.) One of the most powerful body slots in the game.

Gold dragons are new in 5.0 and breathe fire. Their scale mail has no resistance power but is permanently lit (radius 4 blessed, 3 uncursed, 2 cursed) —

the only body-slot light source in the game, and it lets you abandon torches and oil. It also confers hallucination resistance.

All scale mails are dragonhide, body-slot, +9 AC worn (the best in the body slot), and resist disenchantment naturally. The choice of which color to chase is usually whichever dragon's territory you can reach safely; killing a dragon yields scales you can wear immediately or convert to scale mail.



Yet More Ways to Die

Some things in the Mazes kill you outright. Not by whittling down your hit points, not by wearing you down over time, but by ending your life in a single move with no second chance. These are called instadeaths, and learning to recognize the situations that produce them is the difference between a promising run and a one-line epitaph.

The catalog of instadeaths below is inspired by Trevor Powell's Instadeath Spoiler, which drew on Dylan O'Donnell's RGRN files. Trevor defined an instadeath as "a single move death which does not involve the player's hit points dropping to zero," and that taxonomy has been the standard reference ever since.

Petrification (Stoning)

Touching a cockatrice without gloves, eating a cockatrice corpse, catching Medusa's gaze, or **kicking** a cockatrice corpse barefoot will turn you to stone. *Stepping* on the corpse is safe so long as you don't have Fumbling (Fumbling can trip you over the corpse for instant death). The process is sometimes immediate; otherwise a five-turn countdown announces itself with "You are slowing down," "Your limbs are stiffening," "Your limbs have turned to stone" (at which point you are **paralyzed** and can no longer act), "You have turned to stone," and "You are a statue" (death).

Defenses ahead of time: wear gloves around cockatrice corpses, use reflection against Medusa, and pile up *timed* stoning resistance from acid blob corpses (each one grants d(3,6) turns of HStone resistance — useful, but not permanent). For something permanent, wear yellow dragon scale mail.

Defenses while it's happening: eat a lizard corpse (this is why you carry one), eat an acidic corpse, drink a potion of acid, pray, or cast stone-to-flesh on yourself. Note: act *before* the "Your limbs have turned to stone" message — after that you're paralyzed for three turns and the final messages kill you. Amulet of Unchanging does **not** interrupt stoning. If you happen to

be polymorphed into a non-stone golem, wearing it during the countdown is actively harmful — it blocks the stone-golem auto-poly that would otherwise save you on death.

Out of lizards? Any acidic corpse will do: acid blob, jellies, yellow dragon, black naga, and yes, green slime works (but green slime starts a *different* countdown that turns you to slime; only reach for it as a last resort). Quaffing a potion of acid has the same curative effect.

The other side of the coin: a wielded cockatrice corpse (with gloves on) is one of the game's most devastating weapons — anything you hit that lacks stoning resistance turns to stone.

Drowning

Giant eels, electric eels, and krakens can grab you with their wrap attack. Once they have you, each of the monster's turns you can drown — the check uses the *monster's* tile (always water for an eel or kraken), not yours, so you can drown even while standing on adjacent dry land. Only *Swimming*, *magical breathing*, or *amphibious form* prevent the drown; encumbrance doesn't matter here. (Encumbrance only matters if you *fall* into water and need to crawl out — stressed or worse forces emergency disrobe.) You'll meet eels and krakens at Medusa's level, in moats around the Castle, in swamp rooms, and on the Water Plane.

Defenses: An amulet (or spell) of *magical breathing* gives you Breathless and ends the grab-drown threat. Levitation keeps you above pools so you can't walk into them, but **does not save you from an eel's grab** once it lands. Kill sea monsters at range whenever possible — their grab attack requires adjacency.

Attack Wands and the Warning Shot

The first time any given monster zaps a beam wand (death, sleep, fire, cold, lightning, magic missile) at you, the shot misses. If you can see the monster, the wand identifies itself in the same moment, so now you know what was just aimed at you and you have a turn to do something about it before the next zap connects. **Late-game exception:** monsters generated in the

Stronghold, Knox, the Quest, Gehennom, Vlad's Tower, or the endgame planes start with their "experience" flag already set, so their first zap can connect. The freebie is an early-to-mid-game courtesy.

The Touch of Death

Some monsters, most notably Death (one of the Riders on the Astral Plane), can kill you with a single touch. The Finger of Death spell and the wand of death work similarly.

Death the Rider's touch rolls 1d20 each hit. Rolls 17-19 trigger the full **8d6 + 50** instakill attempt and permadrain half the damage from your max HP — magic resistance fully blocks this high-damage branch. Rolls 5-16 (the most common 60%) deliver a smaller life-drain that MR does **not** block. Rolls 0-4 miss entirely. A high-level character with many hit points can survive the high-damage hit; the permadrain still hurts.

The wand of death and Finger of Death spell are gated by magic resistance only when the death ray *hits you from outside*. If you misfire and self-zap, MR doesn't save you — only being **nonliving** (polymorphed into a vampire, lich, skeleton, etc.) or a demon will. This is one of the rare cases where being polymorphed into something dead is the safer state. The same nonliving/demon immunity also protects against incoming death rays.

An amulet of life saving will revive you once if the touch or zap kills you outright.

Starvation

This isn't technically instant, but it feels like it. If your nutrition drops to zero, you faint. If you don't eat something while fainted, you die. In the early game before you've established a food supply, starvation is a real threat.

Defenses: Eat corpses promptly. Pray when your god is willing and you are Weak or Fainting (prayer cures hunger). Carry food rations, tripe rations, or lembas wafers. Don't let nutrition management slide.

Brainlessness

Mind flayers drain Intelligence with their tentacle attacks. If your Intelligence drops to your racial minimum (3 for humans), the next drain kills you: “brainlessness.” A regular mind flayer has three tentacle attacks per turn; the **master mind flayer** has *five*, plus a heavier weapon strike, and is widely called the most lethal non-boss monster in the dungeon. A single unprepared turn next to a master mind flayer can drop your Int by up to ten. Each hit also has a 1-in-5 chance to trigger **spell amnesia**: a random number of your memorized spells (zero to all of them) drop to zero retention; re-study from spellbooks to restore. (Before 5.0 amnesia used to wipe maps and identification also, but no longer.)

Defenses: Wear any helmet. Even a plain orcish helm blocks seven of every eight tentacle drains. Greasing the helmet stacks an additional slip-off roll on top, so a greased helmet is the gold standard. Better yet, kill them at range (wands, spells) so the question doesn’t arise. To recover drained Intelligence you need a *potion of restore ability* (uncursed restores one stat; blessed restores all), the spell of restore ability, or prayer when you’re in good standing. In 5.0 the unicorn horn no longer restores lost attributes, so don’t rely on it. Stockpile at least one restore ability before pushing into mind flayer territory.

Level Drain

A recurring theme in the bestiary: certain monsters reduce your experience level on a hit, taking the HP and power gains that came with each lost level. Wraiths, barrow wights, Nazgul, vampires, vampire leaders, and Vlad himself all carry level-drain attacks. Stormbringer in an enemy's hand does the same. Drained levels do not come back on their own. You re-earn them by killing more monsters, by drinking a potion of restore ability (a blessed one restores all lost levels at once), or by eating a wraith corpse.

(Don't confuse drain-life with *Strength* drain: a vampire bat's poisoned bite drains Str, not levels. Stat drain is a separate problem and Enchantment Drain covers its cousin.)

Defenses: *Drain resistance* makes you immune. The classic sources are wielding Excalibur (Lawful), Stormbringer (Chaotic), or the Staff of Aesculapius (Healer's quest artifact). New in 5.0: wearing **black dragon scale mail** (disintegration resistance plus drain resistance, both in one slot) or a **shield of drain resistance** (random shop find, no other property).

Eating a fresh wraith corpse restores one experience level and is one of the better reasons to keep one fresh; wraith corpses are weightless and can't be tinned (no nutrition), so eat them as soon as the fight ends.

Enchantment Drain

Disenchancers (R, blue) appear only in Gehennom. Their claw is the silent ascension-killer it's reputed to be, but the mechanic is more constrained than common lore suggests.

Their **active** claw picks one of your worn armor pieces (cloak first, then suit, shirt, helm/gloves/boots/shield by weighted chance) and shaves 1 off its enchantment. If you have no armor at all, it can instead chew a ring, amulet, or blindfold. **It can't reach your wielded weapon** with the active attack. The game does print "Your *thing* seems less effective" each time, so you'll know when it lands.

Your weapon only takes enchantment damage as a **passive** counter when you hit them in melee. Three or four melee strikes will take a +7 sword to +3; that passive drain is silent. Range-killing sidesteps both attacks at once.

Defenses. Every artifact has a 90% chance to resist each enchantment-drain attempt on itself; ordinary items resist 10% of the time. The Invocation items (Amulet, Bell, Candelabrum, Book of the Dead) and Rider corpses always resist. **Magic-cancellation armor** is the strongest non-artifact armor defense for the active claw: at MC3 the claw will mostly fail to land. (MC doesn't help against the passive counter, so still don't melee them.) Range-kill is the cleanest plan; rings of conflict and pets reliably redirect them. **Don't eat the corpse:** it strips a random intrinsic.

Engulfment

Two monsters hide in plain sight until you walk into them. The **lurker above** (t, gray, level 10) hides on the ceiling and drops onto whoever passes underneath; the **trapper** (t, green, level 12) hides on the floor and engulfs whoever steps onto it. Both look like ordinary terrain until they trigger. Engulfment wraps and crushes rather than digesting, but you still take damage every turn until you cut your way out, with limited movement options while inside.

Other engulfers don't hide; they just swallow you in melee. Dragons and purple worms can swallow whole creatures up to their size. Dragons tend to be polite about it (you escape after one or two turns); purple worms are the bigger danger, and the dread **fog cloud** and **air elemental** count as engulfers too even though they don't digest.

Defenses: Searching reveals hidden monsters. *Telepathy* shows them through the deception. Wearing a *ring of warning* or a *helm of caution* tips you off before you step.

Getting out. Once engulfed, attack the host repeatedly; weapons still work from inside. If you have a wand of digging, zap it (no direction needed): it almost always expels you immediately, leaving the engulfer at 1 HP. A wand of opening or the knock spell forces the engulfer to release you on the spot. Ranged spells and rays will tear into the host from the inside.

Light Bursts

Yellow lights (y, level 3) and **black lights** (y, level 5) attack by exploding the moment you're adjacent. Yellow lights blind you for **10d20 turns** (up to 200 — a *blessed* potion of healing or any extra/full healing cures, or apply a unicorn horn); black lights hallucinate you for **10d12 turns** (a unicorn horn cures it, or wait it out). Both lights die in the explosion, so the encounter resolves immediately, but the after-effect is long enough to be the real threat. Black lights are invisible; *see invisible* reveals them, but because they die in the same turn they attack, you'll only "see" them just before they vanish.

Defenses: Kill them at range with wands, thrown daggers, breath weapons — anything that doesn't bring you adjacent. *Warning* detects them through invisibility, but *telepathy* does not (they're mindless). If you do get blinded, a unicorn horn cures it.

Seduction

The **amorous demon** (&, gray) appears as a **succubus** to male heroes and an **incubus** to female ones. A same-sex foocubus just claws at you and never starts the seduction. The encounter is a Cha+Int gamble: five bad outcomes vs. five good ones, plus a payment phase. Handled badly it can drain a level, an attribute, and 6–15 HP; handled well it grants a level, an attribute, full HP, and extra max Pw.

Mechanics. The demon must be adjacent and not on cooldown. It strips off your worn armor one piece at a time (cloak, suit, boots, gloves, shield, helm, shirt). The items are unequipped to your inventory, not taken or dropped on the floor; the only thing the strip costs you is the slot for the rest of the encounter. You get a yes/no prompt before each piece comes off with probability Cha/20 (so Cha 18 prompts about 9 times in 10; Cha 10 about half the time). **If you're still wearing a body armor or cloak when the strip ends, the encounter ends right there** and the demon walks away. A hard-to-remove suit is the simplest defense.

If you do get to the act, the outcome rolls against your combined Cha+Int (capped at 32). At the cap the bad-outcome chance is about 6%; at Cha+Int

= 20 it's about 40%; at 10 it's nearly 70%. Check your stats before you accept.

Bad outcome (low Cha+Int)	Good outcome (high Cha+Int)
Energy drained (Pw → 0, -1d10 max)	+1d5 max Pw, refilled
-1 Constitution	+1 Constitution
-1 Wisdom	+1 Wisdom
Lose 1 XP level (drain res blocks)	Gain 1 XP level
6-15 HP damage	HP restored to max

The demon then charges 500+ zorkmids (high Cha can refuse; peaceful demons charge 1/5). Being asleep or otherwise unresponsive defers the attempt entirely.

Strategic note. At high Cha+Int the encounter is net-positive, and the armor-removal step strips *curse*d worn pieces too — an amorous demon can be the cheapest curse-removal in the dungeon. Some players keep one alive to farm XP and attributes. Don't try this at experience level 1, though: the level-drain outcome is fatal.

The Riders

On the Astral Plane, three unique &-class beings guard the way to the high altars: **Death**, **Famine**, and **Pestilence**, the Riders. They are level 30, regenerate while you fight, see invisible, and shove monsters out of their path. Each hits twice per turn with a touch attack dealing 8d8 damage. **Death's** touch has a 3-in-20 chance of instant-kill on every hit — magic resistance blocks the instakill specifically; the regular damage still goes through. **Pestilence** inflicts a deadly illness that kills you over the next several turns. **Sick resistance** is the cleanest defense, though a unicorn horn can sometimes clear it in time. **Famine** adds 40-79 hunger units to a normal hit, which won't drop you below Hungry in one swing but will starve you fast across an encounter. Eating any Rider corpse is straight-up fatal. A mercy in 5.0: if Pestilence or Famine land their first attack on a turn, the second downgrades to a stun.

Defenses: An **amulet of life saving** is the best insurance on Astral, full stop. Magic resistance is what stops Death's instakill (but not its 8d8 base-line). Sick resistance handles Pestilence. Carry plenty of food (Famine's

drain bypasses normal nutrition) and a unicorn horn for the stun secondary effects. In a crowd, a ring of conflict can keep the Riders tangled fighting nearby monsters instead of chasing you, sometimes long enough to reach the altar.

Choking

If you push past Satiated and keep eating, you can choke and die. The game prints “You’re having a hard time getting all of it down” as a warning; if you have eating-confirmations turned on it’ll also prompt you. Past a hard nutrition threshold the choke check fires and, unless you’re Breathless or pass a 1-in-20 escape, kills you instantly.

The other path to choking is the amulet of strangulation. Worn, it puts a short countdown on your throat and kills you when it runs out. The amulet generates cursed 90% of the time, so you usually can’t just take it off: pray, or uncure it with holy water or remove curse. Magic resistance doesn’t help — strangulation isn’t an attack, it’s a timer death. Polymorphing into a Breathless form *does* save you.

Defense: Don’t eat above Satiated. Be paranoid about unidentified amulets.

Deadly Poison

A handful of monsters (pit vipers, killer bees, cobras, some spiders) have a poison-damage branch that can deliver 10 to 34 extra HP of damage on top of the normal hit. At full HP you usually survive; at low HP it can outright kill you. The “extra-damage” roll fires about 1 in 240 per qualifying hit. Eating any Rider corpse (Death, Pestilence, *or* Famine) is genuinely instantly fatal regardless of HP.

Defenses: Poison resistance makes you immune. Most characters can get this early by eating enough appropriate corpses. It’s one of the first intrinsics worth acquiring.

Disintegration

A black dragon's breath is the only thing in the game that disintegrates you. There's no other monster, spell, or wand that deals the same damage type.

Defenses: Disintegration resistance (from eating a black dragon corpse or wearing black dragon scale mail) gives full immunity. **Reflection** bounces the beam back, protecting you — but black dragons are themselves disintegration-resistant, so the bounce won't kill them. Magic resistance does **not** help.

Without disintegration resistance, the game tries to save your worn armor before disintegrating you: the breath destroys your **shield** first if you have one, then your **body armor**; only if neither is worn do you die outright (with your cloak and shirt destroyed in the process). So an ordinary shield at least eats one breath for you before being lost. An amulet of life saving still rescues you from the fatal case, though you lose any armor it took.

Genocide

Reading an uncursed scroll of genocide while confused can genocide your own species. Don't do this.

Delayed Deaths

Not every fatal threat kills instantly. Several give you a few turns to react. Knowing the warning signs and the cures can save a run.

Sliming. Being hit by a green slime (or eating its glob, or being digested by one as a polyform) starts a ~10-turn transformation into a green slime yourself — dead. **Cures:** burn the slime off with fire (a wand of fire zapped at yourself, a scroll of fire read at self, a fire trap, a red dragon's breath); polymorph into a flame-bodied or slime-immune form; or cast the spell of *cure sickness*. An **amulet of unchanging** blocks the contagion entirely and even aborts a transformation already underway. Cancelling the green slime in melee prevents new infections but does nothing to a timer already running. Prayer would cure it, but green slime lives in Gehennom where prayer fails, so don't plan on it. Fire is the most reliable cure.

Illness (food poisoning). Eating a rotten corpse or certain attacks (giant ant, etc.) gives you food poisoning, which kills in 10–19 turns (“You feel deathly sick.”). **Cures:** a unicorn horn (apply it), pray, eat a eucalyptus leaf, or vomit (by being satiated and eating more). Vomiting from other causes also cures food poisoning. Poison resistance does NOT protect against food poisoning — that’s *sickness resistance*, a separate intrinsic.

Pestilence’s terminal illness is the harder cousin: vomiting won’t clear it, and the timer is Constitution-dependent (~20+Con turns). The cures that *do* work: unicorn horn, prayer, eucalyptus leaf.

Sinking in lava. Falling into lava without levitation or fire resistance gives you a few turns to escape before you sink and die. Your inventory is also at risk. **Cures:** prayer, levitation (put on levitation boots or a ring), teleport, or just step out if you can. Fire resistance prevents the damage but doesn’t prevent sinking. Lava immersion also destroys most of your inventory.

Drowning (being held). When grabbed by an eel or kraken in water, you have a few turns to escape before drowning. The drown check uses the eel’s tile, so levitation, water walking, and encumbrance status are irrelevant once the grab lands. **Cures:** magical breathing (amulet or spell), kill or teleport the eel before it pulls you under, or avoid water entirely. See Drowning in Ways to Die for the full picture.

Strangulation. Wearing a cursed amulet of strangulation slowly kills you over a few turns. **Cure:** remove the amulet (requires uncursing it first, since cursed amulets can’t be removed: use a scroll of remove curse, holy water, or prayer).

The Displacer Beast

The **displacer beast** (f, blue, 5.0 addition) is a tiger-sized feline with AC –10 and three attacks per turn (4d4 / 4d4 / 2d10). The misleading name: it isn’t displaced in the cloak-of-displacement sense. Its trick is the opposite, when you melee it, half the time it **swaps places with you** instead of taking the hit, which can pull you off Elbereth, out of a doorway, or onto a trap. Ranged attacks (wand, spell, thrown) bypass the swap entirely. It also has **MR 0** — extremely unusual for a level-12 monster, where most peers carry 10–70% resistance — so sleep, paralysis, and charm/taming all land with no

save. Speed 12, so a speed-boosted hero outpaces it. (Don't bother trying to swap it into a moat or lava — the swap only fires if the destination square is survivable for the beast, and water/lava aren't.)

Tame one and you have one of the best pets in the game. AC –10, three attacks (4d4 claw / 4d4 claw / 2d10 bite), speed 12. Charm monster works first try; a scroll of taming with no MR roll to fail is essentially guaranteed. A tame displacer beast will walk into late-game fights and walk out, eating tough hostiles while taking minimal retaliation.

Eating the corpse gives you cloak-style displacement for a few turns: monsters target a phantom image one square off from where you really are and miss accordingly. Note that this is a different mechanic from the beast's own place-swap, despite the shared name: you get the same effect as wearing a cloak of displacement, not the ability to swap places with attackers.

The Genetic Engineer

The **genetic engineer** (Q, green) shares its symbol class with the quantum mechanic but plays differently: where a quantum mechanic *teleports* its target on a hit, a genetic engineer *polymorphs* its target. One claw and, unless you have *Unchanging* or magic resistance, you become something else: same roll as any other uncontrolled polymorph source, with the dramatic message “you are subjected to a freakish metamorphosis.” Engineers also teleport on their own, so range alone won’t save you forever.

Defenses: *Unchanging* (immune), magic resistance (also fully blocks the polymorph), kill it before it closes, or accept the next several turns of the dungeon playing as something else. The engineer has a short cooldown between successful polymorph hits, so the encounter is survivable even without unchanging if you can finish quickly.

The corpse is a tool. Eating a genetic engineer corpse is mechanically identical to eating a doppelganger corpse: the same uncontrolled polymorph, just with louder flavor text. The practical use is the same as the doppelganger’s: tin it, and you have a portable polymorph source. Pair a tin with *polymorph control* and you have a controlled polymorph that survives Gehennom’s hot ground. The first engineer that kills you is a loss; the second one in your bag is a kit.



Divine Relations

Your relationship with your god is one of the most important mechanics in the game. A happy god answers prayers, forgives transgressions, and occasionally sends gift artifacts. An angry god smites you.

Prayer

Praying (#pray) calls on your god for help. When conditions are right, prayer is the single most powerful emergency tool in the game. When conditions are wrong, it can kill you.

The mechanics below are inspired by Matthew Labut's Praying Spoiler, the long-running RGRN reference for the prayer system.

What prayer fixes (in priority order). Your god addresses your problems in a specific order, fixing the most urgent first:

1. Petrification in progress (stoning)
2. Sliming in progress
3. Strangulation
4. Sinking in lava
5. Illness (food poisoning, sickness)
6. Severe hunger (Weak or Fainting)
7. Standing in a stinking cloud
8. Critically low HP (≤ 5 , or below a fraction of maxHP that scales with your experience level: 1/5 at XL 1–5, 1/6 at 6–13, 1/7 at 14–21, 1/8 at 22–29, 1/9 at XL 30+)
9. Lycanthropy
10. Stuck in a wall, collapsing under load, cursed levitation boots, unusable hands (cursed glove + cursed wielded weapon), cursed blindfold

After resolving the major troubles above, your god may also grant additional blessings: clearing minor afflictions (plain hunger, blindness, confusion,

stunning, hallucination, ordinary punishment with iron ball and chain), improving your alignment, or even gifting intrinsics like telepathy or speed.

The requirements for a safe prayer. All of the following must be true:

- Your **alignment** must be non-negative. Killing peacefuls, robbing shops, and other misdeeds reduce alignment. Sacrifice and virtuous behavior raise it.
- Your **luck** must be non-negative. Luck is affected by many things (see Luck and Fortune).
- Your god must not be **angry**. God anger is separate from alignment and accumulates from specific offenses (breaking conduct with your god, desecrating altars).
- The **prayer timeout** must have expired. After a successful prayer, you must wait before praying again. The timeout averages around 450 turns but can range from under 200 to over 700 due to the random formula used. In a genuine emergency (HP critical, starving), there is some forgiveness if your timeout is close to expiring.
- You must not be **polymorphed** into a demon or undead while worshipping a non-chaotic god.
- You must not be in **Gehennom** (unless you worship Moloch, which no standard role does). Your god cannot hear you there. This is one of the things that makes Gehennom so dangerous.
- If you're on an altar, it should be **co-aligned**. Praying on a cross-aligned altar directs your prayer to the wrong god.

When prayer goes wrong. If any requirement is unmet, your god responds with punishment instead of help: loss of alignment, loss of luck, increased timeout, cursing of worn items, or summoning of hostile minions. Severe transgressions (praying to a very angry god) can trigger lightning or disintegration, both potentially fatal.

Practical guidance. Pray when you're about to die and have no other option. Starvation, stoning, illness, and critically low HP are all valid emergencies. Don't waste prayers on minor inconveniences. Before you pray, make a mental check: is my alignment positive? Have enough turns passed? Am I on a co-aligned altar or no altar at all? If you can't answer yes to these, find another solution.

Prayer timeout tracking. The game doesn't show your timeout directly, but you can estimate it. Count roughly 500 turns from your last prayer (more if it went badly). In the early game, when turns are slow and you're fighting one creature at a time, 500 turns pass quickly. In the late game, when you might take 100 actions per level, it takes longer to feel.

Sacrifice

Offering fresh monster corpses at an altar (**#offer**) builds favor with your god. The rules:

- The corpse must be fresh — killed within the last **50 turns**. A corpse older than that has zero sacrifice value (the gods simply ignore it).
- Bigger monsters are more valuable sacrifices.
- The altar must match your alignment, or you're praying to someone else's god (which has its own consequences).
- Same-race sacrifice is forbidden and severely punished. On a lawful or neutral altar it turns the altar chaotic (not co-aligned — only chaotic heroes benefit); on a chaotic altar it summons a demon.

With enough sacrifice credit, your god may gift you an artifact weapon. The first gift comes after relatively modest sacrifice; subsequent gifts require substantially more. Gift artifacts are always aligned to your god and always match a weapon skill you can use.

There is a minimum. In 5.0, not every corpse you drop on the altar moves you toward the next artifact gift. The gods have opinions about what constitutes a worthy offering, and a kobold doesn't make the cut. Fresh corpses of appropriately challenging monsters are what advances your standing. If you've been feeding the altar with early-dungeon sweepings and wondering why the gifts aren't arriving, this is why.

Donating to Priests

A peaceful priest in their own temple accepts donations. **#chat** to them and a prompt appears: *How much will you offer (suggested: X or Y)?* The two numbers are the priest's suggested thresholds for the two reward tiers.

What you get:

- **Clairvoyance** — a few hundred turns of automatic short-range map awareness (you “see” the immediate area around you every few turns without moving). Granted if you offer in the lower tier.
- **Protection** — an intrinsic AC bonus that *stacks* across visits. Granted if you offer in the upper tier. Each successful donation pushes the bonus up by 1 (rarely more), capped at 20. The bonus persists for life, unlike clairvoyance.

The cost. Pay enough and the benefit is yours. The priest’s prompt always shows you the exact ask, which scales with your experience level and how much gold you’re carrying:

- **Clairvoyance:** a randomized 150–250 zorkmids × experience level as the base ask
- **Protection:** twice that — 300–500 zorkmids × experience level

If you walk in carrying far more gold than the baseline, the priest scales the ask up to match — roughly a third of your purse for clairvoyance, two-thirds for protection. A rich hero who hands over only the baseline amount will be politely thanked but not blessed. The prompt always tells you the exact figure, so trust it over any rule of thumb.

The cheapskate penalty. If you offer noticeably less than what’s expected while clearly able to afford more, the priest calls you a Cheapskate and will hold a grudge: the next time you chat with that same priest, the cost will be higher. The penalty stacks if you keep doing it, and it sticks for the rest of the game. Other priests in other temples aren’t affected. Refusing to donate anything at all also costs you alignment with your god.

Practical guidance:

- **Donate early, donate often.** Protection stacks, so 500 zm at XL 1 buys the same AC reduction as 15000 zm at XL 30. Visiting the Minetown temple every time you climb back up from the Mines is a classic stacking ritual.
- **Count gold before chatting.** The priest’s roll is sensitive to what’s in your inventory; drop excess gold on the floor outside the temple before asking, then pick it back up.
- **Cross-aligned priests still accept donations** and still grant the AC and clairvoyance. You miss the alignment bonus and you can’t sacrifice on their altar, but the AC ramp still works.

- **Walk away rather than lowball.** Once the cheapskate flag is set on a priest, it doesn't come off. If the suggested amount is more than you want to part with, decline the prompt entirely rather than offering a token sum.

Altars and Alignment

To convert a cross-aligned altar, sacrifice ordinary fresh corpses on it. Each attempt either flips the altar to your god (success), costs you Luck (failure), or — if your god is already angry — converts *you* to the altar's alignment instead. Better odds at higher experience level. Worth the risk when you need a co-aligned altar for sacrifice gifts, holy water, or BUC testing.

Two things to **never** sacrifice on any altar:

- **A same-race corpse** (humans for most roles; also elves if you're elven). Punished on every altar; on a Chaotic one it summons a demon.
- **A unicorn whose alignment matches the altar.** Counts as an insult to that god.

Crowning

If your alignment record is very high (through sacrifice and good behavior), your god may crown you. Crowning grants:

- A special title (e.g., “Hand of Elbereth” for lawful characters).
- An artifact weapon appropriate to your alignment, if one is available that you can use.
- Intrinsic fire resistance, cold resistance, shock resistance, sleep resistance, poison resistance, and see invisible.
- A class-specific bonus: Wizards get the *finger of death* spell; Monks get *restore ability*.

The catch is that crowning **adds about ~1000 turns of prayer timeout** on top of the usual post-prayer wait, turning prayer into an unreliable emergency tool. If you're sacrificing to fish for an artifact gift, watch the alignment record so you don't trigger a crowning by accident.



Making Friends

The Mazes of Menace are dark, hostile, and full of things that want to eat you. Under those circumstances, a loyal companion is worth more than a bag of gold. Fortunately, the dungeon provides.

Starting Pets

Most roles begin with a faithful pet: a little dog or a kitten, depending on your role. This small creature is more useful than it looks. It follows you between levels (if adjacent when you take stairs), fights alongside you, picks up items, and eats food it finds on the floor. Think of it as a self-propelled, self-feeding trap detector with teeth.

A pet that eats well and fights often will grow. A little dog becomes a dog, then a large dog. A kitten becomes a housecat, then a large cat. A grown large dog or large cat is a genuine combat asset, capable of taking on mid-dungeon threats that would give you trouble.

One more thing: your pet usually avoids cursed items when there's an uncursed alternative, which makes it a *probabilistic* curse-detector. Drop items on the ground and watch what your pet walks past versus what it walks around. If it has no choice, it will still cross the cursed square, but consistent avoidance across many turns is a strong tell.

Feeding and Loyalty

Pets have an invisible tameness score that decreases when they go hungry past the threshold, when you leave them behind on another level for too many turns, or when *you* hit them. (Combat damage from other monsters doesn't reduce tameness.) When tameness hits zero, the pet either goes untame-but-peaceful or turns fully hostile. Feeding is the antidote:

- **Dogs and cats** love tripe rations and most meat

- **Horses** prefer apples, carrots, and other vegetarian fare

Tripe rations are ideal for dogs and cats. You'll find them scattered through the dungeon. Always pick them up, even though they're revolting food for humans. Your pet will adore you for it.

Taming New Creatures

If your starting pet perishes (or you want an army), several methods of taming exist:

- **Throwing food** at a suitable creature: meat for dogs and cats, produce for horses
- **Scroll of taming** or **spell of charm monster** both route through the same handler and tame all eligible creatures within a 3×3 radius. Reading the scroll while confused widens that to 11×11 (but you can't cast the spell while confused).
- **Magic trap effects** occasionally produce taming

Taming isn't limited to small animals: with a scroll of taming or the charm monster spell, you can recruit a purple worm to swallow your enemies whole (its growing tail will sprawl across the room and get in the way of your shots), a dragon to breathe fire at them, a titan to crush them underfoot. The exclusion list is substantial, though: no humans (priests, shopkeepers, watchmen, soldiers, kings), no covetous monsters (the Wizard, liches, masters), no demons (unless you are one), no vault guards, quest leaders, nor minions can be tamed. Unique monsters (Medusa, etc.) also resist.

What Pets Do for You

A well-fed pet earns its keep in several ways:

- **Combat muscle.** A strong pet clears rooms and softens up dangerous monsters before you engage
- **Curse detection.** The old drop-and-watch trick, described above: free, reliable, and available from turn one
- **Shoplifting.** If your pet picks up an item inside a shop and carries it out the door, the shopkeeper blames the animal, not you. This takes

patience (the pet must wander onto the item, then wander back out) but it's the cheapest way to acquire a wand of wishing from a shop

- **Sacrifice fodder.** Monsters your pet kills leave corpses you can sacrifice on altars, exactly as if you'd killed them yourself

Training apport (fetching). Hand-feeding your pet builds a score called apport. A pet with high apport will pick up nearby items and bring them to you. This is what makes pet-shoplifting practical: once your pet returns dropped items reliably, you can drop something at the shop counter, walk out, and trust the pet to follow with the goods. Pair it with a magic whistle (below) to yank a loaded pet to your side from anywhere on the level.

Upgrading your pet. Three moves matter most.

- A **magic whistle** teleports every tame creature on the level to a spot next to you each time you blow it. Distance doesn't matter; trapped pets get freed in the process.
- Tame a **warhorse** early (throw apples or carrots) and you have a fast, hard-hitting mount before mid-game.
- Late in the run, **polymorph your pet** into a stronger form. Titans, balrogs, and gray dragons are popular targets; a gray dragon has magic resistance and resists further polymorph, so it locks in. Cast polymorph carefully: random self-poly on the pet can downgrade it, and a polymorphed steed stops being saddled.

Keeping Your Pet Alive

Pets die from the same things you do: traps, poison, powerful monsters, drowning in water. Keep an eye on your companion's health (; to farlook) and don't lead it into fights it can't win. A dead pet is not just a loss of utility; it's a cold feeling in the pit of your stomach.

If you change levels and your pet isn't adjacent, it won't follow. Your pet is still alive on the previous level, but its loyalty is ticking down. Go back for it before it forgets you were friends.

If you see "*You have a sad feeling for a moment*" — that's different. That message means a pet of yours just died offscreen on another level, usually one you left behind that got into a fight it couldn't win.

Current editions have added two things that veteran pet-owners should know.

First: your pet eats for a reason beyond loyalty. The same corpse mechanics that grant you resistances apply to pets as well. A pet that dines on the right monsters will gain resistances: fire resistance, cold resistance, whatever the dungeon's terrible buffet was offering. A well-fed pet is also a better-armored one. This is not something you can reliably engineer, but it's a reason to let your pet eat rather than scooping up every corpse yourself.

Second, and more importantly: pets can now be revived. If your companion falls in battle, stand on its corpse at a co-aligned altar and pray. The gods, in their occasional mercy, may return it to you. This is a last-resort miracle, not a renewable strategy: your prayer timeout, your alignment, and a certain amount of luck all factor in. But it means that the large cat you've carried since level 3, the one who has earned names and battle scars and the terrified respect of every dungeon denizen you've walked past, is worth a detour to the nearest temple before you write it off. The dungeon kept this secret for a long time. Now you know.



Gear and Provisions

A Practical Identification Strategy

Here is the central puzzle of the Mazes, and the thing that kills more promising expeditions than any monster: you will find dozens of items, and you won't know what most of them are.

That potion might heal you or it might make you hallucinate. That scroll could enchant your armor or destroy it. That ring could grant you invisibility or slowly starve you to death. In the Mazes, ignorance is not bliss. Ignorance is death by unidentified wand.

Every game, the dungeon shuffles the deck. Potions, scrolls, wands, rings, amulets, and spellbooks are all given randomized appearances. The “milky potion” in this game might be healing; in your next game it might be paralysis. The only things that stay consistent between games are the item classes themselves (a ! is always a potion, a ? is always a scroll) and the prices, which turn out to be the single most powerful identification tool you have.

The Identification Flowchart

```
.start{fill:#E8F4FD;stroke:#3B6FA0;stroke-width:2}.decision{fill:#FFF4E6;stroke:#3B6FA0;stroke-width:2}.action{fill:#F0F9E8;stroke:#5B8E3A;stroke-width:2}.final{fill:#FCE8E6;stroke:#5B8E3A;stroke-width:2}.label{font-size:18px;fill:#1f2933;text-anchor:middle}.startlbl{font-size:19px;font-weight:600;fill:#1f2933;text-anchor:middle}.branch{font-size:16px;font-style:italic;fill:#5a5a5a}.edge{fill:none;stroke:#5a5a5a;stroke-width:1.5}Found an itemCan you reach an altar?yesDrop it. Check BUC.noIs your pet nearby?yesDrop it. Pet avoids it?yes: it's cursed; no: it's safenoCan you reach a shop?yesCheck price.noIs it a wand?yesEngrave-test it.noSpare ring or potion with a sink?yesDrop ring or dip potion.noIs it safe to use-test?yesTry it carefully.noRead a scroll of identify.
```

The identification flowchart: cheapest method first, scroll of identify last.

Blessed, Uncursed, Cursed (BUC)

Before you can worry about *what* an item is, you need to know *what condition* it's in. Every item in the Mazes is blessed, uncursed, or cursed (BUC for short), and the difference matters far more than you'd think. The gods have opinions about your equipment, and those opinions have consequences:

- A **blessed** scroll of identify reveals at least 2 items in your pack (more with positive Luck), and one time in five reveals the whole pack. An *uncursed* scroll IDs one or two items; a *cursed* scroll IDs only the scroll itself the first time you read one of that type, and one item per subsequent cursed read.
- A **cursed** piece of armor bonds to your skin like it has abandonment issues. You cannot remove it until you lift the curse.
- A **cursed** potion of gain level interprets “gain a level” in the most literal architectural sense: you rocket through the ceiling to the floor above, instead of gaining an experience level.

Blessed items are helpful beyond their description, uncursed items work as advertised, and cursed items find creative ways to ruin your day. A blessed luckstone passively improves your luck; a cursed one drags it down. A cursed scroll of teleportation sends you to a random *level* instead of teleporting within the current one. You get the idea.

You don't see BUC status by default (Priests are the exception: they sense it naturally, which tells you something about clerical paranoia). But there are several reliable ways to check:

Altar testing. Drop an item on an altar:

- An amber flash means blessed.
- A black flash means cursed.
- No flash means uncursed.

This is free, fast, and unlimited. If you find an altar early, use it heavily.

Pet testing. Your pet won't step on cursed items. If you drop something and your dog walks around it, it's cursed. If the dog walks over it (or picks it up), it's safe. Not as precise as an altar, but works anywhere.

Holy water. Dipping an item in blessed water (holy water) will uncure a cursed item or bless an uncursed one. Dipping in cursed water (unholy water) curses an uncursed item or unblesses a blessed one. You make holy

water by praying on a co-aligned altar while carrying potions of water; it's precious in the early game, so save it for items you've already identified.

Scroll of identify. A blessed scroll identifies at least 2 items in your pack, more with positive Luck, with a 1-in-5 chance to ID the whole pack outright. An uncursed scroll IDs one or two items per read. A cursed scroll IDs only itself the first time you read one of that type, then one item per cursed read after.

The Price Is Right

Shopkeepers are, without exaggeration, your most important identification tool. Every unidentified item has a fixed base price that depends on what it actually is. When you pick up an item in a shop, the shopkeeper quotes you a price derived from that base price, modified by your Charisma and the shopkeeper's markup.

Shopkeeper pricing was first documented in detail by Gregory Bond's Shopping Spoiler, HTML-formatted by Kate Nepveu and hosted on steelytips.org. David Damerell's Object Identification Spoiler expanded the price-based identification techniques. The mechanics below draw from both.

The key insight: items in the same category that share a base price are in the same **price group**. If you know the price, you can narrow down the possibilities enormously, sometimes to just two or three candidates.

Pick up an item and note the quoted price. With average Charisma (11-15), buy price equals base and sell is half base. Low Charisma pushes buy up ($\times 2$ at $\text{Cha} \leq 5$); high Charisma pulls it down ($\times \frac{1}{2}$ at $\text{Cha} \geq 19$). Sell prices don't change with Charisma, but if shopkeepers see you as a **mark**, then you can only sell at a third of base, and you'll have to pay $\frac{4}{3}$ to buy. Three visible cues count you as a mark: wearing a **dunce cap**, playing a **Tourist** below XL 15, or wearing a **Hawaiian shirt visibly** (no body armor or cloak over it). The rest of this guide refers to them collectively as *Tourist*. You don't need to memorize the formulas; what matters is grouping by price tier.

Two further wrinkles affect unidentified items. About a quarter of unID'd items carry an extra $\frac{4}{3}$ buy surcharge, fixed per item, so a given scroll's surcharge status is consistent across shops. And about a quarter of shopkeepers

are “unfamiliar” with unID’d merchandise and offer only 3/4 of normal on sell, fixed per shopkeeper, so once you’ve tested one unID item you know the rule for all unID sales at that shop. Either wrinkle can shift a quoted price into an adjacent tier, so when in doubt check the surrounding tiers too.

Angry. A shopkeeper you’ve previously angered (fired a wand from a doorway, attacked them, picked up an unpaid item while broke) and then made amends (paid the bill, fled and let them calm down) becomes peaceful again but keeps a permanent +33% buy surcharge on every item. Paying the bill clears the bill but not the surcharge; that flag sticks for the rest of your visits to that shopkeeper. Sell prices are unaffected.

The price tables for each item class follow. These are your field reference for shopping trips.

Quoted-price conversion

The per-class tables below show **buy prices at Cha 11–15 with no Tourist markup** (the baseline). To recover the base price from a quoted price under different conditions, find the row that matches your situation and read across; or, given a base price you suspect, read the price you’d be quoted. *T Cha* rows are the same Cha bands with the Tourist surcharge stacked on.

Modifier	Mult	20	50	60	80	100	150	175	200	300
Cha 6–7	×1.5	30	75	90	120	150	225	263	300	450
Cha 8–10	×1.33	27	67	80	107	133	200	233	267	400
Cha 11–15	×1.00	20	50	60	80	100	150	175	200	300
Cha 16–17	×0.75	15	38	45	60	75	113	131	150	225
Cha 18	×0.67	13	33	40	53	67	100	117	133	200
Cha 19+	×0.5	10	25	30	40	50	75	88	100	150
T Cha 6–7	×2.0	40	100	120	160	200	300	350	400	600
T Cha 8–10	×1.78	36	89	107	142	178	267	311	356	533
T Cha 11–15	×1.33	27	67	80	107	133	200	233	267	400
T Cha 16–17	×1.00	20	50	60	80	100	150	175	200	300
T Cha 18	×0.89	18	44	53	71	89	133	156	178	267
T Cha 19+	×0.67	13	33	40	53	67	100	117	133	200

Numbers are NetHack’s integer-rounded prices, not the round-number multiplier reapplied. Sell offers are unaffected by Charisma, so they aren’t shown;

an unangry shopkeeper offers $\frac{1}{2}$ of base on a sell ($\frac{3}{8}$ on unidentified items from an unfamiliar shop).

Scroll Prices

Price	Scrolls
20	identify
50	light
60	blank paper, enchant weapon
80	enchant armor, remove curse
100	confuse monster, destroy armor, fire, food detection, gold detection, magic mapping, scare monster, teleportation
200	amnesia, create monster, earth, taming
300	charging, genocide, punishment, stinking cloud

The \$100 group is crowded, which makes scroll price-ID less precise than other categories. But you can still narrow things down. If a scroll is in the \$20 group, it's identify. Period. That's one of the most useful scrolls in the game and you just found it for free.

Potion Prices

Price	Potions
20	healing
50	booze, fruit juice, see invisible, sickness
100	confusion, extra healing, hallucination, restore ability, sleeping, water
150	blindness, gain energy, invisibility, monster detection, object detection
200	enlightenment, full healing, levitation, polymorph, speed
250	acid, oil
300	gain ability, gain level, paralysis

Healing sits alone at \$20, uniquely identifiable from the price tag. Water is always the "clear" potion, so if you see "clear potion" you know what it is without even checking the price. The \$50 group is tricky because sickness and see invisible are in there together (one very good, one very bad). The \$200 group is packed with excellent potions.

Ring Prices

Price Rings

100	adornment, hunger, protection, protection from shape changers, stealth, sustain ability, warning
150	aggravate monster, cold resistance, gain constitution, gain strength, increase accuracy, increase damage, invisibility, poison resistance, see invisible, shock resistance
200	fire resistance, free action, levitation, regeneration, searching, slow digestion, teleportation
300	conflict, polymorph, polymorph control, teleport control

The \$300 group is extremely informative: only four rings live there, and three of them (conflict, polymorph control, teleport control) are among the most powerful in the game.

Wand Prices

Price Wands

100	light, nothing
150	digging, enlightenment, locking, magic missile, make invisible, opening, probing, secret door detection, slow monster, speed monster, stasis, striking, undead turning
175	cold, fire, lightning, sleep
200	cancellation, create monster, polymorph, teleportation
500	death, wishing

If a wand costs \$500, you are having a very good day.

Amulet Prices

All amulets have a base price of \$150 except the cheap Amulet of Yendor imitations (\$0). Price won't ID them; you'll need other methods.

The Engrave Test (Wands)

The single most useful wand-identification trick costs you nothing. Apply a wand by engraving on the floor with it (command: **E**, then select the wand). What happens tells you what the wand is:

What you see when you engrave	Wand type
<i>"A lit field surrounds you"</i>	light
<i>"The floor is riddled by bullet holes"</i>	magic missile
<i>"Gravel flies up from the floor"</i>	digging
<i>"A few ice cubes drop from the wand"</i>	cold
<i>"Flames fly from the wand"</i>	fire
<i>"Lightning arcs from the wand"</i> (may blind)	lightning
<i>"The bugs on the floor stop moving!"</i>	sleep or death
You feel self-knowledgeable	enlightenment
Floor reveals secret features	secret door detection
Monsters appear next to you	create monster
Pre-existing engraving randomizes	polymorph
Pre-existing engraving "vanishes"	cancellation, make invisible, or teleportation (test against floor with no prior writing to disambiguate)
<i>"The wand unsuccessfully fights your attempt to write!"</i>	striking (this exact phrasing is striking-only)
<i>"The bugs on the floor slow down!"</i>	slow monster
<i>"The bugs on the floor speed up!"</i>	speed monster
You write in the dust with no special-case message	nothing, undead turning, opening, locking, probing, or stasis — zap-test to disambiguate
Wish prompt appears	wand of wishing (yes, engrave gives you the wish — don't be afraid to engrave the suspected \$500 wand)

The engrave test costs one charge per wand but preserves the rest. With one zap you can sort most wands into clear categories. For wands that just write in the dust, you'll need further testing: zap them at a monster or in a safe direction.

Warning: In 5.0, cursed wands may **explode** when used to engrave. BUC-test your wands before engraving with them.

The Sink Test (Rings)

If you find a sink, you can drop a ring down it. Each ring type produces a characteristic message, identifying the ring. See Sinks under Points of Interest for the full message-to-ring table; the short version is that searching and slow digestion come back to you (free identification), and every other ring is consumed.

Use-Testing (The Careful Way)

When you don't have access to a shop or a sink, you can sometimes figure out what an item is by using it carefully. Here's the approach for each category:

Potions. The safest test is to throw a potion at a monster and observe the effect. Throwing avoids the risk of drinking something lethal. If a potion heals the monster, it's some kind of healing potion. If the monster speeds up, it's speed. If the monster becomes invisible, well, you've learned something (and now have an invisible monster to deal with).

You can also dip items into potions. Dipping a stack of poisonable ammunition (arrows, crossbow bolts, darts, shuriken, or sling stones) into a potion of sickness will poison it, confirming the potion's identity (it won't poison a sword or any non-missile weapon). Dipping a unicorn horn into a potion of **confusion**, **hallucination**, or **blindness** turns it into water; dipping into a potion of **sickness** turns it into fruit juice.

Scrolls. Reading is risky. Some scrolls (destroy armor, amnesia, punishment) are outright harmful. The safest approach is to price-ID first, then read scrolls from safe price groups. If you must test blind: take off your armor before reading a scroll that might be destroy armor. Read from a position where teleportation won't be disastrous.

Confused reading produces different effects for many scrolls and is sometimes useful. A confused scroll of remove curse **randomizes the BUC of your uncursed items** (about a quarter end up blessed, a quarter end up cursed, and half stay uncursed) and leaves already-cursed items cursed. A non-blessed confused scroll only touches your worn and wielded gear (plus loadstones and active leashes); a blessed confused scroll touches your whole inventory. So it's a way to get a few cheap blessings on worn items, not a

curse-removal tool. Don't read it confused if you need to uncure something.

Rings. First, confirm the ring is not cursed (altar or pet test). Then put it on. Many rings produce an immediate message or visible effect: you start levitating, you become invisible, you feel stronger. If nothing obvious happens, check your stats and inventory for subtle changes (protection, searching). Take it off quickly if you start feeling hungry faster than normal (hunger ring) or if monsters seem to be approaching more aggressively (aggravate monster).

Amulets. Most amulets are safe to wear briefly. Put it on, wait a few turns, take it off. The dangerous ones (strangulation, restless sleep) are usually cursed, so check BUC first. An amulet of ESP reveals itself if you go blind while wearing it (you'll see monsters as brain-shapes). Amulet of reflection is trickier to detect, but you'll notice it when a ray bounces off you.

Armor. Magical armor reveals itself when worn: speed boots make you faster, a cloak of invisibility makes you invisible. But trying on unknown armor in a shop is dangerous: if it's cursed it welds itself on, you can't drop it, and the shopkeeper still expects payment. Worse, the auto-cursed types (fumble boots, levitation boots, gauntlets of fumbling, helm of opposite alignment) masquerade as the desirable ones. **Verify BUC before wearing unknown armor in a shop.** Without an altar, your options are the pet-step test, Priest intrinsic BUC sense, or a scroll of identify from your own inventory.

Each type of special armor has a **randomized appearance**, so the same "snow boots" that were safe levitation in your last game might be jumping or fumble boots this time. The four shuffled pools are:

- 4 magical **helms** share 4 appearances: plumed / etched / crested / visored helmet → one of helmet, helm of caution, helm of opposite alignment, helm of telepathy. (Helm of brilliance is always "crystal helmet"; dunce cap and cornuthaum both look like "conical hat"; that pair *is* a fixed pun.)
- 4 magical **cloaks** share 4 appearances: tattered cape / opera cloak / ornamental cope / piece of cloth → one of cloak of protection, invisibility, magic resistance, or displacement.

- 4 **gloves** share 4 appearances: old / padded / riding / fencing gloves → leather gloves or one of the three gauntlet types (fumbling, power, dexterity).
- 7 magical **boots** share 7 appearances: combat / jungle / hiking / mud / buckled / riding / snow boots → one of speed, water walking, jumping, elven, kicking, fumble, or levitation boots.

The good news: prices *don't* shuffle, and prices within each pool fall into informative tiers.

Armor Prices

Price	Type	Possibilities
8	Boots	elven (stealth), kicking
30	Boots	fumble, levitation (both commonly cursed!)
50	Boots	speed, water walking, jumping (all desirable)
8	Gloves	leather gloves (only)
50	Gloves	gauntlets of fumbling, power, or dexterity
50	Cloaks	cloak of protection or displacement
60	Cloaks	cloak of invisibility or magic resistance

A \$30 boot is the warning sign: both candidates are common auto-curse items and putting them on without BUC-checking can ruin a run. A \$50 boot is almost always one you want. A \$60 cloak is one of two excellent cloaks, but you still need BUC and a free body before wearing. \$8 boots and \$50 gauntlets are the cases where you can't tell stealth-from-kicking or fumbling-from-power by price alone. Try them on (BUC-checked) and watch for the messages.

Gray Stones: Four Stones, One Correct Answer

Gray stones deserve their own section because they look identical but have wildly different value. There are four types:

Price	Stone	Effect
1	flint or loadstone	flint is useless ammunition; loadstone weighs 500 units, usually cursed, and won't drop once carried. Use the kick test (loadstones don't scoot).

Price	Stone	Effect
45	touchstone	Identifies gems when rubbed. Very useful.
60	luckstone	Preserves luck. Essential.

The problem: all four look like “a gray stone” until identified. Here’s how to tell them apart:

The kick test. Kick an unidentified gray stone on the floor. If it scoots away normally, it’s not a loadstone. A loadstone is abnormally heavy and resists being kicked.

The pick-up test. Loadstones are cursed when they generate, and a cursed loadstone refuses to be dropped at all — the game prints “For some reason, you cannot drop the stone!” and the stone stays in your pack. If you pick up a gray stone and it weighs you down suspiciously, try to drop it. If you can’t, you’re stuck with a cursed loadstone until you can uncure it (holy water, scroll of remove curse, prayer) — then drop it.

The price test. If you can reach a shop: a \$60 gray stone is a luckstone. A \$45 gray stone is a touchstone. A \$1 gray stone is flint or a loadstone.

The rub test. Apply (a) a gray stone to a gem in your pack. A touchstone produces a colored-streak message — and if the touchstone is **bles**sed (or you’re an Archeologist or Gnome holding an uncursed one), the streak also identifies the gem. Other gray stones produce similar streak messages, so a streak alone doesn’t prove touchstone; an *identification* result does. A cursed touchstone can shatter the gem.

Location clue. The luckstone at Mine’s End is guaranteed. If you find a gray stone at the bottom of the Mines, it’s almost certainly the luckstone. Bless-test it at an altar to confirm (the guaranteed one is always uncursed).

The rule of thumb: if you find a gray stone, don’t pick it up until you’ve tested it. A loadstone can ruin your encumbrance, and if it’s cursed, you’re stuck with it until you find a way to uncure. Kick it first. Check BUC second. Then pick it up.

Naming What You've Learned

As you gather clues, use the `#name` command to track what you know. You can **call** an entire item class by a name you choose. For example, if you've determined that "fizzy potions" are in the \$200 price group, call them "fizzy=\$200" so you don't forget. If you later throw one at a monster and it speeds up, you can rename the class to "speed."

This habit of annotating your discoveries is what separates adventurers who die on level 8 from adventurers who reach the Castle. The dungeon doesn't keep notes for you. You have to do it yourself.

Identification by stacking. When you pick up an item, the game merges it into an existing slot only if the two are *identical*: same type, same enchantment, same BUC, same erodeproofing. So whether a new item stacks with one you already understand leaks information for free. When a merge actually teaches you something the game says so explicitly: "*You learn more about your items by comparing them.*" That message is your cue that the merge propagated a known property (BUC, enchantment, erosion) to the previously unknown side. Two same-appearance items that *don't* merge are a different potion, a different BUC, or one side has been diluted or eroded.

A Practical Strategy

All of these techniques combine into a workflow. Here's what a seasoned traveler does on a typical descent:

At an altar (priority one). Ferry everything you've found to the altar. Drop each item. Sort your pack into blessed, uncursed, and cursed piles. Wield or wear the blessed stuff. Stash or discard the cursed stuff.

At a shop (priority two). Pick up and put down unidentified items to get price quotes. Group them by price. Cross-reference with the tables above. Suddenly half your inventory is narrowed to two or three possibilities.

Engrave-test your wands as soon as you find them. It's fast, it costs only one charge, and it immediately sorts wands into categories. A wand that digs the floor is digging. A wand that drops ice cubes is cold. Simple.

Experiment cautiously with the rest. Wear non-cursed rings one at a time. Throw potions at monsters. Read scrolls from safe price groups after removing your armor.

Save your scrolls of identify for the items that resist other methods: amulets (all the same price), spellbooks (dangerous to read if unknown), and the one stubborn potion in the \$50 group that you can't quite pin down.

The system is about reducing uncertainty with the cheapest, safest method first: altars and shops are free, engrave-testing costs one charge, use-testing costs more and carries risk, and scrolls of identify are the precious last resort.



Provisions and Dining

Of all the things that kill adventurers in the Mazes of Menace (the dragons, the liches, the cockatrices, the inexplicable decision to kick a sink), none is quite as embarrassing as starving to death while carrying forty thousand gold pieces. Hunger is the dungeon's most persistent clock: every turn you spend costs nutrition, and when the tank hits empty, you faint. Faint a few times without eating and you die. It is, in the grand tradition of roguelikes, completely your fault.

How Hunger Works

Your nutrition starts at 900 and ticks down steadily. The rate depends on what you're doing:

- **Base consumption** costs 1 point per turn (less while sleeping).
- **Regeneration** (from a ring or intrinsic) costs extra on odd turns.
- **Encumbrance** costs extra on odd turns if you're **stressed** or worse (burdened alone is free).
- **Rings** cause additional hunger while worn. Two rings drain faster.

When nutrition drops below certain thresholds, you get warnings:

Nutrition	Status	Effect
above 1000	Satiated	Overfull. Eating more risks choking.
151–1000	Normal	Fine.
51–150	Hungry	Warning message. Time to eat.
1–50	Weak	Strength penalty (-1 Str). Pray if possible.
0 or below	Fainting	Collapse randomly. Eat NOW or die.

Eat when you get the “Hungry” message; don’t wait for “Weak.” If you hit Fainting and have no food, pray to your god (see Divine Relations). Prayer cures hunger if your god is willing to help.

What to Eat

Eat the things you kill. The single most important food fact for new players: unless you're playing a vegetarian role (Monk, or any role pursuing a vegan/vegetarian conduct), the bulk of your nutrition comes from **monster corpses you leave on the floor**. Every fresh kill is a meal. Don't burn food rations while there's a freshly dead rat at your feet. A few rules:

- Eat corpses within 30 to 50 turns of the kill. Past that they risk being tainted, which means food poisoning (lethal without treatment).
- Never eat old corpses. If in doubt, don't eat it.
- Some corpses grant intrinsic resistances (poison resistance from killer bees, fire resistance from fire giants, etc.). Eat these deliberately, even when you're not hungry — see the table below.
- Some corpses are harmful (floating eyes paralyze you, green slimes turn you into slime, cockatrice corpses kill you). Know which corpses are safe before eating.

Food rations are the emergency backup. 800 nutrition, weight 20, common in shops. Carry two or three for the times you don't have a fresh kill in front of you. You don't need to hoard them.

Lembas wafers are the gold standard: 800 nutrition at only 5 weight, the best ratio in the game. Elven characters find these more often.

Tripe rations are terrible for you (your character retches) but pets love them. Save tripe for your pet.

Tins are preserved food that never spoils, but they are also a *trap if you're sloppy about where you open them*. Opening a tin is an occupation: you cannot act while you work, and a monster can wander up and attack you mid-open. A tin opener finishes in zero or one turn, a dagger in three, an axe in six, and bare hands in as many as fifty turns of helpless effort. Don't pop a tin in a corridor next to a sleeping room. Blessed tins are the one exception: they open in zero or one turn no matter the tool (instantly with a blessed tin opener). A tin of spinach increases your Strength.

Vegetarian characters have to live on rations, lembas, fruits, and the small set of non-meat corpses (fungi, molds, lichens, jellies, plus eggs). **Vegans** lose the eggs, so they're stricter still: rations, lembas, fruits, and plant corpses

only. Plan ahead — the corpse-pile strategy doesn't work for either, so rations and fruit are the budget items to hoard.

Dangerous Foods

Cockatrice corpse: instant death by stoning. Never eat this.

Acidic corpses (acid blob, etc.): damage unless acid resistant.

Poisonous corpses: damage and stat drain unless poison resistant.

Rotten corpses: food poisoning. Pray immediately if affected.

Cannibalism (eating your own race): costs 2 to 5 luck and gives the aggravate monster intrinsic. Cavemen and orcs are exempt.

Useful Corpse Effects

Eating for intrinsics is the highest-leverage habit in the early and mid game. Each resistance is a *chance* per eat, not a guarantee, so eat *every* one of these you find, not just the first. Two tables follow: meat corpses and vegetarian-safe corpses, each ordered roughly by when you'll first meet the creature on a typical descent.

Meat corpses:

Corpse	Effect
Newt	May restore 1 to 3 mana
Killer bee	Poison resistance
Lizard	Cures stoning in progress
Floating eye	Telepathy (but paralyzes you too)
Fire ant	Fire resistance
Wraith	Gain an experience level
Yeti	Cold resistance
Tengu	Teleportitis / teleport control
Giant (any)	Increase strength
Winter wolf	Cold resistance
Stalker	Invisibility (and see invisible)
Black pudding (glob)	Cold, shock, and poison resistance
Fire giant	Fire resistance + Strength
Disenchanter	STRIPS a random intrinsic. Never eat.

Corpse	Effect
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Vegetarian-safe corpses (those marked † are also vegan):

Corpse	Effect
Acid blob †	Acid and stoning resistance
Yellow mold †	Poison resistance
Brown mold †	Cold and poison resistance
Red mold †	Fire and poison resistance
Quivering blob †	Poison resistance
Gray ooze (glob)	Fire, cold, and poison resistance
Blue jelly †	Cold and poison resistance
Brown pudding (glob)	Cold, shock, and poison resistance
Gelatinous cube †	Fire, cold, shock, and sleep resistance

A gelatinous cube is the highest-density source of ascension-kit intrinsics in the game; poison resistance off any of the early corpses is the most important single intrinsic to bank.

Sprig of wolfsbane. Not a corpse but the same shelf. Eating one cures lycanthropy outright. If you're heading anywhere were-things roam (the Mines, the Quest for some roles), carry a sprig or two. It weighs almost nothing.

Eat the puddings, cubes, molds, and blobs. They look like inedible terrain, but every one of them yields an intrinsic when eaten. Puddings and acid blobs leave **globs** rather than corpses (a 5.0 food-handling detail that doesn't change the strategy), and the globs of one color stack and shrink slowly, so a pile of brown-pudding globs is a re-rollable chance at shock resistance.

Food Strategy

1. Eat fresh corpses as your primary food source.
2. Save food rations and lembas wafers for emergencies.
3. Eat intrinsic-granting corpses deliberately (even if not hungry).
4. Pray when Weak or Fainting if you have nothing to eat.
5. Buy food from shops when you can afford it.
6. Don't carry more food than you need. It's heavy.



The Apothecary

The dungeon is full of mysterious bottles. Ruby liquids, milky fluids, smoky concoctions: each one a small gamble between salvation and catastrophe. The colors are shuffled every game, so the “bubbly potion” that healed you last time might polymorph you this time. Identification is everything.

The Potion Table

As with all randomized items, price is your best friend. A shop visit narrows a mysterious bottle from “could be anything” to a short list of candidates:

Price	Potions
20	healing
50	booze, fruit juice, see invisible, sickness
100	confusion, extra healing, hallucination, restore ability, sleeping, water
150	blindness, gain energy, invisibility, monster detection, object detection
200	enlightenment, full healing, levitation, polymorph, speed
250	acid, oil
300	gain ability, gain level, paralysis

Water is the oddity in the \$100 group: it always appears as “clear potion,” identifiable on sight. Don’t underestimate it; water is the raw material for holy water, which is the foundation of everything.

Key Potions

Healing, extra healing, full healing. The healing chain, and your lifeline in combat. Extra healing is the workhorse: it always cures blindness and (non-cursed) also cures sickness in addition to restoring HP. Non-cursed extra and full healing raise your maximum HP if the heal would otherwise overflow; blessed versions give the biggest boost. You can never have too many of these.

Gain ability. When blessed, raises *all* your stats by 1. Uncursed raises a random stat. This is liquid gold: save every one until you can bless it.

Speed. One non-cursed quaff and you're permanently faster for the rest of the game; blessing only stretches the temporary timer that overlays the intrinsic. Speed is arguably the single most important buff in NetHack; the difference between moving at normal speed and fast speed is the difference between trading blows and hitting twice before they swing once. In 5.0, the wand of speed monster no longer grants permanent speed when self-zapped, only a temporary burst of 50–74 turns. The potion is the real prize.

Holy water. Not a potion you find: a potion you *make*. Drop uncursed water on a co-aligned altar, pray, and the gods bless it for you. Holy water can then bless any item you dip into it. This is the engine that drives your entire inventory: blessed scrolls of identify, blessed potions of gain ability, blessed scrolls of enchant weapon. You will never have enough holy water.

Gain level. Raises your experience level by 1. Useful for reaching quest eligibility quickly, or converting into something better through alchemy.

Identifying a polymorph potion. A clean test: dip a single arrow or dart into an unknown potion. If the arrow turns into a different item, the potion was polymorph and identifies itself. You spend one arrow and one potion; you save the gamble of quaffing it.

Alchemy

Here's where potions get interesting. Dip one potion into another and you might create something better, or you might cause an explosion. Most combinations are duds, but the useful recipes are worth memorizing:

Dip this	Into this	Result
Healing	Gain energy/level	Extra healing
Extra healing	Gain energy/level	Full healing
Full healing	Gain energy/level	Gain ability
Fruit juice	Gain energy/level	See invisible
Speed	Healing	Extra healing
Booze	Gain energy/level	Hallucination
Levitation	Enlightenment	Gain level (2/3)

The chain from healing → extra healing → full healing → gain ability via gain energy or gain level is the core alchemy sequence, and it's extraordinarily powerful. A handful of common healing potions and a gain energy or two can be transmuted into the rarest potions in the game. Treat every gain energy potion like the catalyst it is.

A side-loop worth knowing: **Levitation + Enlightenment → Gain level (2/3 chance, or nothing 1/3)**. Both inputs are reasonably common and individually low-value, but the output is one of the catalysts that feeds the main healing chain. If you find a stack of each, this is a way to manufacture gain-level potions rather than wait for the dungeon to drop them.

A note on the current state of dungeon chemistry. The old alchemy trick (dilute a large stack of potions by dipping them in water, then convert the whole diluted stack at once) no longer works. Current editions cap diluted dips at two potions per operation. The chain from healing up to gain ability is still there; you just do it in small batches with undiluted inputs. Think of it as artisanal alchemy rather than industrial production.

The explosion risk is real: roughly 10% on any non-water combination. An alchemy smock (if you find one) reduces this to about 1 in 30, which is the difference between “risky hobby” and “acceptable profession.” Do your chemistry in an isolated room, away from your stash, and never dip a cursed potion into another. The dipping potion (not the one it goes into) is the one the game tests for explosion, and a cursed dip detonates every time. The dungeon is consistent about this if nothing else.

Unicorn Horn Interactions

A unicorn horn dipped into certain potions purifies them:

- **Blindness, confusion, hallucination** → uncursed water
- **Sickness** → fruit juice

This turns dangerous potions into useful raw materials. The water can be blessed into holy water; the fruit juice can be alchemized into see invisible. Nothing is wasted in a well-run dungeon pharmacy.



The Scroll Rack

Scrolls are the dungeon's single-use spells: read once, triggered, gone. They appear with absurd randomized labels ("ZELGO MER," "DAIYEN FOOELS," "PRATYAVAYAH") that stay consistent within a game but mean nothing until you identify them. The labels are part of the charm. You'll develop superstitious favorites.

The Scroll Table

Price-identification is especially powerful for scrolls, because the cheapest scroll (base 20) is always identify, the one you need most:

Price	Scrolls
20	identify
50	light
60	blank paper, enchant weapon
80	enchant armor, remove curse
100	confuse monster, destroy armor, fire, food detection, gold detection, magic mapping, scare monster, teleportation
200	amnesia, create monster, earth, taming
300	charging, genocide, punishment, stinking cloud

The \$60 group is treasure (enchant weapon lurks there alongside innocent blank paper). The \$80 group is equally good: enchant armor and remove curse, two scrolls you'll always want more of. The \$100 group is the danger zone, a grab-bag mixing magic mapping and teleportation with destroy armor. And at \$300, you'll find both genocide (the game's nuclear option) and punishment (a ball and chain permanently attached to your ankle). Choose wisely.

Key Scrolls

Identify. The bread and butter of dungeon life. Blessed identify reveals multiple items at once (with positive luck, always at least two). You will never have enough of these.

Enchant weapon / enchant armor. The path to endgame power. Uncursed enchant *weapon* raises by +1. Blessed raises by up to 3, less the more the weapon is already enchanted (no more than +1 once the weapon is +6 or higher). And there's a catch: at +6 or higher, each read has a 2/3 chance of destroying the weapon outright. **Safe ceiling: +5.** Enchant *armor* raises by a small random amount that's larger when armor is unenchanted, larger again for elven or non-magic armor, and +1 extra when blessed. Once worn armor exceeds +3 (or +5 for elven / Wizard's Cornuthaum), each further enchant attempt can destroy the armor; the scroll "evaporates" your gear. Blessed scrolls don't bypass this cap.

Remove curse. Frees you from cursed equipment. Uncursed version works on worn and wielded items only; blessed version uncurses your entire inventory. Every adventurer has a "put on a cursed ring" story. This scroll is the happy ending.

Charging. Recharges wands and rechargeable tools. Save these for your wand of wishing: one charge means one more wish. Blessed charging restores more charges. Each recharge has an $n^3 / 7^3$ chance of the wand exploding (where n is the count of previous recharges): 0% on first, 0.3% on second, 2% on third, 8% on fourth, 19% on fifth, 36% on sixth, 63% on seventh — and on the eighth, always. Wand of wishing is the exception: it explodes 100% of the time on the second recharge, so recharge it exactly once and no more.

Genocide. The nuclear option. Uncursed eliminates a single species; blessed wipes an entire monster class from the game forever. Liches (L) are the canonical blessed target. **Never blessed-genocide a class that contains your own race or role.** Dwarves are h, Gnomes are G, Elves and Humans are @, Orcs are o; a blessed scroll targeting one of those ends the game with "killed by a scroll of genocide". (That makes the popular "wipe mind flayers" pick a Dwarf trap, since mind flayers are also h.) Read one while confused and you genocide your own role's species the same way. Read carefully.

Reverse genocide. A cursed scroll of genocide doesn't remove its target; it spawns 4 to 6 of the named species at your feet. The named species must be one that can ordinarily be created. Naming wraiths gives you a corpse pile for level recovery; naming mind flayers buys an Int-fed feast if you're polymorphed into one; naming an easy-to-tame creature gives you instant pet candidates. Don't try unique monsters (the gods refuse).

Magic mapping. Reveals the entire level layout; blessed also shows secret doors. Invaluable in Gehennom's maddening mazes, where mapping by hand could take a lifetime you don't have.

Scare monster. The trick: don't read it. Drop it on the floor and stand on it. It works like a permanent Elbereth, frightening most monsters away. The catch: pick it up after it's been dropped and it crumbles to dust. So choose your standing spot wisely.

Teleportation. Uncursed teleports you randomly on the level. Cursed or confused reading sends you to a random dungeon level. With teleport control, *you* choose where you land — the game's most flexible escape hatch.

Confused Reading

Here's a trick the dungeon doesn't advertise: many scrolls do something completely different when read while confused. Some of these alternate effects are *better* than the normal ones:

Confused destroy armor, *if cursed*, doesn't destroy anything: it erode-proofs a piece of armor. (Uncursed or blessed strips erodeproofing instead.) One of the best tricks in the game.

Confused enchant armor / enchant weapon, *if uncursed or blessed*, erode-proofs the item instead of enchanting. Useful when you need protection from rust more than another +1.

Confused remove curse has a 25% chance of blessing *or* cursing each uncursed item. Risky, but it's a clever way to create holy water if you confuse-read while carrying uncursed potions of water.

Confused taming widens the scroll's reach from a 3×3 area around you to 11×11. The trick is scroll-only; confused charm monster just fizzles.

Confused teleportation sends you to a random *dungeon level* instead of a random spot on this floor. Useful as a panic button, dangerous if you're shallow and don't want to skip the early game.

Confused gold detection detects *traps* on this level instead of gold. Faster and safer than the search command.

Confused light creates a small posse of cancelled, friendly yellow lights around you (or black lights, if the scroll is cursed). They die quietly and can't harm you.

Confused charging restores Pw, and if you're already at full, *raises your max Pw* by 4–16 (6–24 blessed). A spellcaster's permanent buff if you can spare the scroll. Cursed reading zeroes your Pw instead.

Confused scare monster wakes nearby sleepers and you hear sad wailing in the distance. The opposite of helpful. Don't read this for an emergency.

Confused genocide genocides your own role. This kills you. Don't get confused at the wrong moment.



Wands and Staves

Wands are reusable magical items that produce directed effects when zapped. They come in three types: **ray wands** fire a beam in a direction that bounces off walls, **beam wands** affect what they hit in a straight line, and **non-directional wands** affect the area around you.

The Wand Table

Price	Wand	Type	Max Charges
100	Light	NODIR	15
100	Nothing	BEAM	15
150	Digging	RAY	8
150	Enlightenment	NODIR	15
150	Magic missile	RAY	8
150	Make invisible	BEAM	8
150	Opening	BEAM	8
150	Probing	BEAM	8
150	Secret door detection	NODIR	15
150	Slow monster	BEAM	8
150	Speed monster	BEAM	8
150	Stasis	NODIR	15
150	Striking	BEAM	8
150	Undead turning	BEAM	8
150	Locking	BEAM	8
175	Cold	RAY	8
175	Fire	RAY	8
175	Lightning	RAY	8
175	Sleep	RAY	8
200	Cancellation	BEAM	8
200	Create monster	NODIR	15
200	Polymorph	BEAM	8
200	Teleportation	BEAM	8

Price	Wand	Type	Max Charges
500	Death	RAY	8
500	Wishing	NODIR	3

Key Wands

Wishing. The most valuable item in the game. Each zap grants one wish. In 5.0, wands of wishing generate with only **1 charge** and can be recharged once (and only once) to a maximum of 1 additional charge. This means the Castle wand of wishing typically yields 2 wishes plus a possible wrested third, a significant reduction from older versions where it could provide 5 to 7. Plan your wishes carefully before you find one.

Death. Fires a death ray that instantly kills most things it hits. Reflected by reflection. Blocked by magic resistance. One of the best offensive tools in the late game.

Digging. Essential utility. Dig through walls to create shortcuts, dig down to escape dangerous situations, dig through rock to reach vaults and hidden areas. Every ascension kit should include a wand of digging.

Teleportation. Zap monsters to send them somewhere else on the level. Zap yourself to teleport. Enormously useful for escaping trouble or removing a dangerous monster from your path.

Fire, cold, lightning. Offensive ray wands that bounce off walls. Fire burns scrolls and spellbooks on the floor. Cold freezes water (useful for creating paths). Lightning blinds monsters.

Cancellation. Removes special properties from items and monsters. A cancelled monster loses most of its special attacks. Do NOT put this wand in a bag of holding (it will explode the bag). Keep it separate in your main inventory.

Polymorph. Transforms monsters into random other monsters and items into random other items of the same class. Can be used creatively (polymorph a pile of junk armor hoping for dragon scale mail, polymorph a weak monster hoping for a useful corpse). Risky but powerful.

Make invisible. Turns a target (or yourself, if you zap it reflexively) invisible. In older editions, self-zapping granted a permanent invisibility intrinsic, which made this a coveted find. In 5.0, it gives you 31–45 turns of temporary invisibility. Still useful for slipping through a dangerous area or turning a fight in your favor, but not a permanent upgrade. For lasting invisibility, you want a ring of invisibility or a cloak. The wand is now a tactical tool rather than a build enabler: think of it as “invisibility on demand for the next minute” rather than “invisibility forever from one lucky find.”

Stasis. A new 5.0 wand that freezes every monster on the level for **10–30 turns**. No ray, no aim, no message — just a hush. Use it when you’re surrounded and need a free moment to engrave Elbereth, drink a potion, change weapons, or just walk past. The silence on engraving makes it harder to identify by the engrave test, but if you sit on a charge for a fight you’ll know.

Identification by Engraving

The engrave test (described in A Practical Identification Strategy) is the fastest way to sort wands. Every wand type produces a distinctive result when used to engrave on the floor.

Kieron Dunbar’s “Identifying Wands by Zapping” spoiler, originally posted to RGRN, describes a systematic protocol for narrowing down wand identity through controlled experiments. The approach below is adapted from his checklist.

Before you start writing on the floor: in 5.0, a *cursed* wand used to engrave may explode, so BUC-test before you test (see The Engrave Test (Wands) for the full safety procedure).

Beyond Engraving: Systematic Wand Testing

The engrave test sorts most wands immediately, but a few produce ambiguous results. For those, a systematic testing protocol helps:

Step 1: Note the wand category. When you engrave, the result tells you whether the wand is NODIR (non-directional), RAY, or BEAM (immediate). This alone cuts the possibilities dramatically.

- **NODIR wands** (light, enlightenment, create monster, secret door detection, stasis, wishing): Most reveal themselves through the engrave-test message. Light creates a lit field. Enlightenment makes you feel self-knowledgeable. Create monster says “bugs appear.” Wishing prompts you for a wish. **Stasis** is deliberately silent on engraving — the C code hides it among the other silent wands so the engrave test can’t single it out.
- **RAY wands** (digging, magic missile, fire, cold, lightning, sleep, death): Digging riddles the floor with holes. Fire, cold, and lightning produce obvious elemental effects. Magic missile riddles the surface with **bullet holes**. **Sleep and death** both produce the same “the bugs on the surface stop moving!” message — price-test to tell them apart (death is \$500).
- **BEAM wands** (everything else): The engrave test distinguishes most of them. **Cancellation and make invisible** erase the engraving in place. **Teleportation** moves it elsewhere on the level (look around to spot it). **Polymorph** rewrites your engraving as a different random one. **Striking** interrupts with “*The wand unsuccessfully fights your attempt to write!*” **Slow monster** and **speed monster** make the bugs on the surface slow down or speed up, respectively. Five BEAM wands — **nothing, undead turning, opening, locking, probing** — produce *no engrave message at all*. Combined with the silent NODIR stasis (above), a wand that engraves in silence is one of six possibilities; the zap tests below will resolve them.

Step 2: Safe zapping tests. For wands that remain unidentified after engraving, zap them at safe targets:

- **Zap at a locked chest or door.** A wand of opening unlocks it. A wand of locking locks it. A wand of striking breaks it.

- **Zap at a corpse on the floor.** A wand of undead turning revives the corpse to its original species (and animates any carried corpses too). A wand of polymorph transforms it.
- **Zap at a tame or weak monster.** Speed monster makes it faster. Slow monster makes it slower. Make invisible makes it vanish. Probing reveals its stats.
- **Zap at a cancellable item** (a potion, a figurine). Cancellation will dull it. Note: cancellation does NOT affect booze, fruit juice, or oil, so don't use those as test subjects.

The three “vanishes” wands. Cancellation, make-invisible, and teleportation all print “*The engraving vanishes!*” on the engrave-test. To tell them apart, drop a known item and zap each candidate: make-invisible makes the item invisible; teleportation moves it elsewhere on the level; cancellation dulls its magic. (Polymorph isn't in this group: it rewrites your engraving as a different random one, which is its own giveaway.)

Step 3: When in doubt, check the price. If testing hasn't resolved the wand, its shop price narrows the field further. A \$150 wand is one of thirteen types. A \$200 wand is one of four. A \$500 wand is death or wishing, and you should be very careful with it either way.

Recharging

Wands can be recharged with a scroll of charging. Each recharge increases the risk of the wand exploding. The formula is (recharges cubed) / 343, so:

- First recharge: 0.3% explosion chance.
- Second: 2.3%.
- Third: 7.9%.
- Seventh: 100%.

Use blessed charging for the best results — except on a wand of wishing, which follows its own rules. A fresh wand of wishing is always generated with **exactly one** charge. A scroll of charging adds **one more** wish whether blessed or uncursed; blessing doesn't help here, and a cursed scroll strips the wand to zero like any other. You can recharge once safely; a second attempt is a **guaranteed explosion**. So the lifetime cap on a single wand of wishing

is two wishes reliably, or three if you successfully wrest the final charge at the end.

Wresting

When a wand has 0 charges, you can still try to zap it. There is a 1/121 chance of “wresting” one final charge from the wand before it turns to dust. This is a last resort, but it works on wands of wishing too.

Polymorph as a Tool

Self-polymorph is one of the most interesting tools in the game. A wand of polymorph zapped at yourself, a potion of polymorph, the polymorph self spell, or stepping on a polytrap all do the same thing: roll a new form for you. With **polymorph control** (the ring or intrinsic) the game lets you *choose* the form, which is where the real fun begins.

- **Travel where your legs can't.** A xorn phases through walls. An eel breathes underwater. A vampire becomes a bat or a fog cloud and slips under doors. A floating eye drifts past traps you can't disarm.
- **Bring your own resistances and attacks.** A red dragon form gives you fire breath. A brown mold form burns anything that hits you in melee. A purple worm swallows your problems whole. Most monster powers are yours when you wear their shape.
- **Grow a bigger body.** A stronger form rolls a new max HP and your current HP scales with the ratio. A dying Wizard at 50/100 wakes up at 200/400 as a fresh titan.
- **Escape cursed body armor.** A *bigger* form breaks out and destroys the suit. A *smaller* form drops it intact into your inventory, where you can holy-water it back to neutral.
- **Eat what you can't.** A metallivore form eats iron bars. A green dragon shrugs off poisonous corpses.

Caveat: cursed polymorph items strip control, and rough transformations can hit you with system shock. Don't be at 5 HP when you reach for the wand.



Rings and Amulets

Two ring fingers. One neck. These are the most constrained equipment slots in the game, which makes choosing what to wear a genuine strategic decision. Both rings and amulets have randomized appearances, and some of the best items in the game hide behind unassuming descriptions like “granite ring” or “circular amulet.”

The Ring Table

Price	Ring	Notes
100	Adornment	+CHA, chargeable
100	Hunger	Increases hunger (auto-curse)
100	Protection	+AC, chargeable
100	Protection from shape changers	Useful against werebeasts
100	Stealth	Reduces noise
100	Sustain ability	Prevents stat drain
100	Warning	Shows nearby monsters
150	Aggravate monster	Bad (auto-curse)
150	Cold resistance	Resist cold attacks
150	Gain constitution	+CON, chargeable
150	Gain strength	+STR, chargeable
150	Increase accuracy	+hit, chargeable
150	Increase damage	+dmg, chargeable
150	Invisibility	You become invisible
150	Poison resistance	Immune to poison
150	See invisible	See invisible creatures
150	Shock resistance	Resist electric attacks
200	Fire resistance	Resist fire attacks
200	Free action	Immune to paralysis
200	Levitation	Float in the air
200	Regeneration	Heal faster (costs hunger)
200	Searching	Auto-search each turn

Price	Ring	Notes
200	Slow digestion	Reduces hunger
200	Teleportation	Random teleports (auto-curse)
300	Conflict	Monsters fight each other
300	Polymorph	Random polymorphs (auto-curse)
300	Polymorph control	Choose polymorph form
300	Teleport control	Choose teleport destination

Rings marked “auto-curse” generate cursed 90% of the time. If you slip on a ring and can’t remove it, you’ve just learned what auto-curse means the hard way.

Ring of aggravate monster deserves a footnote in the “niche uses of terrible things” category. In 5.0, wearing it roughly doubles the effective dungeon level for purposes of monster generation, so creatures well above your current depth start appearing. This is obviously catastrophic if you forget you’re wearing it. But for a chaotic player who needs high-difficulty sacrifice fodder for the next artifact gift, deliberately wearing the ring to force harder spawns (then removing it) is a calculated risk with an actual payoff. The key word is “deliberately.” The ring is auto-cursed 90% of the time. If it goes on and won’t come off, the fact that you’re now generating liches on dungeon level 8 is no longer a feature.

The rings that matter most: Free action is arguably the single best ring in the game: paralysis is death in the late game, and this ring makes you immune. Teleport control turns random teleportation from a nuisance into on-demand transportation. Conflict makes monsters attack each other instead of you, which is devastating on crowded levels (though it also turns your pets hostile). Slow digestion lets you go indefinitely between meals.

In 5.0, a blessed potion of polymorph grants you polymorph control for that specific transformation: you choose the form, no ring required. This makes the ring of polymorph control less of a critical acquisition: you no longer need to find it or wish for it just to do a single controlled polymorph. The ring remains useful if you want ongoing control for repeated transformations, but it’s no longer a hard prerequisite for the opening act of any polymorph strategy. Save that wish for something else.

The hidden cost: Every ring you wear increases your hunger rate. Two rings drain food noticeably faster. The veteran habit is to keep rings in inven-

tory and slip them on only when needed: free action before fighting mind flayers, conflict before entering a throne room. Economy of fingers is an art.

Amulets

Amulets are simpler in theory but harder to identify: they all cost \$150, so price is no help. You'll need to wear-test or use a scroll of identify. The stakes are high, because the range runs from "saves your life" to "slowly strangles you to death":

Amulet	Effect
Life saving	Revives you once from death, then crumbles
Reflection	Reflects ray attacks
Magical breathing	Survive underwater and without air
ESP	Detect monsters via telepathy
Unchanging	Prevents involuntary polymorph
Versus poison	Poison resistance
Flying	Grants flight (new in 5.0)
Guarding	+2 AC and +2 MC (new in 5.0)
Strangulation	Slowly kills you (always cursed)
Restful sleep	Puts you to sleep randomly (usually cursed); grants +1 HP/turn regen while asleep

Life saving is the crown jewel. When you die (any kind of death) it triggers, revives you at full HP, and crumbles to dust. Wear it whenever you're going somewhere dangerous. Take it off when you're safe. You only get the one miracle.

Reflection is excellent if you didn't get a shield of reflection from Perseus's statue or elsewhere. Wearing it as an amulet frees up your shield slot for a small shield or two-weapon fighting.

Guarding provides +2 AC and +2 magic cancellation (MC). This is a new addition in 5.0 that neatly solves the MC puzzle: pair it with a cloak of magic resistance (MC1) and you reach MC3, freeing you from needing the less versatile cloak of protection.

Magical breathing prevents drowning, which sounds niche until you reach Medusa's level (surrounded by water) or the Plane of Water (entirely underwater). Then it's existential.

Flying is the late-addition cousin of levitation: you stay in the air the same way, but you can still pick things up and you can choose to drop down on your turn. The under-appreciated bonus is that **your steed flies with you**. A flying warhorse skips over moats, fountains, pools, and the Castle's drawbridge entirely — a fast Knight can cross Medusa's island and the Castle from edge to edge without worrying about the water at all. Stack with boots of speed and a wand of speed monster on the mount and you have a terrifying cavalry unit.

Restful sleep puts you to sleep randomly and is usually cursed, which should tell you everything you need to know about when to put it on unexamined. However, in 5.0, wearing it while asleep grants +1 HP per turn via accelerated regeneration, stacking with your normal healing. In a fully secured room with the door spiked shut and nothing actively trying to kill you, this turns a nearly useless item into a slow but functional field hospital. The conditions required (safety, time, and nothing better to do) describe a situation you rarely find in the Mazes. When you do, the amulet is less embarrassing to wear than it looks.



Tools of the Trade

The (symbol covers the dungeon's most eclectic category: pickaxes, magic lamps, unicorn horns, musical instruments, crystal balls, and bags that eat other bags. Some of the most powerful items in the game hide in this grab-bag.

Containers

Container	Weight	Special
Sack	15	Basic storage
Oilskin sack	15	Protects contents from water
Bag of holding	15	Reduces weight of contents dramatically
Bag of tricks	15	Creates monsters when opened (not a bag)
Large box	350	Comes with 0 to 3 items (0 to 5 if locked)
Chest	600	Comes with 0 to 5 items (0 to 7 if locked)
Ice box	900	Preserves corpses from rotting

Note the weights. Sacks are 15 (carry one). Boxes and chests are furniture, not luggage: a large box weighs 350, a chest 600, an ice box 900 — comparable to your *entire* carrying capacity. Use them as floor stash, not as something to drag from level to level.

The **bag of holding** deserves special mention because it transforms how you play. A blessed bag reduces the weight of everything inside to roughly one quarter, meaning you can carry your entire potion supply, your backup armor, your scroll library, and still have room for loot. Almost every ascending player carries one. Sokoban's prize is a bag of holding half the time; otherwise wish for one when you can.

A warning: **never** put a wand of cancellation, another bag of holding, or a charged bag of tricks inside a bag of holding. The resulting magical explosion scatters your carefully curated inventory across the floor (in older

editions it *destroyed* everything!). Either way, it's a game-ending mistake that every veteran has made exactly once.

If you find a *cursed* bag of holding (in a bones pile, perhaps), don't open it. Drop it on the floor and zap a wand of cancellation *at the bag from outside*. Cancellation uncurses items it touches, and the explosion rule only triggers on insertion, not on a zap. You'll have a safe, uncursed bag.

Carrying capacity

Your carrying capacity is roughly $25 \times (\text{Strength} + \text{Constitution}) + 50$, capped at 1000. Average human stats land you near 950; a low-Str spellcaster might start closer to 700. As you load up, the status line walks through these tiers:

Tier	When	Cost
Unencumbered	weight at or below capacity	None
Burdened	up to about $1.5 \times$ capacity	Status flag, but movement and nutrition fine
Stressed	up to about $2 \times$ capacity	Extra hunger every odd turn
Strained	up to about $2.5 \times$ capacity	Worse hunger, harder to dodge water
Overtaxed	up to about $3 \times$ capacity	Bad
Overloaded	beyond $3 \times$ capacity	You can't even pick anything else up

Practical rule: stay **Unencumbered** in normal play, accept **Burdened** during loot runs, and never linger at **Stressed** or worse without a reason. The bag of holding is the standard answer to the encumbrance problem; carrying everything inside one reduces the effective weight to roughly a quarter, which is why veteran players treat finding one as a turning point in the run.

Running out of inventory letters. Weight isn't the only limit. Your inventory has **52 slots** (a–z plus A–Z), and a 53rd item hits "*Your pack is too full.*" Stackable items consolidate into a single slot only when the game can tell they're the same thing — five identified scrolls of identify share one letter, but identified and unidentified scrolls of the same type stay in separate slots, and weapons of different enchantments don't merge. So clutter is usually an identification problem in disguise: the more you ID, the more your inventory consolidates. The bag of holding doubles as the answer here too — items inside any container don't count against your 52, so a stash of twenty potions in a BoH costs you a single letter. The `#adjust` command

lets you swap items between letters, force-merge stacks that didn't merge, or split a stack to a new letter — purely relabeling, no game effect.

One 5.0 hazard that you will need to be aware of: **intelligent monsters can now loot unlocked containers**. They can remove items, carry containers away, and unlock chests with keys. If you've been leaving your secondary stash in an unlocked chest on a partially-cleared level while you scouted ahead, stop. The Castle chest in particular (containing the wand of wishing) can be emptied by the level's residents if you leave them time and opportunity. Clear levels before abandoning valuables, and **keep your most important containers locked**. The dungeon has gotten better at wanting what you have.

Unlocking Tools

The dungeon is full of locked things, and brute force is noisy and slow. A **skeleton key** is the gold standard (70%+ success on doors, 75%+ on boxes). A **lock pick** is respectable. A **credit card** is the worst but still better than kicking. Always carry one of these. The weight is negligible and the utility is constant.

Skeleton keys and lock picks can also **lock** what they can unlock, so they double as your way to relock a chest after stashing loot. Credit cards are unlock-only.

Light Sources

Oil lamps and **candles** light dark corridors, which is pleasant but not essential. The real prize is the **magic lamp**: rub it and there's a 1-in-3 chance the djinni emerges, then a chance it grants you a wish — 80% if the lamp is blessed (so ~27% wish per rub overall), less if it isn't. Try again on the same lamp until the djinni shows. Never, ever use a magic lamp for light. That's like using a winning lottery ticket as a bookmark.

The **Candelabrum of Invocation** is a unique candelabra found in Vlad's Tower. It's one of three items needed for the invocation ritual to enter Moloch's Sanctum. You'll need seven candles to fill it, so start hoarding candles when you find them.

Musical Instruments

Music has power in the Mazes. Any tonal instrument (wooden flute, magic flute, tooled horn, frost or fire horn, bugle, or harp) can play the passtune at the Castle drawbridge — you’ll find the notes nearby, so listen carefully. A **magic harp** charms monsters into tameness. A **magic flute** puts them to sleep. A **drum of earthquake** creates pits around you, which is as chaotic as it sounds.

Non-magical instruments (wooden flute, leather drum) produce noise but no special effects, useful only for confusing the issue.

Other Notable Tools

Tool	Use
Pickaxe / mattock	Dig through walls and floors
Unicorn horn	Cure confusion, blindness, sickness, hallucination, stunning, vomiting, deafness
Stethoscope	Check HP and status of a monster
Tin opener	Open tins in one turn
Tinning kit	Preserve corpses as tins
Blindfold	Voluntarily go blind (useful for telepathy)
Towel	Wipe cream pie from face, use as blindfold
Magic marker	Write scrolls and spellbooks on blank paper
Crystal ball	Pick a glyph class per gaze (objects, traps, monsters, etc.); each gaze answers one question
Bell of Opening	Invocation item; carried by your quest nemesis, looted from their corpse
Leash	Tie a pet to you so it follows through stairs

The **unicorn horn** is the dungeon’s all-purpose first-aid kit. Apply it to cure confusion, blindness, sickness, hallucination, stunning, vomiting, and (new in 5.0) deafness: most of the status ailments that matter. Carry one at all times. If you don’t have one, getting one should be near the top of your priority list.

Bless your horn. A blessed horn can fix up to seven ailments in a single application; an uncursed horn maxes out at three, with a 35% chance of doing nothing even when you have troubles to fix. A cursed horn will *inflict*

a random ailment from the same list (including the new deafness one), so be sure of bless status before applying. Horns don't get used up, so a non-emergency test apply is free.

A 5.0 caveat: the unicorn horn **no longer restores lost ability scores** the way it used to. Drained Strength, Intelligence, Wisdom, and so on now require a *potion of restore ability* (or its spell) to bring back. The horn remains the universal cure for *status* problems, but not for attribute drain. Earlier guides that described it as a complete cure-all are out of date; budget for restore ability separately.

The **magic marker** is a printing press for scrolls (and, more expensively, spellbooks). A fresh marker has 30-99 charges; one non-cursed scroll of charging restores it to at least 50 (more if the scroll is blessed), but only once. The second recharge attempt always fails. Each write costs roughly half to all of the target scroll's basecost: magic mapping 4-7 charges, identify 7-13, enchant weapon / enchant armor / charging 8-15, teleportation 10-19, and **genocide** 15-29. Spellbooks cost about $10 \times$ spell level: a level-3 book averages ~22 charges, a level-7 ~52.

To write a scroll intentionally you must have **identified** it first. Writing by appearance gives a random scroll of that appearance, which is usually wasted charges. If charges run out mid-write, scrolls disappear entirely (paper + charges wasted); a spellbook's paper survives but the writing fades.

The big-ticket writes for an ascension kit are scrolls of **genocide** (three of these wipe the worst monster letters L, &, and h out of the game, though uniquely-named demon lords survive any class genocide; see Genocide for the race-trap warning), **charging** (a blessed one restores one additional wish to an empty wand of wishing for 8-15 charges very well spent, though a second charging attempt always explodes the wand), and **enchant weapon** / **enchant armor** for the +7 ascension kit. A well-used marker can produce a meaningful share of your ascension kit.



The Armory

Weapons and armor are the bread and butter of combat. Your choice of equipment determines how hard you hit, how well you dodge, and what special resistances you carry. This section covers the strategy of choosing equipment; the Weapons Tables and Armor Tables appendices give the full stats for every item.

Armor and AC

Armor Class (AC) starts at 10 and decreases as you add protection. Lower is better. Each point of AC reduces the chance of being hit. At AC -10 or below, you're quite difficult to damage with physical attacks.

The key armor slots:

Slot	Primary pick	Specialty pick
Body	Splint mail, banded mail	Dragon scale mail (two extrinsics)
Cloak	Cloak of protection	Cloak of magic resistance
Helmet	Helm of caution (early game)	Helm of telepathy / helm of brilliance
Gloves	Gauntlets of power	Gauntlets of dexterity
Boots	Speed boots	Water walking boots, levitation boots
Shield	Shield of reflection	Small shield (for spellcasters)

The **helm of caution** is new in 5.0: it grants *warning*, the same intrinsic the ring provides, in the helmet slot. Warning fills the screen with colored markers indicating nearby threats by danger level (white for the least threat, through red, with magenta for the worst) without you having to see the monsters yet. It is the ideal early-game helm slot: cheap (50 zm), light, and a real edge against ambushes. Late game it competes with helm of brilliance (Wizards) and helm of telepathy (everyone), but the warning bonus stays useful all the way down.

Dragon scale mail is the endgame body armor of choice. In 5.0, most colors provide two extrinsic resistances (gray and silver provide only the named one). Gray dragon scale mail provides magic resistance and is a popular wish target. Silver provides reflection. Black provides disintegration resistance and drain resistance (one of two non-artifact sources, alongside the shield of drain resistance). Green provides poison resistance and sickness immunity.

To get dragon scale mail: kill a dragon, pick up the scales it drops, then read a (non-cursed) scroll of enchant armor while wearing them (they transform into scale mail); or wish for the mail directly.

Speed boots are worth wishing for. Being faster than your enemies means you get more turns — more chances to attack, cast spells, or run away.

Cloak of magic resistance provides magic resistance in the cloak slot and frees up other slots for different resistances. However, be aware that since 3.6, **magic cancellation (MC) values were overhauled**: the cloak of magic resistance now provides only MC1, not MC3. The **cloak of protection** is now the only single item that provides MC3, which blocks 90% of monster special attacks (down from 98% in older editions). A ring of protection now contributes +1 MC, and the new amulet of guarding provides +2 MC, giving you more ways to assemble full magic cancellation coverage.

For the AC, MC, weight, cost, and granted-power numbers on every piece of armor in the game, see the Armor Tables appendix.

Weapons

Weapon choice depends heavily on your role and skill caps.

Weapon	Damage (sm/lg)	Notes
Long sword	d8 / d12	Lawfuls can dip for Excalibur
Katana	d10 / d12	Best base damage for a one-hander
Silver saber	d8 / d8	+d20 vs silver-hating monsters
Crysknife	d10 / d10	Excellent damage, fragile
Tsurugi	d16 / d8+2d6	Two-handed, bisects small monsters
Runesword	d4 / d6+d4	Chaotic weapon
Battle-axe	d8+d4 / d6+2d4	Two-handed, good damage
Rubber hose	d4 / d3	No, seriously, don't use this

Excalibur (long sword dipped in a fountain while Lawful) is one of the best weapons: +d5 to hit and +d10 damage, level drain resistance, automatic searching. For Lawful characters, getting Excalibur early is a priority.

Silver saber deserves special mention. Many endgame threats (demons, undead, werecreatures) are vulnerable to silver. A silver saber does an extra d20 damage against them, making it one of the best late-game weapons.

Your quest artifact is often your primary weapon or at least worth carrying for its properties. Check what your role's artifact does.

For the full damage/weight/cost numbers on every weapon in the game, see the Weapons Tables appendix.

Enchantment

Weapons and armor can be enchanted using scrolls of enchant weapon and enchant armor. Each scroll adds +1 (uncursed) or potentially more (blessed). For **weapons** there's no destruction limit at all: above +9 the scroll just becomes less likely to add a point, but the weapon is never lost. **Armor** is different — above +3 each new scroll has a chance to destroy the item (above +5 for “special” armor like elven pieces, or the Wizard's cornuthaum). Blessed scrolls give more points per read but don't change the destruction threshold; cursed scrolls can subtract enchantment and shouldn't be used for enchanting at all.

Erosion and Proofing

Weapons and armor can be damaged by rust (iron items), fire (organic items), and corrosion (copper items). A badly damaged item provides less AC or damage.

To fix erosion, read a confused scroll of enchant weapon (for your weapon) or confused scroll of enchant armor (for a random worn armor piece). This erodeproofs the item permanently without changing its enchantment. It also repairs any existing damage.

You can also slow erosion without magic. Coat an armor piece with grease (apply a can of grease). The grease layer also makes the piece slippery to monster steal and to grab attacks, but it wears off after a few hits.

Dragon Scale Mail

Killing a dragon doesn't always drop full scale mail. Often you'll find loose **scales** instead. Scales wear in the body slot just like the mail and carry the color's full intrinsic property (gray gives magic resistance, silver reflection, and so on, identical to the mail). The trade-off is AC: scales give +3 where the mail gives +9. Same weight.

To upgrade scales into scale mail: wear the scales and read a non-cursed scroll of enchant armor. The scales merge and harden into the corresponding dragon scale mail at +0 (or higher if blessed; a blessed scroll also blesses the result). A cursed scroll just gives the usual bad enchant effect; no merge.

For which color to chase, see A note on dragons.



Curses and How to Break Them

Sooner or later, you will put on something cursed. Maybe it's a ring you didn't test. Maybe it's boots from a bones level. Maybe a monster touched your inventory and you didn't notice. However it happens, you're now wearing an item that refuses to come off, and it's probably doing something terrible. The curse problem is one of the dungeon's quieter ways to kill you.

How Items Get Cursed

- **Born that way.** Some items generate cursed most of the time (rings of teleportation, rings of polymorph, amulets of strangulation; anything the dungeon thinks is funny)
- **Bones inheritance.** Items on a bones level have an 80% chance of being cursed. That tempting armor on the dead adventurer's corpse? Probably trapped
- **Monster interference.** Certain monsters can curse items in your inventory
- **Confused remove curse.** Reading it confused has a chance of *cursing* items instead of uncursing them
- **Unholy water.** The evil twin of holy water

Effects of Cursed Items

- **Cursed armor and rings** bond to you and can't be removed: a cursed ring of teleportation means random teleports you can't stop, and a cursed pair of levitation boots means you can never touch the ground again
- **Cursed weapons** can't be unwielded. Hope you like that -3 orcish dagger
- **Cursed potions and scrolls** often do the opposite of what you want, or a weakened version of the normal effect

- **Cursed tools** malfunction spectacularly. A cursed bag of holding *doubles* the weight of its contents instead of reducing it
- **Cursed food** is unpleasant but rarely fatal. Small mercies

Detecting Curses

Prevention is better than cure. Test items *before* wearing them:

- **Altar test.** Drop an item on an altar. A black flash means cursed. This is free, instant, and should become instinct
- **Pet test.** Your pet refuses to step on cursed items. Drop and observe
- **Scroll of identify.** Always reveals the full status
- **Formal price-ID via shop appraisal.** Shopkeepers don't reveal BUC directly, but the sell-back offer they make narrows the item to a few possibilities; combined with the altar test you can often pin it down

(Temple donation does *not* reveal BUC — that's a common spoiler myth. Donating to a priest grants temporary clairvoyance and a Protection bonus, but inventory BUC stays hidden.)

Removing Curses

When prevention fails, you have three remedies:

- **Scroll of remove curse.** Uncursed removes curses from worn and wielded items. Blessed uncurses your entire inventory — a real relief when the curse problem has gotten out of hand
- **Holy water.** Dip a cursed item in holy water and it becomes uncursed. Simple, reliable, and reason enough to stockpile holy water
- **Prayer.** A pleased god uncurses your worn items as a side benefit of answering prayer. Don't waste a prayer solely on this, but it's a nice bonus

Stuck in cursed body armor? Polymorphing into a form too small for the suit drops it off into your inventory (curse and all), even though it would normally refuse to come off. From there, dip in holy water and re-wear. See Polymorph as a Tool.

Always carry holy water and a scroll of remove curse. The moment you find yourself stuck with cursed levitation boots over a moat, you'll understand why veterans never leave home without them.



Mastery

Spellcasting

Magic in the Mazes is less “wave a wand and sparkles happen” and more “laboriously study a crumbling book, hope it doesn’t go off in your face, and then set things on fire with your mind.” Spells are reusable abilities learned from spellbooks. Unlike scrolls (consumed on use) or wands (limited charges), spells can be cast repeatedly as long as you have mana (Pw, power) and the spell hasn’t expired from your increasingly overtaxed brain.

Learning Spells

Read a spellbook to learn the spell it contains. Reading takes several turns and can fail. A failed reading can teleport you, take your gold, blind, confuse, or poison you, blow up in your face for HP damage, or randomly curse one of your items. A book that survives failures can be retried.

The book’s level decides which effects are on the table. A level-1 book can teleport you somewhere random when you fail to read it. A level-2 book might aggravate nearby monsters instead. Misread a level-3 book and it can blind you for 250 to 350 turns. A level-4 book can take all your gold, and level 5 can leave you confused for 16 to 22 turns. Misread a level-6 book and you may be contact-poisoned: gloves take corrosion damage, bare hands take 1 or 2 points of Strength plus 1d10 HP (1d6 with poison resistance). And a level-7 book can have an exploding rune. Magic resistance blocks the explosion; without it, you take 2d10+5 damage. Practical rule: don’t read books you can’t afford to fail.

The chance of successfully reading a spellbook depends on the **spell level**, your **Intelligence**, and your **experience level**. The exact formula is $\text{Int} + 4 + \text{XL}/2 - 2 \cdot \text{level}$ versus a roll of 1d20, so read 20 or more always succeeds, 10 is a coin flip, and anything below that is dicey. Reading a level-7 spell at Int 15, XL 2 gives a read score of 6: only a 30% chance of success. Lenses add +2. A **blessed** spellbook bypasses the check entirely and always

succeeds. A **cursed** spellbook fails automatically and applies one of the failure effects above.

Here's a rough guide to what you can safely read:

Spell Level	Minimum Int + XL needed	Who can read it reliably
1	~10	Almost anyone, early game
2	~14	Most characters by mid-game
3	~18	Wizards easily, others with effort
4	~22	Wizards with decent stats
5	~26	Wizards with boosted Int
6	~30	Wizards with serious investment
7	~34	Only well-built Wizards

The “Minimum Int + XL” column means the sum of your Intelligence and experience level. With 18 Intelligence at level 14, your sum is 32, so you can reliably read up to level 6 spells. **A blessed book skips the difficulty check entirely and always succeeds**, no matter what your Int and level are — which is one reason to save holy water for your hardest unread spellbooks.

Wizards identify books by training. In 5.0, advancing a spell school skill to each rank automatically reveals the appearances of spellbooks in that school: unskilled unlocks level-1 appearances, basic level-3, skilled level-5, expert level-7. A Wizard starts knowing all level-1 appearances and level-3 in attack and enchantment, which means they begin the game with a meaningful identification advantage in their core schools.

So training your spell schools pays off twice: better casting *and* free book-ID. The unknown book you've been carrying since level 5? Train up the right school and suddenly you know what it is. Prioritize the schools containing your most-wanted unidentified books, not just the ones that improve your current casting.

Wizards are the undisputed masters of magic: they learn faster, fail less, and have the widest range of useful spells. A well-built Wizard can eventually learn *every* spell in the game, which is the closest the Mazes come to letting you cheat. Other roles can cast some spells but with less panache. A Valkyrie can occasionally read identify (level 3) if her Intelligence is boosted by gainability potions, but non-spellcasters are usually better off with scrolls. Tourists, Barbarians, and Cavemen should probably stick to hitting things.

Each spell stays in memory for about 20,000 turns, then fades and must be relearned. The spell list (+) shows time-remaining. You can also apply a spellbook to check how worn it is: each **successful** read counts toward a fixed total of four before the book fades to blank paper. Failed reads don't add to that counter, but each failure has its own 1-in-3 chance to destroy the book outright. Carry important spellbooks with you if you plan to rely on their spells in the late game.

Paperbacks. A spellbook that appears as a *paperback* is a novel rather than a real spellbook. Read it: the first novel you pick up in a game grants 20 XP, which is exactly enough to lift a fresh character from experience level 1 to 2. (The 20 XP only fires once; subsequent paperbacks just display a quote.) Each paperback is a Terry Pratchett **Discworld** title, and reading it opens a passage from the novel.

Key Spells

Spell	Level	Effect
Force bolt	1	2d12 ranged hit; an Int/XL bonus adjusts by -3 to +3
Healing	1	Restore hit points
Detect monsters	1	Sense nearby monsters
Identify	3	Identify items (saves scrolls)
Remove curse	3	Uncurse worn/wielded items
Chain lightning	2	Shock that spreads from the caster in all directions, chaining to nearby monsters
Magic mapping	5	Reveal the level (saves scrolls)
Charm monster	5	Tame nearby creatures in a 3×3 area; Skilled+ acts like a blessed scroll
Finger of death	7	Kill in a beam; MR resists

The other 34 spells, along with their schools, types, and rank-gated upgrades, are in the Spell Tables appendix.

For Wizards, learning **identify** and **magic mapping** as spells dramatically reduces your need for scrolls: it's like having infinite scrolls, except they cost mana instead of inventory space. **Finger of death** is the ultimate argument-ender. **Charm monster** turns your enemies into your friends, which is even better than killing them because friends carry things and absorb hits.

Mana Management

Your power (Pw) pool determines how many spells you can cast before you need to sit in a corner and regenerate like a phone battery. Casting a spell costs **5 Pw per spell level** (so finger of death is 35 Pw). A failed cast still spends half. Power regenerates over time, faster with higher Wisdom and Intelligence, faster still for Wizards or with a regeneration source.

High-level spells cost serious power. Plan your casting and carry backup wands and scrolls: a Wizard out of Pw is just a person in a bathrobe holding a stick.



Luck and Fortune

The Mazes are rigged. Not unfairly (the dungeon doesn't *hate* you), but there is a hidden number attached to your character that quietly tilts every die roll, every prayer, every scroll, every combat swing. It's called Luck, and it's one of the most important stats you can't see.

Players who ignore Luck die to things that "shouldn't have happened." Players who cultivate it find that the dungeon is mysteriously generous. This is not a coincidence.

How Luck Works

Luck ranges from -13 to +13. It starts at 0, the universe's way of saying "prove yourself." Left alone, luck drifts back toward zero over time; the Mazes don't give anything for free.

Luck timeout. Every 600 turns, your luck moves one point toward 0. If you have +5 luck, it will drop to +4 after 600 turns, then +3 after 1200, eventually reaching 0. Your good deeds are forgotten. Your sins, alas, are also forgiven.

Luckstone. Carrying a luckstone in your open inventory (not inside a container) freezes the timer. Your luck stays wherever it is until something changes it. This is why getting the luckstone from Mine's End is one of the first things every experienced player does. It's a small gray stone that makes the universe remember you fondly.

Bless state matters. Any **non-cursed** luckstone (blessed *or* uncursed) freezes drift toward your baseline and adds **+3 to your effective Luck on most rolls**. A **cursed** luckstone is dangerous: it subtracts 3 from your effective Luck and holds *negative* Luck in place (preventing the usual drift back toward zero from below). Always BUC-check a luckstone before carrying it, and bless it on an altar if you can. (The +3 bonus comes from `set_moreluck`; the curse doesn't speed positive Luck's decay, but it locks bad Luck in.)

The Heart of Ahriman, Tsurugi of Muramasa, and Orb of Fate all count as luckstones. Barbarian, Samurai, and Valkyrie quest artifacts confer the same drift-freeze and bless-state bonus, so those three roles get a “free luckstone” from their quest reward. Carrying both a blessed luckstone *and* one of these artifacts doesn’t stack the +3 bonus (the bonus is binary, not additive), but it does add an extra unit of “blessed” to the count if you somehow end up with a cursed luckstone, partially offsetting it.

Calendar Luck. The drift target isn’t always 0:

- On a **full moon** night, baseline Luck is +1: Luck drifts toward +1 instead of 0. If you started the session on a full moon, you have +1 Luck for free.
- On **Friday the 13th**, baseline Luck is –1. Avoid stair-up runs on this day if you can; your accumulated good Luck will sap toward –1 even if you’ve been virtuous.

(NetHack uses your computer’s real date for this; set your clock back if you’ve planned an ascension on the 13th and don’t want the penalty, though most players just embrace the theme.)

Gaining and Losing Luck

Action	Luck change
Throw identified real gem to co-aligned unicorn	+5
Throw named-but-unidentified real gem to co-aligned	+2
Throw unknown real gem to co-aligned unicorn	+1
Throw fully-identified real gem to cross-aligned unicorn	–3 to +3 (random)
Throw unidentified real gem to cross-aligned unicorn	–1 to +1 (random)
Sacrificing on your own altar (varies by corpse value)	typically +1
Sitting on a throne (lucky outcome)	+1
Breaking a Sokoban rule (squeeze, fracture, polymorph boulder, scroll of earth)	–1 each
Killing a peaceful creature	–1 (50% chance per kill)
Killing a same-alignment unicorn	–5
Killing your quest leader	–20 immediate (floor at –10), +7 god-anger, plus permanent –4 to baseline luck

Action	Luck change
Killing your pet	-1 plus -15 alignment
Cannibalism	-2 to -5
Breaking a mirror	-2

Be virtuous and the numbers smile on you. Be a monster and they frown. The Mazes have a moral compass, and it's embedded in the math.

Unicorn gem-throwing is the strongest active Luck source in the game.

Throw a properly-identified real gem (not glass) at a unicorn whose alignment matches yours and you gain +5 Luck immediately. The unicorn turns peaceful, accepts the gift, and teleports away, and will accept another later if you find it again. Identify your gems *first* (touchstone or scroll of identify); the bonus drops from +5 to +1 if you don't actually know what you're throwing. Glass gems are harmless but yield nothing; throwing them is a safe way to pacify an unwanted unicorn without spending real gems. Avoid throwing real gems at cross-aligned unicorns: the result is a random Luck change between -3 and +3 and is rarely worth the gamble. Archeologists start with a **touchstone**, which lets them verify whether a gem is real before throwing it at a unicorn.

There is a ceiling on the luck you can harvest from any given corpse. If your current luck score already exceeds the difficulty rating of the monster you just sacrificed, you gain nothing. The altar accepts your offering politely and gives you nothing in return, because the gods have standards.

Before 5.0, players used to be able to sit at a co-aligned altar with a pile of kobold corpses and grind luck to maximum. That no longer works once your luck is already above modest levels. To raise luck via sacrifice in the mid-to-late game, you need fresh corpses of monsters whose difficulty exceeds your current luck value. In practice: a luckstone, occasional mid-tier sacrifices, and not killing peaceulfs is the standard path to high luck.

Why Luck Matters

At Luck +5 (or higher, with a luckstone), life is *noticeably* better:

- You hit more often in combat. Swings that would have missed connect instead.

- Your prayers are more likely to be answered. Your god likes lucky people. (Gods are fickle that way.)
- Scrolls of enchant weapon/armor succeed more often at high enchantment levels.
- Wands of wishing are more likely to work perfectly on wresting.
- Fountain wishes become slightly more likely.

At negative luck, all of these go wrong. **Any** negative Luck causes prayer to fail with the “too naughty” rejection (`pray.c:2155`) — not just at the floor of -10 . You’ll miss attacks you should have hit. Scrolls will backfire. The dungeon becomes a place that is trying to kill you even harder than usual, which is saying something.

The practical advice: get a luckstone early, sacrifice occasionally to keep luck positive, and don’t kill peacefuls. Treat the universe well and it will return the favor, in the form of slightly better random numbers, which in the Mazes is the closest thing to love.



Enhancing Skills

Most adventurers discover the skill system the first time they press #enhance and realize the broadsword they've been swinging for several levels is finally ready to graduate from Basic to Skilled. Weapons, fighting styles, and spell schools each track their own proficiency, and you train them one slot at a time.

The Skill Ladder

Most skills run **Unskilled** → **Basic** → **Skilled** → **Expert**. **Bare hands** and **martial arts** alone reach **Master** and **Grand Master**. Each rank-up costs both **practice** (uses of the skill) and **skill slots** (a finite budget tied to your experience level).

To reach	Practice (cumulative)	Weapon slots	Non-weapon slots
Basic	20	1	1
Skilled	80	2	1
Expert	180	3	2
Master	320	—	2
Grand Master	500	—	3

Non-weapon skills — spell schools, riding, bare hands, martial arts — cost roughly half as many slots as melee weapons, the dungeon's quiet subsidy for magic. (Two-weapon uses the weapon column despite the name.) You start with 2 slots, gain one per experience level (29 more by XL 30), and one more if you are crowned, so the absolute ceiling is **32 slots** for an XL-30 crowned hero. Lose an experience level and you lose a slot, which can demote your most recent advancement.

Each role has a per-skill **cap** beyond which no amount of training will help. A Wizard caps at Basic with a mace and is restricted from long swords. Restricted skills don't appear on #enhance and stay Unskilled, with one exception: if your god grants you an artifact weapon, you're auto-unrestricted in

its skill up to Basic. The full role caps are tabled in Per-Role Skill Caps below.

Training a Skill

Practice accumulates through use:

- **Weapon skills** tick on every melee or thrown hit that does **more than 1 damage**. A pillow-soft punch for 1 point doesn't count. Spears, javelins, knives, daggers, and aklys train the same skill whether you stab with them or throw them.
- **Bare hands** counts **50%** of your hits; **martial arts** counts **75%**. The rank still applies on every hit; this just slows the climb.
- **Riding** earns one tick every **100 squares** ridden.
- **Spell schools** earn **N practice per successful cast of a level-N spell**. Every school has a level-1 option to grind. See the schools table below.

Skills your role starts at Basic come **pre-credited with 20 practice uses**, so you're already a quarter of the way to Skilled before the first turn.

When you've earned enough practice, the game says **"You feel more confident in your skills."** That's your cue to type `#enhance`. If more advancements remain after you pick one, you'll see **"You feel you could be more dangerous!"** — keep going.

What a Rank Buys You

For weapons and fighting styles, each rank shifts your to-hit and damage bonuses by a flat amount (the values replace each other, not stack):

Rank	Weapon	Two- weapon	Riding	Bare hands	Martial arts
Unskilled	-4 / -2	-9 / -3	-2 / 0	+1 / 0	+2 / +1
Basic	0 / 0	-7 / -1	-1 / 0	+1 / +1	+3 / +3
Skilled	+2 / +1	-5 / 0	0 / +1	+2 / +1	+4 / +4
Expert	+3 / +2	-3 / +1	0 / +2	+2 / +2	+5 / +6
Master	—	—	—	+3 / +2	+6 / +7
Grand Master	—	—	—	+3 / +3	+7 / +9

(Each cell is **to-hit / damage**.) Two-weapon penalties apply to **each** of the two strikes. A Basic two-weaponer hits twice but at -7 each, which is much worse than one solid swing. Bare hands and martial arts bonuses apply on every hit; only the practice counter is gated by the $\text{dmg} > 1$ roll. The Expert weapon line ($+3 / +2$) is why dedicating to a single weapon matters: that's the difference between landing the killing blow and watching the monster shrug.

The Seven Spell Schools

Every spellbook belongs to one of seven schools, and your rank in that school determines how reliably you can cast spells from it. Higher rank also unlocks some spell upgrades. Cone of cold becomes a cluster of 3×3 explosions at Skilled, identify IDs the whole stack, haste self lasts longer, and so on.

School	Focus	L1 grind
Attack	Direct damage (force bolt, fireball)	Force bolt
Healing	HP restore and cure status	Healing
Divination	Sensing, identifying, mapping	Light
Enchantment	Bufs, debuffs, charm	Confuse monster
Cleric	Divine protection and summoning	Protection
Escape	Mobility, evasion, levitation	Jumping
Matter	Manipulation, transmutation, polymorph	Knock

Per-Role Skill Caps

Three tables of fixed maxima follow: weapons, fighting styles, and spell schools. Skills not listed for a role are **restricted**: the rank is locked at Unskilled, with one exception (a god-given artifact weapon unrestricts you to Basic in its skill). Key: **B**=Basic, **S**=Skilled, **E**=Expert, **M**=Master, **GM**=Grand Master, **—**=restricted.

A “—” doesn't mean the skill is unusable, just locked at Unskilled forever. A Healer can still read a spellbook of force bolt and try to cast it. A Wizard can still swing a long sword. They'll just always pay the Unskilled penalty from the Skill Ladder ($-4/-2$ for a weapon, $-9/-3$ per strike for two-weapon, the

Unskilled cast-failure rate for a spell school), with no path to improvement.

Role abbreviations: Arc=Archeologist, Bar=Barbarian, Cav=Caveman, Hea=Healer, Kni=Knight, Mon=Monk, Pri=Priest, Rog=Rogue, Ran=Ranger, Sam=Samurai, Tou=Tourist, Val=Valkyrie, Wiz=Wizard.

Weapon Skill Caps

Weapon	Arc	Bar	Cav	Hea	Kni	Mon	Pri	Rog	Ran	Sam	Tou	Val	Wiz
dagger	B	B	B	S	B	—	—	E	E	B	E	E	E
knife	B	—	S	E	B	—	—	E	S	S	S	—	S
axe	—	E	S	—	S	—	—	—	S	—	B	E	S
pick-axe	E	S	B	—	B	—	—	—	B	—	B	S	—
short sword	B	E	—	S	S	—	—	E	B	E	E	S	B
broadsword	—	S	—	—	S	—	—	S	—	S	B	S	—
long sword	—	S	—	—	E	—	—	S	—	E	B	E	—
two-handed sword	—	E	—	—	S	—	—	B	—	E	B	E	—
saber	E	S	—	B	S	—	—	S	—	B	S	B	—
club	S	S	E	S	B	—	E	S	—	—	—	—	S
mace	—	S	E	B	S	—	E	S	—	—	B	—	B
morning star	—	S	B	—	S	—	E	B	B	—	B	—	—
flail	—	B	S	—	B	—	E	B	S	S	B	—	—
hammer	—	E	S	—	B	—	E	B	B	—	B	E	—
quarterstaff	S	B	E	E	—	B	E	—	B	B	B	B	E
polearms	—	—	S	B	S	—	S	B	S	S	B	S	S
spear	—	S	E	B	S	B	S	B	E	S	B	E	B
trident	—	S	S	B	B	—	S	—	B	—	B	B	B
lance	—	—	—	—	E	—	B	—	—	S	B	S	—
bow	—	B	S	—	B	—	B	—	E	E	B	—	—
sling	S	—	E	S	—	—	B	—	E	—	B	B	S
crossbow	—	—	—	—	S	B	B	E	E	—	B	—	—
dart	B	—	—	E	—	—	B	E	E	—	E	—	E
shuriken	—	—	—	S	—	B	B	S	S	E	B	—	B
boomerang	E	—	E	—	—	—	B	—	E	—	B	—	—
whip	E	—	—	—	—	—	—	—	B	—	B	—	—
unicorn horn	S	—	B	E	—	—	S	—	—	—	S	—	—

Scimitar was merged into saber in 5.0; both refer to the same skill now.

Fighting Style Caps

Style	Arc	Bar	Cav	Hea	Kni	Mon	Pri	Rog	Ran	Sam	Tou	Val	Wiz
bare hands	E	M	M	B	E	—	B	E	B	—	S	E	B
two- weapon	B	B	—	—	S	—	—	E	—	E	S	S	—
riding	B	B	—	—	E	—	—	B	B	S	B	S	B
martial arts	—	—	—	—	—	GM	—	—	—	M	—	—	—

Only Monks and Samurai have martial arts at all, and only Monks reach Grand Master.

Spell School Caps

School	Arc	Bar	Cav	Hea	Kni	Mon	Pri	Rog	Ran	Sam	Tou	Val	Wiz
Attack	B	B	B	—	S	B	—	—	—	B	—	B	E
Healing	B	—	—	E	S	E	E	—	B	—	—	—	S
Divination	E	—	—	—	—	B	E	S	E	B	B	—	E
Enchantment	—	—	—	—	—	B	—	—	—	—	B	—	S
Cleric	—	—	—	—	S	S	E	—	—	S	—	—	S
Escape	—	B	—	—	—	S	—	S	B	—	S	B	E
Matter	B	—	S	—	—	B	—	S	—	—	—	—	E

Healers cap at Expert in healing but are restricted from every other school — the only role with this kind of single-school specialization. Wizards and Monks are the only roles with access to all seven schools, though only Wizards can push four of them to Expert; Monks reach Expert only in healing. Barbarians and Valkyries cap at Basic in their two available schools (attack and escape) and are restricted from the other five.

Spending Slots Wisely

Thirty slots sounds like plenty until you start counting. Expert in a single weapon costs **6 slots** (1+2+3) by itself. A Valkyrie aiming for Expert long sword, Expert two-weapon, and Skilled riding is fourteen slots deep before any spell school.

A few principles:

- **Don't enhance reflexively.** Slots are spent permanently (short of losing experience). If you're not committed to a weapon, hold the slot until you are.
- **Cap-aware investment.** Pushing a skill to its role cap is fine: the menu just stops offering further advances. You can't waste enhancements past the cap because the option never appears.
- **Wizards get two benefits from spell schools.** Each rank-up improves casting success *and* reveals more spellbook appearances in that school (the identification payoff covered in the Spellcasting chapter). Schools containing your unidentified books deserve priority. This double benefit is Wizard-only; other roles only get the casting-success benefit.
- **Riding is a skill.** Without **Basic riding** you can't pick up items, loot, dip, set or disarm traps, or engrave on the floor while mounted. Knights start at Basic. Pushing to Skilled erases the -1 to-hit penalty in the saddle and adds +1 damage.
- **Bare hands and martial arts are the domain of Monks.** Grand Master needs **9 cumulative non-weapon slots**, which Monks reach naturally. Anyone else dabbling in unarmed combat should plan to stop at Basic.

A few spells get sharper at Skilled. Cone of cold and fireball become a cluster of 3×3 **explosions** you can place at range. Identify, remove curse, haste self, detect monsters, and several others gain the blessed-scroll effect.



Wishes and Wishing

There is a moment in every successful game where you're asked, "For what do you wish?" It's the best question in all of gaming. Don't panic. Don't mistype. And for the love of all that is holy, don't wish for a +3 blessed cockatrice. (Actually, that *would* be something. But no.)

Wishes are rare, powerful, and the difference between a character who ascends and one who dies memorably on the Plane of Fire.

Sources of Wishes

The Mazes are stingy, but there are more wish sources than most travelers realize:

- **Wand of wishing:** found in the Castle treasure room (see Key Wands for the 5.0 charge mechanics). The Castle chest also contains a potion of gain level, because the Mazes occasionally feel generous.
- **Vlad's throne:** A special throne that grants a guaranteed wish if you keep sitting. Four of thirteen outcomes are a wish (which destroys the throne); the other nine are painful but the throne survives, so persistence pays off.
- **The Amulet of Yendor:** Grants a wish when you first pick it up. A reward for reaching the bottom of the dungeon. You can decline this wish if your kit is already complete; some minimalist ascenders skip it entirely on principle.
- **Magic lamp:** Rubbing a blessed lamp summons the djinni 1-in-3 times; *if* it appears, it grants a wish 80% of the time, so roughly 27% wish per rub. Keep rubbing. Either a magic lamp or a magic marker is guaranteed in Orcus Town.
- **Fountain:** roughly 1 in 30 quaffs summons a water demon, and *that* demon grants a wish only about 1-in-5 times on shallow floors (less on

deeper ones), so a true wish chance closer to 1 in 150 per quaff. Far more likely to produce snakes, nymphs, curses, or vomiting.

- **Throne:** Very rare chance of a wish when sitting. Also a very real chance of everything going wrong.
- **Djinni from smoky potion:** Rare (1 in 13 base probability), and even then only 20% wish chance (80% if blessed). But when it works, you feel like a genius.

In practice, the number of wishes a run produces varies widely. A sensible budget if you take each guaranteed source once is about four (Castle wand, Vlad's throne, Amulet pickup, one magic lamp). Anything beyond that is luck (extra lamps, fountain demons, recharge chains) or commitment. Don't waste any of them on food.

What to Wish For

Generations of adventurers have argued about optimal wish order. Here's the conventional wisdom, battle-tested by thousands of ascensions:

1. **Gray dragon scale mail** (magic resistance + AC; magic resistance is the most important protection in the game, so this is highly recommended).
2. **Silver dragon scale mail** (reflection + AC, the second pillar of not dying to wands).
3. **Speed boots** (being fast gives you more actions per turn, excellent for both offense and escape).
4. **Gauntlets of power** (STR 25 if your role benefits; most roles benefit from punching harder).
5. **Amulet of life saving** (insurance for the endgame, when overconfidence kills more adventurers than monsters do).
6. **A specific artifact** (Grayswandir is a common target for the silver damage against everything in Gehennom).

Don't wish for consumables (scrolls, potions) unless you're in dire straits. Items you can find through normal play aren't worth a wish. A wish is for things that change the fundamental equation of your survival.

Wish Syntax

When the game asks “For what do you wish?”, be specific. This is not the time for ambiguity:

- “blessed +3 gray dragon scale mail” gets you exactly that.
- “gray dragon scale mail” alone lets the dice pick blessed/ cursed and enchantment — a bare wish can roll cursed. You had *one* wish; spell out the BUC and the plus.
- Artifact wishes get *harder* as artifacts accumulate. The denial roll scales with the total artifacts in the world (yours, generated, even bones-file ones), and your artifact-wish counter ticks whether or not the artifact actually appears. Quest artifacts are absolutely blocked.
- A few targets are silently nerfed into mundane substitutes: the **Amulet of Yendor** becomes a fake amulet, the **Bell of Opening** a plain bell, the **Book of the Dead** blank paper, the **Candelabrum** a tallow candle, and — relevant after all that lamp-rubbing — a wish for a **magic lamp** hands you an ordinary oil lamp.



Artifacts

Scattered throughout the Mazes are items of legend: named weapons, amulets, and tools that carry powers no ordinary gear can match. Each artifact exists only once per game, so when you find one, you're holding a genuine one-of-a-kind. Here's how they come into your hands:

- **Fountain dipping** (Excalibur, for Lawful characters).
- **Sacrifice** on an altar (your god may gift you an aligned artifact).
- **Quest completion** (each role's unique quest artifact).
- **Wishing** (you can wish for most artifacts, but they resist if they don't match your alignment).
- **Random generation** (rare, but weapons have a small chance of being generated as an artifact).

Alignment and Blasting

Each artifact has an alignment. If you try to handle an artifact that doesn't match your alignment:

- **Intelligent artifacts** (most quest artifacts and certain alignment-restricted artifacts): 4d10 damage (or 2d10 with magic resistance) and the item evades your grasp. You cannot wield these.
- **Other misaligned artifacts**: 4d4 damage on first touch (2d4 with magic resistance), 1/4 chance of being blasted on each subsequent touch.

Wishable / random artifacts

These are the artifacts you can find, get from a sacrifice gift, fountain-dip up (Excalibur), or wish for. Bonus damage is rolled fresh on each hit (e.g. +d10 means roll 1d10). The "extra" column is the damage rolled *on top of* the base weapon's own damage. A weapon listed as "×2 vs X" rolls its base damage *twice* against any member of that monster class.

Artifact	Align	Weapon	Hit	Extra damage	Notable
Excalibur	Lawful	long sword	+d5	+d10 physical	drain resistance, automatic searching
Grayswandir	Lawful	silver saber	+d5	(base only)	half physical damage received, hallucination res.
Mjollnir	Neutral	war hammer	+d5	+d24 shock	returns when thrown if STR 25
Magicbane	Neutral	athame	+d3	+d4 magic (stun)	magic resistance and curse protection while <i>wielded</i>
Stormbringer	Chaotic	runesword	+d5	+d2 drain life	drains a level (you gain it); attacks peacefuls
Vorpal Blade	any	long sword	+d5	+d1 physical	chance to behead on hit
Frost Brand	any	long sword	+d5	(base only) cold	cold resistance while wielded
Fire Brand	any	long sword	+d5	(base only) fire	fire resistance while wielded
Sunsword	Lawful	long sword	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs undead	wielded light; #invoke fires a blinding ray any direction (camera-style; works on any monster)
Snickersnee	Lawful	katana	—	+d8 physical	acts as a polearm without a steed; one free reach-attack per turn (the “Shkinng!” hit)
Cleaver	Neutral	battle-axe	+d3	+d6 physical	one-handed wield → strikes target <i>and</i> both flanks
Demonbane	Lawful	silver mace	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs demons	banishes demons; Priest’s first sacrifice gift
Sting	Chaotic	elven dagger	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs orcs	warns of orcs (the dagger glows blue)
Orcrist	Chaotic	elven broadsword	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs orcs	warns of orcs
Grimtooth	Chaotic	orcish dagger	+d2	+d6 physical (any target)	warns of elves; defends vs poison
Dragonbane	any	broadsword	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs dragons	reflection while wielded
Werebane	any	silver saber	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs were-	defends against lycanthropy

Artifact	Align	Weapon	Hit	Extra damage	Notable
Giantslayer	Neutral	long sword	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs giants	—
Ogresmasher	any	war hammer	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs ogres	—
Trollsbane	any	morning star	+d5	(base only); ×2 vs trolls	regeneration while wielded

Not every entry is equally desirable. **Grayswandir** and **Magicbane** are the artifacts most players try to wish for first; **Mjollnir** is the Valkyrie’s archetypal wish; **Excalibur** is usually fountain-dipped rather than wished. **Frost Brand**, **Vorpal Blade**, and **Stormbringer** are common second wishes. **Snickersnee** and **Sunsword** were historically considered flavour pieces, but their 5.0 effects (free reach attack per turn; on-demand camera-style blind) have moved them into the “worth wishing for, role permitting” tier. The remaining entries (the bane weapons, Fire Brand, Cleaver) are usually accepted as sacrifice gifts rather than spent wishes on.

Excalibur is the go-to weapon for Lawful characters; the drain resistance alone is worth carrying it, even after you have a stronger weapon. Knights start aligned to it and have unique 1-in-6 fountain-dip odds; every other Lawful role faces 1-in-30.

Grayswandir is wishable and arguably the game’s best melee weapon. It’s silver (extra damage to many monsters), halves incoming physical damage, and grants hallucination resistance.

Mjollnir is the Valkyrie’s signature throw-and-return weapon — and only Valkyries get the reliable 99% catch-back. Other roles can wield it for melee but won’t reliably catch it on the return throw. It needs Strength 25 to wield in either case (gauntlets of power or rings of gain strength get you there). Its +d24 shock damage is brutal against anything not shock-resistant.

Magicbane is the Wizard’s go-to athame. The combined effect of its stun damage, curse protection, and magic resistance — all of which require it to be **wielded**, not just carried — makes it Wizard’s preferred melee weapon. Often the first gift from a Neutral sacrifice.

Stormbringer is dangerous to use because it attacks peaceful monsters automatically, which can cause alignment problems. But each hit drains a level

from the target and gives it to you, which is huge in the early-to-mid game. Stormbringer is also *intelligent*: a Lawful or Neutral wielder who touches it without permission takes the heavier 4d10 magical-blast damage rather than the 4d4 dealt by ordinary cross-alignment artifacts.

Cleaver is the Barbarian quest artifact. When wielded one-handed (not two-weaponing), every swing strikes the primary target *and* one square on each side of it: three monsters per attack when packed in a corridor mouth or against a diagonal pair. The two-weapon penalty suppresses the spin, so most Barbarians keep Cleaver as their primary and a shield in the off slot.

Frost Brand and **Fire Brand** each have an *#invoke* power the wishable table doesn't capture: Frost Brand summons a snowstorm around you (cold damage to nearby squares), Fire Brand summons a firestorm. Either one clears the room around you when you're cornered.

Snickersnee got a major buff in 5.0: it now counts as a polearm even when you're on foot (regular pole weapons require a steed). Once per turn you can *#apply* it for a free reach attack at a target up to two squares away — a real free action that *doesn't* end your turn, leaving you a normal melee swing on top. The free hit is announced by a distinctive "Shkinng!" The combined output (one ranged + one melee per turn) makes Snickersnee a contender for best Samurai weapon in the game, not just a flavor piece.

Sunsword is the Lawful long sword that wants to be a tool. Wielded, it lights its current radius (handy in caves and the Mines without costing an oil lamp). *#invoke* it for a directed *blinding ray* — mechanically a Camera flash in any direction, *not* limited to undead. It costs 5×spell-level Pw to invoke, so save it for the fights that demand it (Riders, mind flayers, the Wizard of Yendor), but a blind monster is a monster that misses you. Invoking up or down lights the room; invoking at yourself self-blinds (don't).

Bane weapons (Sunsword, Demonbane, Sting, Orcrist, Grimtooth, Dragonbane, Werebane, Giantslayer, Ogresmasher, Trollsbane) deal double base damage against their target class. Most are disappointing as a primary weapon, but the defensive riders are often the real reason to swap one in: Trollsbane regenerates while wielded (genuinely useful for an early character holding the line), Dragonbane reflects, Werebane neutralizes lycanthropy, Grimtooth defends against poison. Sting and Orcrist are notable because elves can start with elven daggers and broadswords as their base weapons.

Quest artifacts

Each role has exactly one quest artifact, awarded for completing the role’s quest. They are intelligent: only the rightful owner can safely wield them; anyone else gets blasted. Most of the non-weapon ones grant magic resistance just by sitting in your inventory, so roles whose quest artifact is a passive object still benefit from carrying it.

A wishing quirk to know about. The wish system blocks *your own* role’s quest artifact (you have to earn it the hard way), but it doesn’t block *other roles’* quest artifacts. A neutral character can wish for any neutral quest artifact, a lawful one for any lawful quest artifact, and so on. The alignment-blast rule still applies if you actually wield or wear a misaligned one, but carry bonuses (MR, drain resistance, regeneration, half spell damage, energy regeneration, etc.) work for anyone. A neutral Monk can wish for the Healer’s *Staff of Aesculapius* for the drain-life-on-hit and drain-resistance carry bonus, or the Wizard’s *Eye of the Aethiopica* for MR + half-spell-damage + energy regen, even though those quests are closed to the Monk. Wishes for artifacts of all kinds also have an increasing fizzle chance as more artifacts already exist in the game.

#invoke (default ^A) activates each artifact’s special power; the cost is some energy plus a wear-out interval before it can be used again.

Role	Artifact	Form	Wear/wield	Carry	#invoke
Arc	The Orb of Detection	crystal ball	—	MR, ESP, ½ spell dmg	invisibility
Bar	The Heart of Ahriman	luckstone	×2 dmg as a projectile	stealth, +luck	levitation
Cav	The Sceptre of Might	mace	+d5 hit; ×2 vs non-lawful	magic resistance	conflict
Hea	The Staff of Aesculapius	quarterstaff	drain-life on hit	drain res., regen	full heal + cure
Kni	The Magic Mirror of Merlin	mirror	(speaks to you)	MR, ESP	—
Mon	The Eyes of the Overworld	lenses	astral vision, magic res. (when worn)	—	enlightenment
Pri	The Mitre of Holiness	helm	+1 prot. (brilliance base)	fire res.	energy boost
Ran	The Longbow of Diana	bow	+d5 hit; reflection	ESP	conjure arrows

Role	Artifact	Form	Wear/wield	Carry	#invoke
Rog	The Master Key of Thievery	skeleton key	—	warn, t-ctrl, ½ phys	guaranteed untrap
Sam	The Tsurugi of Muramasa	tsurugi	+d8 phys; chance to behead	+luck, +1 prot.	—
Tou	Platinum Yendorian Express Card	credit card	—	MR, ESP, ½ spell dmg	charge an item
Val	The Orb of Fate	crystal ball	—	+luck, warn, ½ all dmg	levitate / teleport
Wiz	The Eye of the Aethiopica	amulet	—	MR, ½ spell, +energy	create portal

The Orb of Detection (Archeologist): a crystal ball that grants ESP and magic resistance just by being carried. #invoke toggles invisibility. Archeologists are already exceptional at stealth, and this turns them into a ghost.

The Heart of Ahriman (Barbarian): a luckstone that doubles as a +1 luck talisman with stealth. Critically, it counts as a luckstone for *all* the luckstone mechanics (mine's-end protection, gem-throw luck math, luck cap +13 instead of +10). It's also a projectile weapon: Barbarians can throw it for double damage and pick it back up. #invoke is levitation.

The Sceptre of Might (Caveman): mace base, +d5 to-hit, double damage against any monster whose alignment differs from the artifact's (the Sceptre itself is Lawful, so it deals doubled damage against chaotic, neutral, *and* unaligned monsters — most of the dungeon's hostiles once you reach Gehennom). It also grants magic resistance while *wielded*. #invoke casts conflict (monsters fight each other) at a steep energy cost.

The Staff of Aesculapius (Healer): the Healer's salvation. Each hit drains life (one of only three drain-life weapons; the others are Stormbringer and the rider Death) and gives you regeneration plus drain resistance just by carrying it. #invoke heals fully and cures nearly every bad status. Few artifacts change a role's late game as much as this one.

The Magic Mirror of Merlin (Knight): grants ESP and magic resistance, and occasionally *speaks*, dropping hints. Knights already have Excalibur for combat, so the Mirror is pure passive utility.

The Eyes of the Overworld (Monk): lenses that, when worn, give astral vision (see invisible, see through walls, spot secret doors) **and** magic resis-

tance. Both effects require them to be worn — carrying them in inventory does nothing. **#invoke** enlightens you. For a Monk who can't safely wear body armor, a powerful passive on a slot they can use.

The Mitre of Holiness (Priest): a helm of brilliance with the usual brilliance bonus to intelligence and wisdom (so spell-cast more reliably), plus fire resistance while carried, plus a free -1 to AC. **#invoke** for an energy boost, useful for spell-heavy Priests. Note: despite what older spoilers say, the Mitre does **not** deal bonus damage against undead (the artifact has no melee attack to carry the bonus), and it does not grant drain resistance.

The Longbow of Diana (Ranger): a real artifact bow with +d5 to hit plus reflection while wielded, ESP while carried. **#invoke** conjures free arrows out of thin air. Combined with the Ranger's ranged specialization this is the role's centerpiece.

The Master Key of Thievery (Rogue): a carry package of warning, teleport control, half physical damage taken, and **#invoke** instantly untraps a nearby trap. The unlocking bonus depends on alignment: a Rogue gets it from any non-cursed Key; everyone else needs a **blessed** Key. With those preconditions met, **#untrap** also gains a perfect-detection bonus on doors and chests.

The Tsurugi of Muramasa (Samurai): a katana-grade two-handed sword with +d8 damage *and* a behead chance (like Vorpal Blade) *and* a +1 protection bonus, and it acts as a luckstone. Note that Tsurugi does **not** grant magic resistance, despite the weapon's reputation. One of the strongest artifacts in the game, the Samurai's reward for a hard quest.

The Platinum Yendorian Express Card (Tourist): the Tourist's get-out-of-jail card. Carrying it grants ESP, magic resistance, and half spell damage; **#invoke** charges an item (a wand, ring, or marker), which in the Tourist's hands is roughly "a free wish per ~1000 turns." Pairs especially well with marker-stockpiling strategies.

The Orb of Fate (Valkyrie): the most generous passive in the game: counts as a luckstone, grants warning, halves both spell *and* physical damage taken. **#invoke** is levitate-or-teleport (a toggle, very useful in the Sanctum). Valkyries also have Mjollnir to throw, so the Orb sits in inventory as pure carry value.

The Eye of the Aethiopia (Wizard): grants magic resistance when **worn** (a Wizard's wearing slot for it is the amulet, so in practice always); carrying

also gives half spell damage taken and *extra energy regeneration*, a Wizard's most precious resource. `#invoke` opens a portal that drops you in Vlad's Tower (one-way; useful for shortcutting the Castle → Vlad's traversal). For a spell-caster this is irreplaceable.



The Deep Dungeon

The Castle

If you've reached the Castle, congratulations: you've survived the easy part. Everything below is worse.

The Castle sits at the bottom of the Dungeons of Doom, guarded by a drawbridge and whatever the dungeon decided to stuff inside this time. (5.0 at least no longer pre-loads the place with arch-liches to greet you on arrival.)

The drawbridge is the first puzzle. You can lower it four ways:

- **Play the passtune.** A five-note musical sequence played on any tonal instrument (wooden flute, magic flute, tooled horn, frost or fire horn, bugle, harp) opens the drawbridge. The notes are randomized per game. You can learn them by trying different sequences: the game tells you how many notes are correct after each attempt, like a game of Mastermind.
- **Wand of opening** pointed at the drawbridge.
- **Spell of knock** cast at the drawbridge.
- **Wand of striking** *destroys* the drawbridge entirely. The moat squares become walkable, but the bridge is gone and the tune is useless afterward. Use this as a one-way option.

Once you're across, the Castle contains:

- A **throne room** with a throne and a random court of high-letter monsters (liches, nymphs, eyes, giants, and the like). Sitting on the throne is tempting but risky (see Points of Interest). The throne room also holds a separate **treasure chest** with random loot — not the wand chest, just a side prize.
- **Barracks** full of soldiers carrying decent equipment, which is to say *your* equipment once you've dealt with them.
- **Four corner-tower alcoves.** One (and only one, randomly) contains the **wand of wishing** in a locked chest. *Search them all.* In 5.0, that chest also holds a **potion of gain level**, included as a small make-good for the wand's charge changes (see below). The chest's square is protected by a burned-in *Elbereth* engraving and sealed with a cursed scroll

of scare monster. Those wards exist to keep wandering monsters from *eating* the chest itself (some species, like leprechauns and rats, gnaw containers); the cursed scroll is also a known gotcha — don't try to read it casually. The locked chest opens by force, by a key, or by a wand of opening.

- Four **storerooms** along the north and south walls, each guarded by a dragon (D-class). Don't confuse them with the corner alcoves; the storerooms hold random fodder.
- A **central hallway lined with five trap doors**. Stepping on one drops you straight to the Valley of the Dead, which is rarely what you want at this stage. Watch the floor.
- A **fountain** in the moat-side corridor — usable in emergencies but not worth risking the wand of wishing for.
- A **moat** surrounding the fortress, occupied by giant eels and the occasional shark.

Strategy: clear the Castle carefully. A ring of conflict turns the guards against each other: walk in, put on the ring, and let the soldiers solve your monster problem for you. Loot everything. Then use your wand of wishing to fill critical gaps in your equipment (gray dragon scale mail, silver dragon scale mail, gauntlets of power, speed boots, whatever you're missing).

The locked Castle wand chest is **safe to leave temporarily**: monsters in 5.0 can pick up and rummage through *unlocked* containers, and they can unlock doors with keys, but they cannot unlock chests. A chest that started life locked stays locked until you or a wand of opening intervene. Unlocked containers are fair game.

The Castle wand yields only two wishes reliably (one charge + one recharge), so plan a *small* wishlist and accept that further wishes will need to come from other guaranteed sources — Vlad's throne, the Amulet pickup, Orcus Town's lamp/marker, fountain luck, or wresting. The era of the bottomless wishing wand is over (see Key Wands for the full mechanics).

Once you're fully equipped, the staircase down leads to Gehennom. Take a moment before descending. Sit down. Have a snack. Check your inventory twice. You should have **magic resistance**, **reflection**, **fire** and **poison resistance**, a **wand of digging**, a **unicorn horn**, plenty of food, holy water, scrolls of teleportation and identify, and your **quest artifact**.



Gehennom

Below the Castle, the dungeon changes. The corridors give way to mazes. The monsters give way to demons. The comforting knowledge that you can pray to your god for help gives way to silence: in Gehennom, you walk beyond the protective gaze of your god.

This is the part of the game that separates tourists from ascenders. Everything you've prepared for has been leading here.

The Valley of the Dead

The very first level of Gehennom, immediately below the Castle, is a named special level called the **Valley of the Dead**. You'll see the arrival message — *"You arrive at the Valley of the Dead..."* — and the dungeon overview will mark it for you. It's a wide hand-designed map with three irregular graveyards scattered across it and a permanent **shrine to Moloch** in the upper-left corner (an unaligned high altar; do not pray here). Walls are non-diggable everywhere, so you can't shortcut through them, and the level is flagged **noteleport** and **nommap** — magic mapping won't reveal it and teleportation doesn't work.

The morbid detail worth noticing: scattered across the level are **dead bodies of every player role** the dungeon has ever seen descend — two corpses each of Archeologists, Barbarians, Cavemen, Healers, Knights, Rangers, Rogues, Samurai, Tourists, Valkyries, and Wizards. Pointedly absent: **no Priests, no Monks** (maybe Moloch has a special fate reserved for members of those classes).

What's Different in Gehennom

- **No prayer.** Your god is deaf to you in Gehennom (unless you're a Moloch worshipper, and you're not). No emergency healing. No food rescue. No curse removal via divine intervention. Pack accordingly, because down here, you are completely on your own
- **Fire everywhere.** Fire traps litter the corridors. Demons breathe fire as casually as you breathe air. If you don't have fire resistance by now, turn around
- **Hot ground.** In 5.0, the ground itself is hot enough to shatter potions dropped on the floor. Keep everything in a bag at all times
- **Demon lords.** Named demon lords (Orcus, Baalzebub, Asmodeus, Juiblex, Yeenoghu, and if you're very unlucky, Demogorgon) hold court on specific levels. Each is a major battle. Several can summon reinforcements. All of them are angry you're here. However, **most demon lords can be bribed.** On first sight, if you haven't already attacked them, a major demon will name a price in gold for safe passage. The demand is a random fraction (roughly 20–100%) of the gold sitting **in your main inventory** — not gold inside containers — so a well-known runner-up trick is to **stash most of your gold in a bag of holding before approaching the throne:** the demand shrinks proportionally, and a few hundred zm bribe can buy off a prince who would otherwise have demanded thousands. The alternative is fighting a high-level boss, so unless you specifically want the XP or sacrifice corpse, bribery is often the better trade. (Wielding Excalibur or Demonbane closes off the bribery option — they refuse to talk and attack on sight.) The Riders on the Astral Plane and a small handful of demons (notably Demogorgon) won't take a bribe; the rest usually will
- **Teleportation restrictions.** In 5.0, teleportation is blocked on a demon lord's lair level while that lord still lives. Kill or banish them and the restriction lifts. In older editions, most Gehennom levels permanently blocked teleportation
- **Mazes.** Nearly every level is a maze. A wand of digging or pickaxe isn't optional here; it's as essential as your weapon. Dig straight lines to the stairs and don't look back

The demon-prince lairs

Three of Gehennom's special levels are the personal thrones of **Asmodeus** (fire-, cold-, and poison-resistant, casts cold spells, carries wands of cold and fire), **Baalzebub** (the Lord of the Flies — gaze that stuns you and a poisonous bite that drains Strength; his lair is a beetle-shaped maze), and **Juiblex** (the Faceless Lord, a slime that engulfs in melee and spits acid). All three sit alone in their lairs and **won't pursue** you, so you can avoid them entirely by skipping their level.

Asmodeus and Baalzebub are bribable: the demand is a random fraction of the gold in your main inventory, so **stash gold in a bag of holding before walking up to the throne** and a few hundred zm will buy off a prince who would otherwise have demanded thousands. **Juiblex is not bribable** — only the Arch-Devil demons with the bribe disposition (Geryon, Dispat, Baalzebub, Asmodeus) accept gold; Juiblex, Yeenoghu, Orcus, and Demogorgon attack on sight regardless. Fighting Juiblex is viable late game (wand of death works on all four), but expect a real fight. None of their corpses is useful for sacrifice the way a fresh weak monster's would be.

Vlad's Tower

A three-level tower branching **upward** off Gehennom (one of the only side-branches in the lower dungeon). **Vlad the Impaler** — a unique vampire lord — guards the **Candelabrum of Invocation** at the top. Climb the tower, kill Vlad, take the Candelabrum.

The tower also contains a **special throne**, and 5.0 has made it both more rewarding and more painful. The good news: it never disintegrates from sheer use the way ordinary thrones do, so you can sit on it again and again. The bad news: you will, because the prize is rare. Each sit rolls one of thirteen effects. Four of them grant a wish (the throne *does* disintegrate after the wish, having spent its power). The other nine are bad: permanent level drain, an inventory-coating layer of grease (your weapon will slip, your shield will fall off), a stripped intrinsic, a forced level teleport to the vibrating-square level (sometimes useful, often not), three summoned demons, a confused-blessed remove curse on your gear, forced polymorph, acid damage in eighty-

HP gulps if you don't have acid resistance, or a randomized stat shuffle that will probably make several of your scores worse.

The arithmetic: only one sit in three picks an effect at all (the other two roll "you feel out of place" and do nothing); of those that fire, 4/13 are the wish. Unconditional rate is about 1 in 10, so plan on roughly ten sits before the wish lands, with about seven bad effects absorbed along the way. Plan accordingly. Stand at full HP, leave any precious gear behind (a grease hit coats your whole pack and makes you Glib for 100 to 200 turns, dropping items from your hands when you try to use them), and have acid resistance or magic resistance ready before you sit. If you don't want a forced wish (say, you've already used your Castle wish and Amulet wish and want to keep this one for the ascension kit), you can sit at any time; you don't have to do it right now. The throne stays put unless something on the level destroys it.

Orcus Town

Orcus is a god of the underworld in Roman mythology — a chthonic figure who punishes broken oaths and devours the dead. In NetHack he's a unique demon prince (&, level 66, fast flier), the **Prince of Undead**, who casts spells, swings a weapon, claws twice, and stings for strength drain. His signature artifact is the **Wand of Orcus** — a wand of death by another name; his fingertip cantrip is also a death ray, so wear an amulet of life saving and consider opening with your own wand of death rather than a melee approach.

His level is a ghost town: a normal shopping district with all the shopkeepers and customers killed off by his ambient aura, the buildings stocked with random loot instead of for-sale inventory. What's left is an honor guard of liches, vampires, and ghouls. Somewhere on the level the dungeon guarantees either a **magic lamp** or a **magic marker** (50/50). Walk carefully (fire and magic traps everywhere), deal with the residents, and lift the lamp or marker on your way out. Either is a real supplement to the Castle wand's single charge.

The Wizard's Tower

A sequence of three special Gehennom levels that lead to the **Wizard of Yendor** himself and the **Book of the Dead**. He is the most dangerous enemy in the game, not because he's the strongest fighter, but because he **never stops**. He teleports to your location, summons monsters, steals back his Amulet whenever you grab it, curses your gear, and once you wake him he *will not leave you alone* for the rest of the game.

Kill him cleanly the first time, grab the Book, and move on. Subsequent kills don't yield new loot (he respawns), so don't engage him voluntarily again. The "Run, don't fight" advice for the Ascension Run is mostly about him.

Moloch's Sanctum

The bottom level of Gehennom. It is **sealed**: until the Invocation ritual is performed (see "The Heist" below), the down-stair to the Sanctum doesn't exist, and the level above is just one more maze. Once the seal breaks, descend to find the **High Priest of Moloch** standing on the **high altar** with the **Amulet of Yendor**. The High Priest is a unique non-briable boss who casts spells, summons minions, and aggrieves anyone in melee range — the standard answer is a wand of death or finger of death from a safe distance.

The Heist

The climax of the game is a choreographed sequence: three Invocation items, one vibrating square, one final boss, and one frantic climb back to the surface. The steps:

1. **Collect the trio.** You need the **Bell of Opening** (the Quest goal, dropped by your quest nemesis), the **Candelabrum of Invocation** (the top of Vlad's Tower), and the **Book of the Dead** (the bottom of the Wizard's Tower). Missing any one means walking all the way back to fetch it; the Bell in particular is easy to leave behind on the nemesis's corpse the first time through the Quest.
2. **Attach all seven candles to the Candelabrum.** Apply (a) each candle and select the Candelabrum. Candles spawn often enough that you'll

usually have enough, but you need a source for seven: **Izchak's lighting shop in Minetown** is the clean answer, or seven are scattered on that level if the shop is absent (Orcish Town layout).

3. **Find the vibrating square.** On the Gehennom level directly above Moloch's Sanctum, a single square vibrates when you step on it: *"You feel an unsettling vibration under your feet."* The square's position is random within the maze, so you have to search by walking — scrolls of magic mapping help enormously.
4. **Perform the Invocation.** Standing on the vibrating square, with the Candelabrum lit and the Book in your pack, **#invoke the Bell of Opening**. The floor opens; a down-stair to the Sanctum appears under your feet.
5. **Swipe the Amulet from Moloch.** Descend, take down the **High Priest** (wand of death is the clean answer), walk onto the high altar, and pick up the **Amulet of Yendor**.
6. **Begin the getaway.** The up-stair from the Sanctum now lifts you out (it wouldn't before you had the Amulet). You're now on the **Ascension Run** — every covetous monster in the game has noticed, the Wizard of Yendor will keep teleporting to you to take his Amulet back, and the Mysterious Force will keep yanking you back down. Climb fast (see The Ascension Run below).

Survival Tips

- **Bring extra food** — you'll be moving fast and praying is not a reliable refill
- **Bring scrolls of remove curse** — fast inventory cleanup when something goes wrong
- **Dig, don't navigate.** Maze walls are faster to go through than around
- **Kill the Wizard quickly.** Every turn he lives is another summoned monster, another stolen item, another cursed piece of gear. He'll come back (he always comes back), but the intervals between his appearances give you breathing room
- **The Amulet anchors you.** Level teleportation doesn't work while you carry it. Every step back to the surface must be climbed by foot
- **Genocide the lich class.** A blessed scroll of genocide applied to **L** removes liches, demiliches, master liches, and arch-liches in one read. Some of the worst Gehennom threats, gone for the rest of the run



The Ascension Kit

By the time you're ready to invoke Moloch's Sanctum, the loadout that experienced players actually wear has converged. A survey of recent ascensions from the public NetHack server shows what most winners carry. Here is the canonical kit, slot by slot:

Slot	Canonical pick	Notes
Body	Dragon scale mail	Gray (magic resistance) or silver (reflection) are the popular picks; blue (shock) also works.
Cloak	Cloak of magic resistance	Or a robe for casters. Magic resistance is non-negotiable in Gehennom.
Helm	Helm of brilliance or helm of telepathy	Brilliance for casters; telepathy when you might be blind.
Gloves	Gauntlets of power	Skip them only if you have a different STR strategy (e.g. a Knight with a +STR ring).
Boots	Speed boots	Universal.
Shirt	Hawaiian shirt or T-shirt	A free body slot under everything else — winners enchant it heavily (typically blessed +4 or +5) for several extra AC at no cost.
Shield	Mostly skipped	Reflection comes from silver dragon scale mail or an amulet instead; two-weapon fighters can't use a shield anyway.
Amulet	Amulet of life saving	The "extra life" plan.
Ring (L)	Free action	Anti-paralysis is non-negotiable on the Astral Plane.
Ring (R)	Slow digestion, conflict, or regeneration	Conflict is the standard Astral-Plane crowd-control choice.
Weapon	Your role's quest artifact + a silver saber	Silver saber appears in most builds as the off-hand because silver bypasses demon resistances.
Pack	Bag of holding, magic lamp, unicorn horn, luckstone, wand of death, multiple wands of teleport, seven candles	The "bag-of-holding bundle." Candles are for the Candelabrum — Izchak's Minetown lighting shop is an easy source.

Slot	Canonical pick	Notes
Required loot	Bell of Opening, Candelabrum of Invocation, Book of the Dead, Amulet of Yendor	The Invocation chain plus the prize.

A typical ascension AC sits in the **−25 to −40** range, but AC alone is not the difference between winners and losers.

What killed the runners-up

A look at characters who died in deep Gehennom (Dlvl 35-50) shows that their *inventories were nearly indistinguishable* from the winners'. Their AC was −23 to −40. They had wands of death, all three Invocation items, silver dragon scale mail. What killed them was *behavior*:

- **Inventory management mid-combat.** An Archeologist on Dlvl 35 tried to open a tin while a jabberwock, a displacer beast, and a zruty were adjacent. The tin opener prompt took the turn she didn't have.
- **Eating when not hungry.** A Tourist with AC −40 and all three Invocation items, deep in Gehennom, chose to eat a stalker corpse while satiated and choked to death. The ring of slow digestion on her finger does not prevent choking.
- **Out of escape consumables.** A Wizard on Dlvl 50 — within sight of the Sanctum — burned the last wand-of-death charge before reserving an escape route, then died blind and surrounded.

The gear gets you to Gehennom. **Discipline** gets you to the Sanctum. Keep at least one escape consumable (scroll of teleportation, wand of digging, oil-skin sack with a potion of full healing) within reach at all times. Don't take a turn that isn't moving you toward the Sanctum unless every adjacent square is clear.



The Ascension Run

You did it. You fought through Gehennom, defeated the High Priest, and snatched the Amulet of Yendor from Moloch's Sanctum. Now all you have to do is carry it from the absolute bottom of the dungeon, through every level of Gehennom, past every demon lord you thought you were done with, all the way back to the surface, and then through the Elemental Planes to the Astral Plane where your god awaits. Easy, right?

A free wish on pickup. The moment you pick up the Amulet of Yendor, your god grants you a single wish on the next turn (it fires automatically — you don't need to invoke it). This is one of the most generous moments in the game. Have your wish list ready *before* you reach the Sanctum: gauntlets of power, a +5 weapon of your choice, blessed cloak of magic resistance, or whatever you're missing for the climb. You only get it once.

Bring the authentic Amulet. The climb out is always open: every up-stair in the Dungeons of Doom takes you closer to the surface regardless of what you carry. The **Astral plane portal** at the top of the Endgame ladder, however, won't open without the real Amulet of Yendor in your inventory. Only the Amulet you took off the High Priest's body in Moloch's Sanctum counts. Bones-pile Amulets are fakes (the game converts a dead adventurer's real Amulet to a fake when their corpse becomes a bones level), and a wish for an Amulet of Yendor silently substitutes a fake too. If you didn't pick yours up off the High Priest, you don't have the real one.

The Ascension Run is the victory lap that keeps killing even the strongest adventurers. You have the most powerful artifact in the dungeon in your pack, every covetous monster in the Mazes knows it, and the dungeon itself is fighting to keep you from leaving. The most exhilarating and terrifying stretch of the game.

The Problems

Everything that can go wrong will try:

- **The Wizard of Yendor** periodically teleports to you, summoning nasty monsters and trying to steal back his Amulet. He will not stop. Kill him each time; he always comes back. He is the world's most persistent ex.
- **The Amulet blocks teleportation.** You can't level teleport while carrying the Amulet. You must climb every single staircase from the bottom of Gehennom to the surface. All of them. By foot.
- **Covetous monsters.** Demon lords and the Wizard can warp directly to your position and attack. They specifically target you for the Amulet, because apparently everyone wants this thing.
- **The Mysterious Force.** While carrying the Amulet in Gehennom, each time you climb stairs there's a chance the force grabs you instead. Often it just shuffles you elsewhere on the same level; sometimes it drops you **down** a level (Chaotic max), two levels (Neutral max), or even three (Lawfuls only) — the dungeon is literally holding onto you. The pull is hardest on Chaotics and softest on Lawfuls, but Lawfuls also pay the longest tail when it does trigger. In 5.0 it **decays** as it triggers: every yank slightly reduces the chance of the next one. The force is a hard Gehennom gate: it stops the moment you climb out of Gehennom, and it also never fires on the bottom four levels.

Strategy

You are no longer an explorer. You are a running back carrying the ball through the entire opposing team. Speed is everything.

- **Run, don't fight.** Don't explore. Don't loot. Just go up. Every turn you spend fighting something optional is a turn the Wizard gets closer to stealing back his Amulet.
- **Dig.** Use your wand of digging to reach staircases quickly. Straight lines through walls beat wandering through corridors.
- **Zap problems away.** Teleportation wands move monsters out of your path. Death wands remove them permanently. Use both liberally.
- **Kill the Wizard fast.** When he shows up (and he will), don't try to be clever. Finger of death, wand of death, or brute force. The faster he's down, the fewer monsters he summons.
- **Don't rely on Elbereth past the Castle.** Elbereth is **completely ignored** in all of Gehennom and on all four Elemental Planes plus Astral. You can still write it for the alignment, but no monster will care. Plan your heal-and-recover breaks around corridors, scrolls of teleportation, and conflict instead.

The Ascension Run rewards preparation and punishes hesitation. If you packed well at the Castle and your resistances are solid, this is a sprint, not a marathon. Once you reach the top of the Dungeons of Doom, the final staircase leads to the Elemental Planes: the last obstacle between you and divinity.



The Elemental Planes

Beyond the top of the Dungeons of Doom, the world dissolves into its raw elements. Four planes stand between you and the gods, each one a different flavor of hostile. There are no stairs here, only magic portals, hidden somewhere in each level, leading to the next. Find the portal. Survive the plane. Move on. There is no going back.

Plane of Earth

You arrive encased in solid rock and boulders, surrounded by earth elementals that hit like the mountain itself. The portal is buried somewhere in the level. Dig. A wand of digging is essential; a scroll of magic mapping or crystal ball reveals the portal's location so you can dig *toward* it instead of blind. This level is claustrophobic, dark, and punishing, but it's the gentlest of the four.

Plane of Air

The opposite extreme: an open void with no walls, no floor you can feel, just empty sky and air elementals moving faster than thought. They attack multiple times per turn and they cannot be genocided. A ring of conflict is devastating here: let them tear each other apart while you search for the portal. A scroll of magic mapping reveals it. The level is divided into drifting **cloud bubbles** that move on their own each turn: if you're standing in a bubble when it shifts, you shift with it. Walking with the drift can carry you across the level faster than fighting against it, and a bubble may eventually drift you onto the portal square itself. (Note that teleportation is blocked on every plane, so wand of teleport on yourself just prints "A mysterious force prevents you from teleporting!" It still works on monsters for clearing space.)

Plane of Fire

Everything is on fire. The ground is fire. The air is fire. Fire elementals fill the level, and fire traps dot every corridor. Fire resistance isn't just recommended: without it, you'll be dead in turns. Map the level, find the portal among the flames, and get there. Don't stop to fight anything you don't have to.

Plane of Water

The entire level is underwater. Without magical breathing (an amulet, the Amphibious intrinsic, or a polyform that breathes water) you will drown. Drowning calls the standard death path, so an **amulet of life saving** will rescue you — but you'll drown again on your next turn unless something has changed. The level is a labyrinth of water-filled chambers with occasional air pockets. Sea monsters prowl the corridors.

The standard tactic on arrival: genocide class ;. Read a scroll of genocide, target the entire ; class (eels, krakens, sea monsters, sharks, jellyfish, piranhas), and the level instantly empties of anything that can drag you under. This is the right moment for that scroll — class ; is almost nowhere else in the game (a kraken in Medusa's pool, a moccasin from a fountain are isolated encounters not worth burning a class-wipe on), and on the next plane it's irrelevant. Spend the scroll here. Then find the portal and push through. This is the last barrier between you and the gods.

The Astral Plane

You surface into the presence of the divine. Three altars stand in the great temple: Lawful, Neutral, and Chaotic. You must sacrifice the Amulet of Yendor on the altar matching your alignment to ascend. **Choose wrong and the game ends on the spot:** the opposing god gains dominion over your god, and you've handed victory to the other side. There is no retrieval — pick the right altar the first time.

The plane is swarming with Angels and the three Riders: Death, Famine, and Pestilence. The Riders cannot be permanently killed; they revive, they

pursue, they do not stop. Don't try to clear the level. You are not here to fight. You are here to reach one altar, make one sacrifice, and end this.

- Conflict and teleportation wands clear a path through the crowds, though note teleportation on **yourself** fails on every elemental plane (only monster-targeted teleport works).
- Identify the correct altar by walking adjacent to it: farlook (;) reveals an altar's alignment only when you're standing next to it. From across the room you only see "an aligned high altar." Plan to visit each in turn if necessary.
- The Riders will follow you. Outrun them, don't outfight them
- When you offer the Amulet on the correct altar: you ascend. The game is won. You've done what so few have done. Congratulations.



Appendices

Advanced Controls

The basic keys get you through every situation in NetHack. The commands below get you through them faster. Once you've spent a few thousand turns hammering s and walking corridors one square at a time, you may find they become reflexive.

Command counts

Type a number before any command and the game repeats it that many times: `10s` searches ten times, `20.` waits twenty turns, `5h` walks west five times. The sequence interrupts automatically as soon as anything interesting happens — a monster appears adjacent, your HP changes, a `--More--` prompt fires, the search turns up something. Press ESC to cancel early.

Counts up to 32,767 are accepted (five digits), but the practical limit is “however long you’ll watch the screen update without losing patience.” `99s` is plenty for any real searching job.

Repeat last command (Ctrl+A)

`Ctrl+A` runs whatever you just ran, with the same count if you used one. After your first `10s` of searching, every subsequent search is one keystroke. This is the most-used advanced command in the game and you’ll reach for it dozens of times per session. It remembers the *last command that actually executed*, not attempts that were canceled or bumped against a wall.

Movement prefixes

A handful of prefix keys modify the next command and then clear. They are essential for moving safely through populated areas.

- **F** then a direction — **force attack** into that square, even if no monster is visible there. Use it on suspected invisible monsters, on a displaced creature whose image is one square off from its real position, or to break your own Elbereth. Double-tap **F** to cancel without acting.
- **G** then a direction — **run** that direction until something interesting appears: a monster, an unknown item, a trap, a corridor branch, a closed door. Capital-letter directions (**H**, **J**, **K**, **L**, and the diagonals **Y**, **U**, **B**, **N**) are the same thing in one keystroke and are what most players actually use. **g** is a less-cautious variant of **G**, but in practice the difference is negligible.
- **m** then a direction — **move without attacking and without picking up**. Walk past your pet without striking it (“Pardon me, Fido”), step past an autopickup heap, refuse to walk into a known pool or lava square. With non-movement commands, **m** requests a menu instead of the default single-target prompt: **me** is “what would you like to eat?”, **ma** is “which tool?”, **m**, lets you pick from a floor pile.

Message history and redraw

Ctrl+P walks backward through the message history one message at a time. A monster’s special-attack warning, a shopkeeper’s price quote, or a status onset is preserved long enough to read it twice. The buffer holds the last several dozen lines; older messages roll off silently.

Ctrl+R redraws the screen — a useful reflex when the terminal gets garbled or when something doesn’t look right.

Dungeon overview and event journal

`Ctrl+O` (or `#overview`) lists the interesting levels you've visited — anywhere with an altar, throne, fountain, sink, shop, temple, vault, or branch stair, plus the Castle's tune once you learn it. Prefix with `m` to see *all* visited levels in a menu and add or edit annotations from there; `#annotate` does the same for the level you're standing on. The classic use is labeling stash floors so you remember which one held the bag.

`v` (or `#chronicle`) opens the **chronicle** — a chronological journal of major events from this run: first kills, conduct breaks, artifact gifts and crownings, prayer outcomes, level milestones, and entries into major branches. Mainly for end-of-run storytelling; for current conduct state use `#conduct`.

Options worth knowing about

Open the options screen with `O` (capital O, not zero). The defaults are reasonable, but a few settings change how the commands above feel:

- **number_pad** turns the numeric keypad into movement keys (1–9 for directions). Off by default; enabling it changes digit-prefix behavior so you press `n` first to enter a count.
- **autopickup** picks items up as you walk over them, filtered by `pickup_types` (e.g. `pickup_types:$?!` for gold, scrolls, and potions). The `m` prefix on movement suppresses autopickup for one step.
- **verbose** turns on a layer of extra descriptive messages (more detailed feedback when wielding, digging, hearing monsters, watching your pet, and so on). Turn it off if the message log feels noisy.

The full options list is deep, but the rest is taste and convenience. If something about the interface annoys you, there is almost certainly a setting for it.

A bigger interface shift requires a different binary: NetHack built with the **curses** windowtype (`nethack-curses` on most distributions, or a custom build with curses support) draws a properly paneled UI inside the terminal. Set `windowtype:curses`, `align_message:right`, `align_status:bottom`, `perm_invent`, and `windowborders` in your `rc`, open a 120×40 terminal, and you get a permanent inventory column, a multi-line message panel, and

bordered status and map regions. Plain tty NetHack pins the message line at row 0 no matter what you set.



Sokoban Solutions

Sokoban is a four-level boulder puzzle branch that goes *up* from its entrance. Each level has two possible layouts, chosen randomly. You push boulders onto pits to fill them and create a path to the next staircase. The penalty for cheating (phasing through walls, levitating over pits, destroying boulders) is a -1 Luck penalty per infraction, and it stacks. Play fair.

In the maps below, boulders are labeled A through T so the solutions can reference them. The ^ symbols mark pits; < marks the upstairs. Your starting position is marked @.

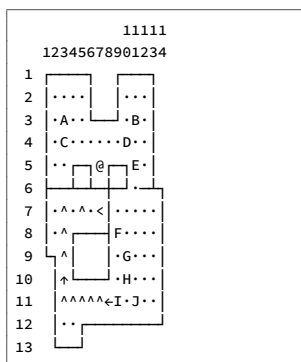
The arrows mark rolling boulder traps. In sokoban, a boulder pushed onto one keeps rolling in the direction you pushed until it falls into a hole or hits something.

After solving a level, push leftover boulders into corners so they can't block you if you return later. Items sometimes hide under boulders.

A note on mirroring. In 5.0 of the game, Sokoban levels may be flipped horizontally and/or vertically. The solutions still work; just mirror the directions.

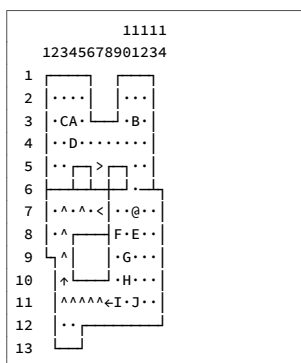
Solutions originally compiled by Boudewijn Waijers, with contributions by Jukka Lahtinen and others, for the steelytips.org NetHack archive maintained by Kate Nepveu. Adapted for 5.0 and reformatted for this guide.

Level 1, Version A



1. Push A right one square.
2. Push C up one square.
3. Push D right one square.
4. Push D left to (4,4).
5. Push E down to (11,8).

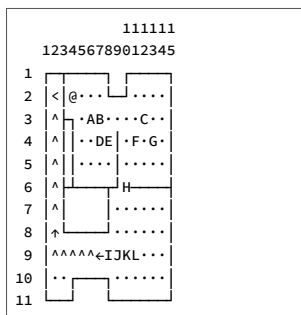
The map now looks like this:



1. Push H left one square.
2. Finish I, J, E, G, H, F, B, D, and C.

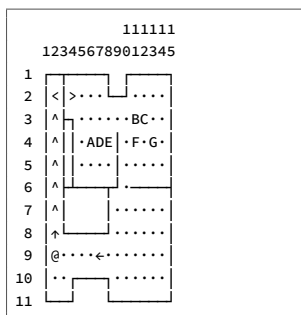
One boulder (A) remains. The two scrolls at (3,12) and (4,12) are always scrolls of earth.

Level 1, Version B



1. Push A down one square.
2. Push B right to (11,3).
3. Push H down to (10,8).
4. Push J up one square.
5. Finish I.
6. Push L up one square.
7. Finish K, J, H, and L.

The map now looks like this:

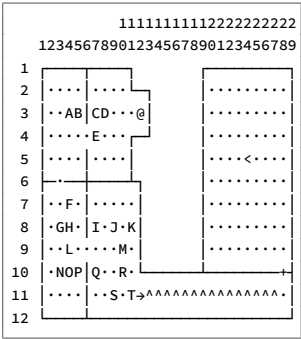


1. Push C down one square.
2. Push B left to (6,3).
3. Push G down one square, then left to (10,5).
4. Finish G.
5. Finish C and F like G.
6. Move B right to (11,3), then down two squares, then left to (10,5).
7. Finish B.
8. Move A up one square.

9. Finish A like B.

Two boulders (D and E) remain. The two scrolls at (2,10) and (3,10) are always scrolls of earth.

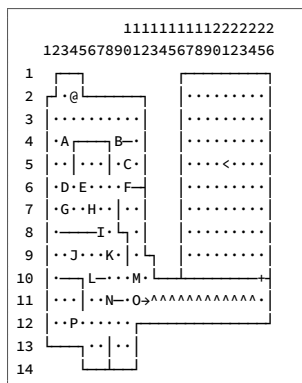
Level 2, Version A



- 1. Push E left to (3,4).
- 2. Push L right to (9,9).
- 3. Push R right one square.
- 4. Finish T, S, M, R, K, J, and L.
- 5. Finish N, O, P, G, and E.
- 6. Push F left one square.
- 7. Finish H.
- 8. Push F up to (3,4).
- 9. Finish F and A.

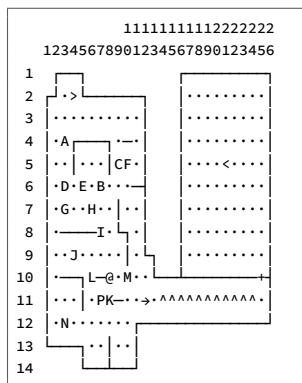
Five boulders (B, C, D, I, and Q) remain.

Level 2, Version B



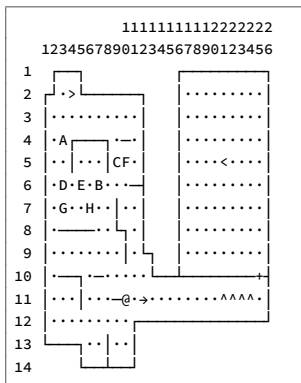
1. Push B down two squares.
2. Push C left one square.
3. Push P right three squares, then up one square, to (7,11).
4. Finish O.
5. Push N down one square, then left to (3,12).
6. Push M left one square.
7. Push F up one square.
8. Push B left two squares.
9. Push K down two squares.

The map now looks like this:



1. Push M right one square, then down to (11,11). Finish M.
2. Push N right to (10,12), then up to (10,10). Finish N like M.
3. Push K down one square, then left to (3,12). Finish K like N.
4. Push P right one square, then down one square. Finish P like N.
5. Push L down two squares, then left to (3,12). Finish L like N.
6. Push I down one square, then right one square, then down to (8,12). Finish I like N.
7. Push J right to (8,9), then down to (8,12). Finish J like N.

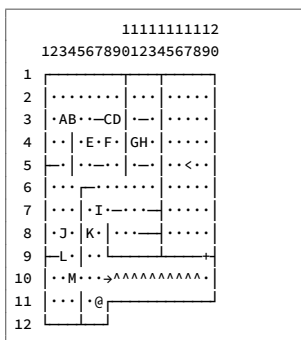
The map now looks like this:



1. Push H left one square.
2. Push B down one square, then right one square, then down to (8,12). Finish B.
3. Push C down one square, then left two squares, to (7,6). Finish C like B.
4. Push F left one square, then down one square, then left to (7,6). Finish F like C.
5. Push G right one square. Push D up one square.
6. Push E right two squares, to (7,6). Finish E like F.

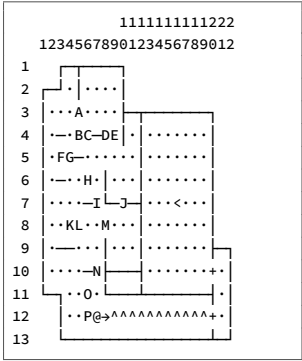
Four boulders (A, D, G, and H) remain.

Level 3, Version A



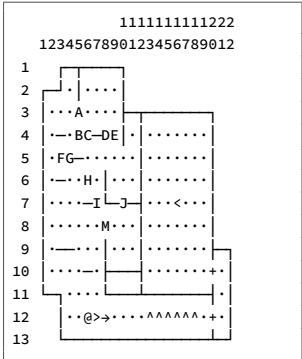
1. Push M left one square. Finish M.
 2. Push J right one square.
 3. Finish L, J, A, and B.
 4. Push D down to (9,6).
 5. Finish I.
 6. Push K down two squares, then left to (3,10). Finish K.
 7. Push E up one square.
 8. Push F right one square, then up one square, to (9,3).
 9. Push E down one square, then left one square, to (5,4).
 10. Push E up one square, then left two squares. Finish E.
 11. Push C down one square, then left three squares, to (5,4). Finish C like E.
 12. Push D right two squares, then left to (8,6).
 13. Push D up two squares, then left to (5,4). Finish D like E.
- Three boulders (F, G, and H) remain.

Level 3, Version B



1. Push O left two squares, to (4,11).
2. Finish P and N.
3. Push L down one square, to (5,9).
4. Push O up one square, to (4,10).
5. Finish L.
6. Push K right one square, to (5,8). Finish K.
7. Push O right one square, to (5,10). Finish O.

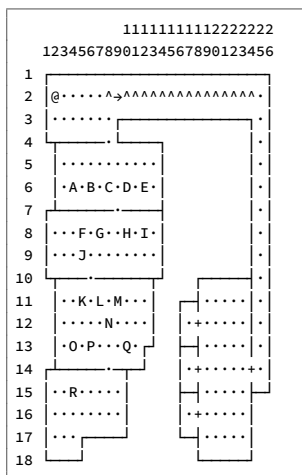
The map now looks like this:



1. Push G down to (4,8), then one square right, to (5,8). Finish G.
2. Push F one square right. Finish F like G.
3. Push M two squares right, to (10,8), then left to (5,8). Finish M.
4. Push J up two squares, to (10,5).
5. Finish I.
6. Push H right one square. Finish H.
7. Push A right two squares, to (7,3).
8. Push C down two squares, to (6,6). Finish C like H.

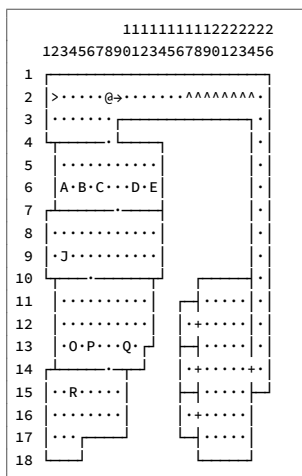
Five boulders (A, B, D, E, and J) remain.

Level 4, Version A (prize: usually bag of holding, 25% amulet of reflection)



1. Push A left one square.
2. Push B left one square.
3. Push C left one square.
4. Push E right one square.
5. Push D right one square.
6. Push G to (9,8), then up three squares, then left one square. Finish G.
7. Finish H and I like G.
8. Push J left two squares, to (3,9).
9. Finish F like G.
10. Push N right three squares, to (11,12).
11. Push L to (6,11), then up three squares. Finish L.
12. Finish M and K like L.
13. Push N left three squares, then up one square, to (8,11). Finish N like L.

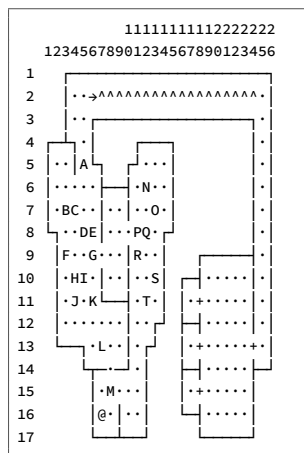
The map now looks like this:



1. Push R to (8,15), then up four squares. Finish R like L.
2. Push Q to (8,13), then down three squares, then left to (3,16). Push Q up one square. Finish Q like R.
3. Finish P and O like Q.
4. Push J to (6,9), then down three squares. Finish J like L.
5. Push C to (9,6), then down three squares. Finish C like J.
6. Finish B and D like C.

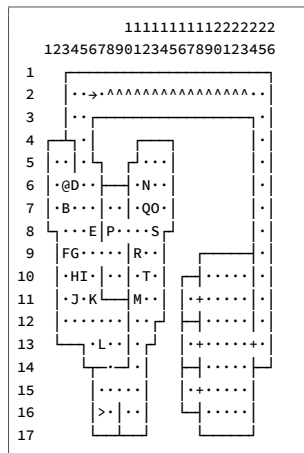
Two boulders (A and E) remain. There is a bag of holding in one of the small chambers ((17,12), (17,14), or (17,16)) next to the treasure zoo.

Level 4, Version B (prize: usually amulet of reflection, 25% bag of holding)



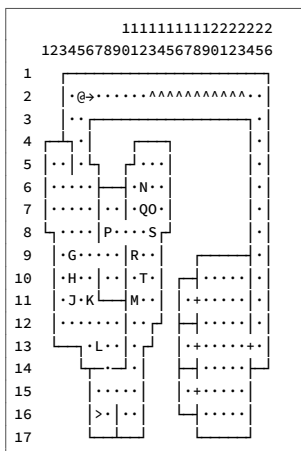
1. Push M right three squares, then up four squares.
2. Push T up one square.
3. Push S up two squares.
4. Push Q up one square.
5. Push P left three squares.
6. Push G left two squares.
7. Push D up two squares, then left one square.
8. Finish A.
9. Push B up one square.
10. Push C right one square. Finish C.
11. Push B down one square.

The map now looks like this:



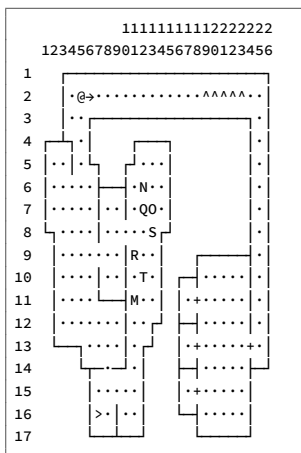
1. Push D right one square. Finish D.
2. Push B right two squares. Finish B.
3. Finish I.
4. Push E down one square, then left one square. Finish E.
5. Push F up three squares, then right two squares. Finish F.

The map now looks like this:



1. Push G right one square. Finish G.
2. Finish H and J like G.
3. Push P down one square, then left three squares, to (5,9). Finish P.
4. Push K to (6,9), then left one square. Finish K.
5. Push L right one square, then up one square, then left two squares. Finish L like K.

The map now looks like this:



1. Push T down one square.
2. Push R to (11,8), then left three squares. Finish R like P.
3. Finish M like R.
4. Push T left one square. Finish T like R.
5. Push N right one square.
6. Push Q down to (12,9), then left one square. Finish Q like R.
7. Push N left one square. Finish N like Q.

Two boulders (O and S) remain. There is an amulet of reflection in one of the small chambers ((17,11), (17,13), or (17,15)) next to the treasure zoo.



Voluntary Challenges

The conduct system is documented in Dion Nicolaas's Conduct Spoiler, originally posted to RGRN and archived at steelypips.org. The information below has been updated for 5.0 of the Mazes.

The game tracks a set of optional self-imposed restrictions called **conducts**. You can check which ones you've maintained at any time with `#conduct`. When you die or ascend, the end-of-game summary lists every conduct you kept. No conduct is required for victory; they exist for players who want a harder game or a more impressive ascension.

Conducts are not declared in advance. The game simply watches your actions and records whether you've broken each restriction. If you eat a corpse on turn 1, you've broken foodless, vegan, and vegetarian for the rest of the run. There's no going back.

The Food Conducts

These form a hierarchy: foodless is stricter than vegan, which is stricter than vegetarian.

Vegetarian. Don't eat meat. Specifically, don't eat the corpses of non-vegetarian monsters, and avoid items made from animal products (meat sticks, eggs from carnivorous creatures). In practice, this means living on permissible corpses and globs. Lichens, jellies, fungi and molds, and gray ooze or brown pudding globs are all safe. Fortune cookies, lembas wafers, and whatever vegetable food you find on the ground also work. Green slime is technically vegan, but eating its glob slimes you. The vegetarian monster list is broader than you might expect: all **b** (blobs), all **j** (jellies), all **F** (fungi and molds), all **v** (vortices), all **y** (lights), all **E** (elementals) except stalkers, and all **'** (golems) except flesh golems and leather golems. Vegetarian-safe is not the same as safe. Yellow mold corpses poison, violet fungus paralyzes,

and acid blobs sting going down. Monks already pay an alignment penalty for meat, so vegetarian is mostly free for them.

Vegan. Follow all vegetarian restrictions, plus avoid eating eggs, pancakes, lumps of royal jelly, cream pies, candy bars, *and* fortune cookies. (Yes, fortune cookies are vegetarian-safe but not vegan-safe. They contain eggs.) The conduct fires only on *eating*: carrying or using animal-derived items is fine, so vegans can still light the Candelabrum with wax or tallow candles, wear leather armor, and apply bone horns. Vegan also excludes puddings.

Foodless. Don't eat anything at all. Your only nutrition sources are prayer (which cures hunger from Hungry status onward, not just Weak/Fainting), the spell of stone to flesh on rocks in your inventory (which creates meatballs, but eating them breaks the conduct), and a ring of slow digestion (which slows hunger almost to a halt). Most foodless runs rely on finding a ring of slow digestion early or praying through hunger until one appears. Wishing for the ring is the usual plan if a wand of wishing or magic lamp turns up. Chewing through walls also breaks this conduct (it counts as eating rock).

Atheist

Don't interact with the divine. Specifically: don't #pray, don't #offer corpses at altars, don't #turn undead, and don't #chat with priests. The altar BUC flash also counts: any non-coin item you drop on an altar increments the conduct counter, so the original identification trick is off-limits too. This removes your safety net for starvation, stoning, illness, and cursed items. You'll need to solve every problem through items and knowledge alone.

Atheist runs require careful resource management. Without prayer to cure hunger, you need reliable food sources. Without sacrifice or altar BUC, identification is harder and you'll get no artifact gifts. The final Amulet offering for ascension is exempt, so a clean atheist ascension is mechanically possible.

Weaponless

Never hit a monster with a wielded weapon or weapon-tool. You can throw weapons, fire them from bows and crossbows, and use wands and spells. You can also fight bare-handed or with martial arts (Monks excel here). What you cannot do is swing a sword, axe, mace, aklys, pick-axe, unicorn horn, or any other weapon-class or weapon-tool item in melee while it's in your wielded slot. The one ranged exception that *does* break the conduct: using a wielded polearm at range via `#apply`.

This is less restrictive than it sounds. Monks start with strong martial arts and get better. Other classes can rely on spells, wands, and thrown daggers. A wielded cockatrice corpse still works (it's not a weapon). The main sacrifice is giving up the damage output of late-game artifact weapons.

Pacifist

Don't kill any monsters. Not directly, not with pets, not through any means that the game attributes to you. The pacifist runs on pets doing the fighting, on conflict to make monsters attack each other, on Elbereth to keep them at bay, and on creative use of the dungeon environment.

Pacifist ascensions are possible but require deep knowledge of the game's mechanics. Most pacifist players use a large, well-trained pet (often polymorphed into a purple worm or similar), the spell of charm monster, and extremely patient tactics.

Illiterate

Don't read anything. No scrolls, no spellbooks, no fortune cookies, no T-shirts. You also can't engrave anything more than a single "x" or "X" (the traditional illiterate's signature). You don't lose the conduct if you read blank scrolls or spellbooks, or Hawaiian shirts, the Book of the Dead, or messages already engraved on the floor.

Without scrolls, you lose access to identify, enchant weapon/armor, teleportation, remove curse, and genocide in their most common forms. Without spellbooks, you can't learn new spells or refresh old ones, so any starting

spell you have will eventually fade. This forces extreme reliance on wands, potions, and creative workarounds.

No Genocide

Never genocide any monster. Genocide is prompted by reading a **scroll of genocide** (uncursed picks one species; blessed wipes the whole class) and by **sitting on a throne**: one outcome in the throne-effect table (case 8 of 13) prompts you to genocide a single species. To preserve the conduct, type **“none”** at the prompt — don’t just press Enter, because empty input re-prompts and on a *curse*d scroll the game will eventually conjure random monsters instead of letting you escape.

This means you’ll face the full bestiary throughout the game, including master and arch-liches, mind flayers, cockatrices, and everything else that experienced players routinely eliminate. You’ll also have to cross the **Plane of Water** the hard way: the standard tactic of genociding class ; to clear out the eels and krakens is off-limits, so bring magical breathing and pay attention to where the sea monsters can reach you.

This is one of the milder conducts: many players ascend without genociding anything simply because they never find the scroll and never roll case 8 on a throne. But deliberately maintaining it against late-game threats takes discipline.

Polymorph Restrictions

Two related conducts track polymorphing:

No polymorph. Never let your form change. Obvious sources: potion or ring of polymorph, wand or spell of polymorph (zapped at you), and polymorph traps. Less obvious: a genetic engineer’s claw; eating a chameleon, doppelganger, or mimic corpse; and failing to cure slimedness (turns you into a green slime). The Amulet of Unchanging blocks every path. A failed system shock does *not* break the conduct. Keeping this conduct forgoes the advantages of powerful monster forms (master mind flayer, xorn, various dragons).

No polymorph objects. Never polymorph items. Don't zap items with a wand of polymorph, don't dip items in potions of polymorph, and avoid other means of transforming objects. This eliminates a powerful item-generation strategy (polypiling) that many players use to obtain specific high-value items.

Wishing Restrictions

Two related conducts:

Wishless. Never make a wish. Refuse wishes from wands, fountains, smoky potion djinn, thrones, and all other sources. **Picking up the Amulet of Yendor also triggers a wish prompt:** wish for “nothing” (the literal string) and the counter doesn't tick. Wishing for “nothing” is the standard escape hatch for any forced wish — keep it in mind whenever something hands you an unwanted wish. This is extremely challenging because wishes are the primary way to obtain critical items (silver dragon scale mail, speed boots, a bag of holding) when the dungeon doesn't provide them.

No wishing for artifacts. Make wishes, but never wish for an artifact. This prevents the most efficient wish strategy (wishing for Grayswandir, the Eye of the Aethiopica, or similar game-changing artifacts) while still allowing wishes for mundane necessities. The counter ticks even for *denied* artifact wishes (when the game gives you “something in your hand” instead), so be sure you can get the artifact before asking.

Combining Conducts

The real prestige comes from combining multiple conducts. A vegetarian atheist run is substantially harder than either alone. A pacifist illiterate vegan foodless atheist weaponless run is the stuff of legends (and has been done). The game's end screen lists all maintained conducts, and the community has long celebrated players who push the boundaries of what's possible within self-imposed constraints.

Recent editions of the Mazes have added several more tracked conducts:

Nudist. Never wear any armor, shirt, cloak, gloves, boots, helmet, or shield. Set the `nudist` option at game start. You fight the entire dungeon in your underwear. Officially tracked since 3.6.

Blind (Zen). Play the entire game without sight. Set the `blind` option at game start. You'll need telepathy and other senses to navigate. Officially tracked since 3.6.

Mazes 5.0 added five more tracked conducts: Pauper, Petless, Permadeaf, Sokoban, and Bonesless. Pauper, Permadeaf, Petless, and Bonesless are start-of-game options (you opt in or out before play). Sokoban is tracked automatically based on what you do during the run.

Pauper (new in 5.0)

Start with absolutely nothing: no gold, no inventory, no armor, no starting weapon. Set `OPTIONS=pauper` in your rcfile (rcfile or `NETHACKOPTIONS` env only; the in-game 0 menu cannot toggle it). Pauper implicitly sets nudist as well, so you also begin without armor. Pauper is a permanent conduct you never lose: it does not forbid acquiring or spending gold later. The conduct is about starting empty, not about staying penniless.

To keep the start from being impossible, the game compensates: you get two unspent weapon-skill slots and your role knows one signature spell or item. Wizard knows force bolt; Healer knows healing; Cleric, Knight, and Monk all know protection (Cleric also knows water); Archeologist knows touchstone; Cave Dweller knows flint; Rogue and Tourist know sack; Samurai knows gunyoki rations. The supply chests on early levels (see What to Pack) can provide much of your first kit.

Petless (new in 5.0)

Never have a pet. Set `OPTIONS=pettytype:none` in your rcfile to skip the starting companion entirely (this overrides per-role defaults). After that, you lose the conduct the moment anything becomes tame. The game won't stop you — scrolls of taming, the charm monster spell, food thrown at hostile dogs and cats, and magic-trap accidents all still work. Each one just breaks Petless on the spot.

Permadeaf (new in 5.0)

Never hear anything. Set `OPTIONS=permadeaf` (or `OPTIONS=deaf`) in your rcfile. This option is set-in-config only; the in-game 0 menu cannot toggle it. (Don't confuse `permadeaf` with the unrelated `acoustics` flavor toggle, which doesn't earn the conduct.) The game then runs as if you had the Deaf intrinsic from turn one and never recovered: all the "you hear water falling", "you hear someone counting money", "you hear a door open" messages and the ambient monster sounds ("you hear a slurp" and friends) are suppressed.

The catch: only the *messages* are suppressed. A shrieker still shrieks and still summons monsters and aggravates the level — you just don't get the warning that it happened. Treat empty silence near a F-class monster as the same threat as the usual SCREECH.

Many monster warnings, environmental cues (vaults, fountains, doors opening off-screen), and status messages arrive as sounds. Permadeaf requires navigating the dungeon by sight and logic alone, which turns out to be possible and occasionally educational about how much information you normally get for free.

Sokoban (new in 5.0)

Complete Sokoban without breaking the rules. Each cheating action costs **1 point of Luck** and increments the conduct counter: pushing into a wall to **squeeze past** a boulder (when you drop your stuff to fit), **fracturing** a boulder with a wand of striking or scroll of earth, **polymorphing** a boulder, or **dismounting** onto a boulder. Flying and levitation don't let you skip Sokoban's pit traps — the air currents pull you down regardless. The game tracks violations automatically. The conduct is for players who enjoy Sokoban's boulder-shoving and want their playthrough to acknowledge a clean solve.

Bonesless (new in 5.0)

Never inherit from another player's grave. To get the bonesless conduct, you have to turn bones off for the run: set `OPTIONS=!bones` in your rcfile (rcfile or `NETHACKOPTIONS` env only; the in-game `0` menu cannot toggle it). The same flag also stops your *own* death from generating a bones file for future players, so `!bones` cuts both directions of the bones cycle. The bonesless achievement is recorded only when bones was disabled, not when you happened not to encounter any. (Going a whole game without bones because the dungeon directory has nothing eligible is a separate enlightenment line — “never encountered any bones levels” — and doesn't earn the conduct.)



Shopping and Shopkeeper Pricing

Shops do more than sell: their pricing system is your most powerful identification tool. You can find full mechanics and interactive price tables in Part Four, *The Price Is Right*. What follows here is the rest: credit, debt, combat, and non-obvious rules.

Credit and Debt

Each shopkeeper keeps a per-customer ledger with three numbers: credit, debit, and loan. The most common confusion is around credit, so spell out exactly when it appears.

How you get credit. Two ways, neither automatic for a successful sale:

1. **Shopkeeper runs short of gold while paying you.** When you sell an item, the shopkeeper pays in gold by default. If they don't have enough gold to cover the offer, the game prompts: "Shopkeeper cannot pay you at present. Will you accept *N* zorkmids in credit for that?" Answering yes converts the shortfall (or the whole price, if they have zero gold) into credit. A *normal* sale where the shopkeeper has enough gold just pays you in cash, no credit involved.
2. **You drop gold on a shop floor square.** Any gold you drop or throw inside the shop is added to your credit balance (after paying off any existing debt first). This is the "shop as safe-deposit box" trick: credit can't be stolen by nymphs, can't fall into pits, and can't be lost to a polymorph trap.

How credit gets used. When you buy something, the shopkeeper applies your credit against the purchase price first ("the price is deducted from your credit"). Any remainder comes out of your gold. Credit is per-shop and per-shopkeeper, and cannot be withdrawn back to gold.

Is paying from credit better or worse than paying in gold? The price itself is identical: credit is deducted from the *post-Charisma*, *post-Tourist*,

post-angry cost at a strict 1:1 ratio, with no markup or discount either way. The differences are about how *safe* and *liquid* your money is, not how far it stretches:

- **Better** in that credit can't be stolen by nymphs, can't fall into a pit when you die, can't be lost to a polymorph trap, and doesn't bog you down with carry weight. A shop you'll come back to is a strong bank.
- **Worse** in that credit is locked to one shopkeeper. If you over-accumulate at a shop that doesn't have items you want (or the shopkeeper dies, or you anger them and they go hostile), the credit evaporates. You also can't tip altar donations, can't pay shrine fees, and can't bribe a demon out of credit.

Practical balance: park spare gold as credit at a shop you intend to keep visiting (the Gnomish Mines general store is a popular choice), but don't deposit more than you expect to spend there.

Debit is the inverse: it accrues when you *use* an unpaid item inside the shop (read a scroll, quaff a potion, zap a wand) and you haven't completed the purchase. You're charged a fraction of the item's price as a usage fee; future gold drops or sales pay it down before any new credit accumulates.

Loan appears only in the unusual case where the shopkeeper has *lent* you gold: you carry their coins as part of your inventory. Dropping gold in the shop pays this off before adding credit.

Walk-out hazard. Leaving the shop with unpaid items or unpaid debt turns the shopkeeper hostile. The Keystone Kops will pursue you through the dungeon, and the shopkeeper themselves is one of the toughest melee NPCs in the game: high HP, low AC, and unfazed by Elbereth. Pay the bill at the door.

Shopkeeper Behavior

A shopkeeper is one of the toughest NPCs in the game: high HP, good AC, hits hard, and unfazed by Elbereth or by the kind of clever escape that works on other monsters. They also see everything — they track every item you pick up and every item that enters the shop, even when you're invisible. The practical consequences for the player:

- Shopkeepers block the door whenever you have unpaid items.

- If you break something in the shop (a potion, a wand), you pay for it.
- Digging through a shop wall or floor doesn't escape the bill. The dig works, but the shopkeeper bills you for wall damage and the chase happens anyway. Tunnel-out is no shortcut.
- Artifact items are priced at special high prices. For most named weapons that lands in the 10,000–30,000 zm range. An unidentified long sword priced at 16,000 zm is not something to glance over: that exorbitant price is a give-away.
- A shopkeeper *can* be killed for the entire stock plus the till (1,000–4,000 zm and a skeleton key on death), but they're a tough fight (high HP, low AC, hits hard with their weapon), and killing them summons a wave of Keystone Kops to pursue you, costs you a chunk of alignment, and leaves the shop permanently empty: no more buying, no more selling, no more price-ID from that shopkeeper. Two community notes worth knowing: **polymorphing the shopkeeper first** (via wand or trap) means killing them no longer counts as murder, which is the preferred approach for Lawful and Neutral characters. And **chaotic humans** can sacrifice the shopkeeper's corpse on an unaligned altar to convert it, which is a niche but real motive. Strong late-game players sometimes do clear shops anyway, but it's not a casual mid-game move.

Beyond the rules, a few tactical habits pay off:

- **Drop everything at the door to see your bill.** Standing on the door square, drop your whole inventory; the shopkeeper's bill highlights the items you owe for. The shopkeeper isn't guessing — the game tracks unpaid items precisely — but it's a handy way to recall what you actually picked up when the shop has a hundred lookalikes.
- **Sell to build credit.** Credit acts as gold you can spend in that shop, and credit doesn't get stolen by nymphs or fall into pits. Selling a stack of useless daggers to a weapon shop is a way to “bank” gold safely while you're shopping in town.
- **Bones-shop gotcha.** When you find a shop in someone's bones file, all the items inside still belong to the dead adventurer's ghost shopkeeper; pick up anything and you owe the new shopkeeper full price. The shop floor is not free loot.
- **“Closed for inventory” engraving on a door.** This marks a shop whose door spawned **locked**, not an abandoned one. The shopkeeper

is still inside, the stock is still unpaid, and breaking the door down to get in just earns you a normal shop visit plus an angry shopkeeper. (In Orcus Town the shopkeepers are usually dead by the time you arrive — Orcus killed them — so the items there often *are* ownerless, but that's because of Orcus, not the engraving.)

The best strategy is usually to play fair: sell what you don't need, buy what you do, and use the pricing system to identify as much as possible before spending your gold on scrolls of identify.

Gem Identification Through Selling

Selling unidentified gems is **not** a reliable price-ID method. Shopkeepers offer 3 to 8 zm for any unidentified gem, real or glass alike, and the exact amount varies by both the gem's true identity and the shopkeeper. Real diamonds and worthless glass diamonds both quote in the same 3-8 zm range; you cannot tell them apart by price. Selling the same gem at two different shops gives different prices for *any* unidentified gem, not just glass.

The practical method is a **touchstone** (gray stone, base price 45, guaranteed at Mine's End and sometimes found elsewhere). Rubbing an unidentified gem against a **blessed** touchstone names the gem outright; with a merely uncursed touchstone you only get a streak color. (Archeologists and Gnomes get the full name from a non-cursed stone, a racial perk.) Hardness doesn't matter; every gem works. Once identified, real gems sell for their real value (often hundreds of zm each) while glass sells for almost nothing.

Real-gem prices

Once you know what a gem is, its type determines its base price. Real gems are tiny piles of liquid gold by weight: every gem weighs just 1, and gems of the same identified type stack into a single inventory slot regardless of count, so the only cost of hoarding a heap of identified rubies is one slot's worth of clutter.

Every real gem, with the unangry-shopkeeper buy price. Use the Cha/Sell/Tourist/Angry toolbar to see how the modifiers shift things.

The Mohs column is real-world mineral hardness on the Mohs scale (talc 1, diamond 10), and the game uses it in two places. Gems of Mohs 8 or higher count as **“hard”**, and hard gems do two things softer gems and glass can't: they can be used as a stylus to *engrave* Elbereth and other messages permanently into the dungeon floor (instead of the temporary dust scratch a finger or soft gem leaves), and they have about a 50% chance to *survive* being thrown rather than shattering on impact. Below Mohs 8, the gem only writes in dust and breaks on impact like glass. Hardness doesn't affect touchstoning — every gem can be identified by a blessed touchstone regardless.

Price	Gem	Color	Mohs	Notes
4500	Dilithium crystal	white	5	rarest white gem
4000	Diamond	white	10	hardest material in the game
3500	Ruby	red	9	
3250	Jacinth	orange	9	one of two orange gems
3000	Sapphire	blue	9	
2500	Black opal	black	8	
2500	Emerald	green	8	
2000	Turquoise	green	6	
1500	Citrine	yellow	6	
1500	Aquamarine	green	8	
1000	Amber	yellowish brown	2	softest gem; only dust-writes
900	Topaz	yellowish brown	8	
850	Jet	black	7	
800	Opal	white	6	
700	Chrysoberyl	yellow	5	
700	Garnet	red	7	

Price	Gem	Color	Mohs	Notes
600	Amethyst	violet	7	
500	Jasper	red	7	
400	Fluorite	violet	4	
300	Jade	green	6	
200	Obsidian	black	6	
200	Agate	orange	6	
0	(worthless glass)	any color	5	sells for 3–8 zm unidentified

The decision is rarely “carry or drop”; it’s “if I’m slot-pressed and have to thin the heap, which colors do I drop first.” Black opals, emeralds, and rubies are usually keepers; agate and obsidian first to go.

A few rules of thumb:

- **Every real gem is equally good for unicorn luck.** A 200 zm agate throws at an orange unicorn for the same +5 luck as a 3250 zm jacinth. Don’t sell off your “junk” gems before you’ve found an alignment-matching unicorn to feed them to.
- **The price column matters only when selling or wishing.** If you’re not in a shop and not weight-pressed, the price ranking is irrelevant.
- **If you must drop some gems** (you’re in a Mine’s End slot-crunch, or you’re consolidating before a stash), drop *duplicates of the cheap colors first*. Keep at least one of every identified type, because the touchstone work is already done.
- **Top tier** (≥ 2500 : dilithium, diamond, ruby, jacinth, sapphire, black opal, emerald) are worth selling individually as you find shops that buy them: 3000+ zm per gem is a real bankroll. Don’t fire-sale them to a non-gem-buying shop for half price.
- **Worthless glass never costs luck.** Glass thrown at a unicorn is either rejected (“not interested in your junk”) or quietly accepted. The Luck risk only fires on *real* gems thrown to a **wrong-alignment** unicorn (random -3 to $+3$).

Read the table as a **selling guide**, not a discard guide: real gems near the top are worth making time to sell at a gem dealer and worth wishing for if you’re flush on wishes. Lower-priced gems aren’t trash — they still feed unicorns and still touchstone-identify other gems by hardness comparison.



Weapons Tables

Damage is shown as **vs small** / **vs large**, the dice rolled before enchantment and excluding silver/material bonuses. **Wt** is unit weight; **Cost** is the unenchanted shop base price in zorkmids. **Hit** is the to-hit bonus baked into the weapon itself (most are 0). Two-handed weapons that prevent shield use and two-weapon combat are flagged in the notes. Weapons are grouped by their skill class so you can see your options within each skill tree at a glance.

Dagger

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
dagger	1d4 / 1d3	10	4	+2	iron	Stackable; Expert-skill Rogues can multishot up to four in a single throw.
elven dagger	1d5 / 1d3	10	4	+2	wood	Stackable. Sting is the artifact form.
orcish dagger	1d3 / 1d3	10	4	+2	iron	Stackable.
silver dagger	1d4 / 1d3	12	40	+2	silver	Stackable. Silver damage to demons, vampires, lycanthropes, shades, and imps. Common Rogue/Ranger off-hand.
athame	1d4 / 1d3	10	4	+2	iron	Stackable. Engraving with an athame doesn't dull the blade — you can write Elbereth in dust without spending an enchantment, the way other weapons must.

Knife

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
scalpel	1d3 / 1d3	5	6	+2	metal	The Healer's starter.
knife	1d3 / 1d2	5	4	—	iron	
stiletto	1d3 / 1d2	5	4	—	iron	
worm tooth	1d2 / 1d2	20	2	—	bone	
crysknife	1d10 / 1d10	20	100	+3	bone	Reverts to a worm tooth when dropped. Keep it welded; a fixed (erodeproof) crysknife reverts on only ~10% of drops.

Short sword

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
short sword	1d6 / 1d8	30	10	—	iron	The Rogue's starter; Samurai's <i>wakizashi</i> is just a short sword by another name.
elven short sword	1d8 / 1d8	30	10	—	wood	
orcish short sword	1d5 / 1d8	30	10	—	iron	
dwarvish short sword	1d7 / 1d8	30	10	—	iron	

Saber

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
scimitar	1d8 / 1d8	40	15	—	iron	
silver saber	1d8 / 1d8	40	75	—	silver	Silver does bonus damage to demons/weres/vampires/imps. Artifact forms: Grayswandir and Werebane (see Artifacts).

Broadsword

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
broadsword	1d4+1d4 / 1d6+1	70	10	—	iron	
elven broadsword	1d6+1d4 / 1d6+1	70	10	—	wood	
runesword	1d4+1d4 / 1d6+1	40	300	—	iron	Stormbringer is the chaotic artifact form.

Long sword

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
long sword	1d8 / 1d12	40	15	—	iron	At XL 5+, dipping in a fountain rolls 1-in-30. Knights get 1-in-6. On a hit, Lawfuls get Excalibur . Others get the sword cursed. Artifact forms: Excalibur, Frost Brand, Fire Brand, Giantslayer, Vorpall Blade, Sunsword.
katana	1d10 / 1d12	40	80	+1	iron	+1 to-hit baked in. Snickersnee is the artifact form.

Two-handed sword

Two-handed weapons get a **3/2 Strength damage bonus** in 5.0 — your STR damage contribution is multiplied by 1.5 when wielding a bimanual weapon. Combined with the high base dice below, that's a big chunk of why two-handed swords compete with one-hand-plus- shield even though you forfeit the shield slot. The same bonus applies to the battle-axe, dwarvish mattock, bardiche, and any other bimanual weapon.

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
two-handed sword	1d12 / 1d6+2d6	150	50	—	iron	Two-handed (no shield, no off-hand weapon). No dedicated artifact form.

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
tsurugi	1d16 / 1d8+2d6	60	500	+2	metal	Two-handed. The Tsurugi of Muramasa is the artifact form.

Axe

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
axe	1d6 / 1d4	60	8	—	iron	
battle-axe	1d8+1d4 / 1d6+2d4	120	40	—	iron	Two-handed (gets the 5.0 3/2 Str damage bonus). +1d4 small, +2d4 large. The Barbarian quest artifact Cleaver is a battle-axe.

Pick-axe

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
pick-axe	1d6 / 1d3	100	50	—	iron	Weapon-tool. Apply to dig through walls or down through floors (creates pit, then hole). Same pick-axe skill as the mattock.
dwarvish mattock	1d12 / 1d8+2d6	120	50	−1	iron	Two-handed (3/2 Str damage bonus). Digs through walls like a pick-axe. Slight to-hit penalty (−1).

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
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Club

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
club	1d6 / 1d3	30	3	—	wood	Caveman starter.
aklys	1d6 / 1d3	15	4	—	iron	Returns when thrown if wielded as your primary weapon (it's tethered); occasional misfire.

Mace

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
mace	1d6+1 / 1d6	30	5	—	iron	The Priest's guaranteed first sacrifice gift, Demonbane: a silver mace with +1d5 to-hit and double damage versus demons, plus a banish invoke.
silver mace	1d6+1 / 1d6	36	60	—	silver	+1d20 versus demons, weres, vampires, shades, and most imps.

Morning star

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
morning star	1d4+1d4 / 1d6+1	120	10	—	iron	+1d4 small, +1 large — punches above its weight for a one-hander.

Flail

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
flail	1d6+1 / 1d4+1d4	15	4	—	iron	+1 small, +1d4 large; one-handed.
grappling hook	1d2 / 1d6	30	50	—	iron	Tool, not a primary weapon, but trains P_FLAIL. #apply to hook and pull a target toward you.

Hammer

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
war hammer	1d4+1 / 1d4	50	5	—	iron	Mjollnir is the artifact form (Valkyrie sacrifice gift; its alignment will match the player's).

Quarterstaff

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
quarterstaff	1d6 / 1d6	40	5	—	wood	Two-handed but light; the Wizard's starting weapon.

Polearms

All polearms are two-handed. To strike at range, #apply the weapon (not wield-and-attack): you can hit at distance 2 orthogonally at Basic skill, with extra positions opening up at Skilled. You can still hit an adjacent monster the normal way with a polearm in hand, but the attack is treated as bashing — damage clamps to 1d2 base before bonuses and the weapon-skill bonus doesn't apply (Strength still does). Reach is what makes them worth carrying. Notes below describe each entry's extra damage; the reach mechanic is identical across the class.

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
partisan	1d6 / 1d6+1	80	10	—	iron	Reach.
ranseur	1d4+1d4 / 1d4+1d4	50	6	—	iron	+1d4 small, +1d4 large.
spetum	1d6+1 / 1d6+1d6	50	5	—	iron	+1 small, +1d6 large.
glaive	1d6 / 1d10	75	6	—	iron	Reach.
halberd	1d10 / 1d6+1d6	150	10	—	iron	+1d6 large.
bardiche	1d4+1d4 / 1d4+2d4	120	7	—	iron	+1d4 small, +2d4 large.
voulge	1d4+1d4 / 1d4+1d4	125	5	—	iron	+1d4 small, +1d4 large.
fauchard	1d6 / 1d8	60	5	—	iron	Reach.
guisarme	1d4+1d4 / 1d8	80	5	—	iron	+1d4 small.
bill- guisarme	1d4+1d4 / 1d10	120	7	—	iron	+1d4 small.
lucern hammer	1d4+1d4 / 1d6	150	7	—	iron	+1d4 small.
bec de corbin	1d8 / 1d6	100	8	—	iron	Reach.

Spear

All spears share the same skill (trident uses a different class — see below). The Valkyrie starts with one and can train to Expert. The **Caveman** is the actual spear-multishot specialist: Cavemen get +1 multishot on any thrown spear (regular, silver, javelin alike), so a stack of javelins is real ranged fire-power for them.

Spears get a **+2 to-hit bonus** when used against the big monsters — xorns, dragons, jabberwocks, nagas, and giants — the kebab bonus.

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
spear	1d6 / 1d8	30	3	—	iron	Throwable. Valkyrie's starting weapon.
elven spear	1d7 / 1d8	30	3	—	wood	
orcish spear	1d5 / 1d8	30	3	—	iron	
dwarvish spear	1d8 / 1d8	35	3	—	iron	
silver spear	1d6 / 1d8	36	40	—	silver	Silver damage to demons and weres.
javelin	1d6 / 1d6	20	3	—	iron	Stackable thrown weapon; Cavemen can ranged-spam them.

Trident

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
trident	1d6+1 / 1d4+2d4	25	5	—	iron	One-handed. +4 to-hit vs swimmers in water, +2 vs eels and snakes — the trident's signature bonus. Outside water it's an ordinary side-arm.

Lance

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
lance	1d6 / 1d8	180	10	—	iron	One-handed, P_LANCE skill. Mounted only: chance to joust for +2d10 primary (+2d2 off-hand) extra damage; a critical can shatter the lance. No bonus on foot.

Whip

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
rubber hose	1d4 / 1d3	20	3	—	plastic	Joke weapon; never spawns randomly.
bullwhip	1d2 / 1	20	4	—	leather	Archeologist's starter. Apply to disarm an adjacent monster (only when the target is wielding a weapon), or to yank yourself out of a pit (anchors on a nearby boulder, furniture, or big monster).

Bow

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
arrow	1d6 / 1d6	1	2	—	iron	
elven arrow	1d7 / 1d6	1	2	—	wood	
orcish arrow	1d5 / 1d6	1	2	—	iron	
silver arrow	1d6 / 1d6	1	5	—	silver	Silver damage to demons and weres.
ya	1d7 / 1d7	1	4	+1	metal	
bow	—	30	60	—	wood	
elven bow	—	30	60	—	wood	
orcish bow	—	30	60	—	wood	
yumi	—	30	60	—	wood	The Samurai's bow.

Weapon	Damage	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
	(S/L)					

Crossbow

Weapon	Damage	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
	(S/L)					
crossbow	1d4 /	1	2	—	iron	Stackable.
bolt	1d6					
crossbow	—	50	40	—	wood	Bolts pierce. Multishot kicks in at Str 18 (Str 16 for gnomes, who also get a baseline +1 multishot); below that, one bolt per turn. Rogues and Rangers reach Expert, Knights Skilled.

Sling

Weapon	Damage	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
	(S/L)					
sling	—	3	20	—	leather	Launches rocks, flint stones, and gems. Caveman starting weapon.

Dart

Weapon	Damage	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
	(S/L)					
dart	1d3 / 1d2	1	2	—	iron	Poisonable. Tourist starts with a stack of ~21–40 at +2.

Shuriken

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
shuriken	1d8 / 1d6	1	5	+2	iron	

Boomerang

Weapon	Damage (S/L)	Wt	Cost	Hit	Material	Notes
boomerang	1d9 / 1d9	5	20	—	wood	Curves back on a clear path; stops on a monster, wall, door, or sink. Low Dex or Fumbling means you catch it in the face.



Armor Tables

AC is the armor-class bonus the piece provides (higher number = more protection; this is the amount subtracted from your displayed AC). **MC** is the magic-cancellation level (1-3) — higher MC reduces the chance of magic attacks landing. **Wt** is weight; **Cost** is shop base price. The **Notes** column folds in the intrinsic property granted while the piece is worn, and tactical caveats. Armor is grouped by slot. Dragon scale mail is listed separately because of its sheer importance to the endgame.

Body armor (suits)

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
plate mail	+7	2	450	600	iron	Spellcasting penalty.
crystal plate mail	+7	2	415	820	glass	Never rusts. Spellcasting penalty.
bronze plate mail	+6	1	450	400	copper	
splint mail	+6	1	400	80	iron	
banded mail	+6	1	350	90	iron	
dwarvish mithril-coat	+6	2	150	240	mithril	Light, but mithril is metallic so the spellcasting penalty still applies (smaller than plate, larger than zero). Wizard mid-game goal.
elven mithril-coat	+5	2	150	240	mithril	Light, expensive. Mithril is metallic, so a casting penalty still applies — smaller than plate but not zero.
chain mail	+5	1	300	75	iron	
orcish chain mail	+4	1	300	75	iron	
scale mail	+4	1	250	45	iron	
studded leather armor	+3	1	200	15	leather	No spellcasting penalty.
ring mail	+3	1	250	100	iron	
orcish ring mail	+2	1	250	80	iron	
leather armor	+2	1	150	5	leather	
leather jacket	+1	—	30	10	leather	

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
gray dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	1200	dragonhide	Magic resistance. Endgame body-armor goal.
silver dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	1200	dragonhide	Reflection.
black dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	1200	dragonhide	Disintegration resistance + drain resistance.
yellow dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Acid resistance + stoning resistance. Rare.
orange dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Sleep resistance + free action.
white dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Gold resistance + slow digestion.
red dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Fire resistance + infravision.
green dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Poison resistance + sickness resistance.
blue dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Shock resistance + speed, same tier as speed boots.
gold dragon scale mail	+9	—	40	900	dragonhide	Hallucination resistance + permanent light (only body-slot light source).

Dragon scales

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
gray dragon scales	+3	—	40	700	dragonhide	Magic resistance. Make-into upgrade to scale mail.
silver dragon scales	+3	—	40	700	dragonhide	Reflection.
black dragon scales	+3	—	40	700	dragonhide	Disintegration resistance + drain resistance.
yellow dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Acid resistance + stoning resistance.
orange dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Sleep resistance + free action.
white dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Gold resistance + slow digestion.
red dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Fire resistance + infravision.
green dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Poison resistance + sickness resistance.

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
blue dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Shock resistance + speed, same tier as speed boots.
gold dragon scales	+3	—	40	500	dragonhide	Hallucination resistance + permanent light.

Shirts

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
Hawaiian shirt	+0	—	5	3	cloth	Tourist starter. Worn under body armor.
T-shirt	+0	—	5	2	cloth	Worn under body armor.

Cloaks

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
mummy wrapping	+0	1	3	2	cloth	Blocks invisibility while worn.
elven cloak	+1	1	10	60	cloth	Stealth.
orcish cloak	+0	1	10	40	cloth	
dwarvish cloak	+0	1	10	50	cloth	
oilskin cloak	+1	2	10	50	cloth	Resists grab attacks.
robe	+2	2	15	50	cloth	Casting bonus. Cancels most of the metal-armor penalty.
alchemy smock	+1	1	10	50	cloth	Poison resistance. Fantastic early-game safety.
leather cloak	+1	1	15	40	leather	
cloak of protection	+3	3	10	50	cloth	Highest MC of any cloak.
cloak of invisibility	+1	1	10	60	cloth	Invisibility.
cloak of magic resistance	+1	1	10	60	cloth	Magic resistance. The lightest source.
cloak of displacement	+1	1	10	50	cloth	Displacement.

Helmets

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
elven leather helm	+1	—	3	8	leather	
orcish helm	+1	—	30	10	iron	
dwarvish iron helm	+2	—	40	20	iron	
fedora	+0	—	3	1	cloth	Tourist starter; Eye of the Aethiopica base.
cornuthaum	+0	1	4	80	cloth	Clairvoyance. Wizards only; blocks other clairvoyance for non-Wizards.
dunce cap	+0	—	4	1	cloth	Int/Wis → 6. Auto-curses on wear. Needs remove curse to take off.
dented pot helm	+1	—	10	8	iron	
helm of brilliance	+1	—	40	50	glass	Adds enchantment value to both Int and Wis while worn (a +3 helm gives +3 Int and +3 Wis).
helmet	+1	—	30	10	iron	
helm of caution	+1	—	50	50	iron	Warning.
helm of opposite alignment	+1	—	50	50	iron	Flips alignment while worn. Generated cursed 9 times in 10. Trap item.
helm of telepathy	+1	—	50	50	iron	Telepathy while blind.

Gloves

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
leather gloves	+1	—	10	8	leather	
gauntlets of fumbling	+1	—	10	50	leather	Causes frequent fumbling. Generated cursed 9 times in 10. Avoid.
gauntlets of power	+1	—	30	50	iron	Sets Strength to 25.
gauntlets of dexterity	+1	—	10	50	leather	Adds enchantment value to Dex while worn (a +3 pair gives +3 Dex).

Boots

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
low boots	+1	—	10	8	leather	
iron shoes	+2	—	50	16	iron	
high boots	+2	—	20	12	leather	
speed boots	+1	—	20	50	leather	Very fast. Free extra action on 2/3 of turns.
water walking boots	+1	—	15	50	leather	Water walking. Critical for the Castle drawbridge.
jumping boots	+1	—	20	50	leather	#apply to leap to a chosen nearby square.
elven boots	+1	—	15	8	leather	Stealth.
kicking boots	+1	—	50	8	iron	
fumble boots	+1	—	20	30	leather	Causes frequent fumbling. Generated cursed 9 times in 10. Avoid.
levitation boots	+1	—	15	30	leather	Levitation. Generated cursed 9 times in 10. Cursed boots can't be taken off, so this is a trap item.

Shields

Armor	AC	MC	Wt	Cost	Material	Notes
small shield	+1	—	30	3	wood	
shield of drain resistance	+1	—	30	50	wood	Drain resistance.
shield of shock resistance	+1	—	30	50	wood	Shock resistance.
elven shield	+2	—	40	7	wood	
Uruk-hai shield	+1	—	50	7	iron	
orcish shield	+1	—	50	7	iron	
large shield	+2	—	100	10	iron	Blocks two-handed weapons.
dwarvish roundshield	+2	—	100	10	iron	
shield of reflection	+2	—	50	50	silver	Reflection. Saves the body-armor slot.



Spell Tables

The complete spellbook catalog, sorted by school then level. **Lvl** is the spell level; **Pw cost** is always $5 \times \text{level}$. **Type** distinguishes how the spell targets:

- **aimed** — a single-square IMMEDIATE; you pick a direction.
- **ray** — a beam from the caster through every square in a line until it stops.
- **untargeted** — no direction needed; the effect is on you, the level, or a fixed area.

Upgrade is the behavior change at **Skilled** rank or above in that school (except for protection, which upgrades at Expert, and jumping, which scales continuously).

Spell	School	Lvl	Type	Effect	Upgrade
force bolt	Attack	1	aimed	2d12 magical hit	—
chain lightning	Attack	2	untargeted	Shock damage to nearby monsters	—
drain life	Attack	2	aimed	Drains an XP level from target	—
magic missile	Attack	2	ray	2d6 force ray; Antimagic blocks it	—
cone of cold	Attack	4	ray	4d6 cold ray	Aimed explosion
fireball	Attack	4	ray	4d6 fire ray	Aimed explosion
finger of death	Attack	7	ray	Death-magic beam; monsters with magic resistance resist. (Against the player it's an instakill with no Antimagic check — only nonliving or demon forms are immune.)	—
healing	Healing	1	aimed	Restore hit points	—
cure blindness	Healing	2	aimed	Removes blindness	—
cure sickness	Healing	3	untargeted	Cures food poisoning and illness	—

Spell	School	Lvl	Type	Effect	Upgrade
extra healing	Healing	3	aimed	Heals more HP	—
stone to flesh	Healing	3	aimed	Statue → corpse; cures stoning	—
restore ability	Healing	4	untargeted	Restores one drained stat	Blessed: all stats
detect monsters	Divination	1	untargeted	Reveals monsters on level	Blessed: longer duration
light	Divination	1	untargeted	Lights the current room	—
detect food	Divination	2	untargeted	Reveals food on level	Blessed: identifies the food
clairvoyance	Divination	3	untargeted	Periodic glimpses of nearby map	Skilled: also detects nearby monsters during each pulse
detect unseen	Divination	3	untargeted	Reveals invisible monsters and traps	—
identify	Divination	3	untargeted	Identifies one inventory item	Blessed: multiple items
detect treasure	Divination	4	untargeted	Reveals gold and gems	Blessed: more detail
magic mapping	Divination	5	untargeted	Reveals the entire level	—
confuse monster	Enchantment	2	aimed	Next melee hit confuses target	Blessed: multiple hits
slow monster	Enchantment	2	aimed	Slows target's speed	—
cause fear	Enchantment	3	untargeted	Visible monsters flee	—
sleep	Enchantment	3	ray	Puts targets in line to sleep	—
charm monster	Enchantment	5	untargeted	Tames monsters in a 3×3 area	Blessed-scroll behavior
protection	Cleric	1	untargeted	Temporary AC bonus paid from Pw	Expert: 2× duration
create monster	Cleric	2	untargeted	Summons a random monster nearby	—
remove curse	Cleric	3	untargeted	Uncurses worn/wielded items	Blessed: all carried items
create familiar	Cleric	6	untargeted	Creates a tame companion	—
turn undead	Cleric	6	aimed	Damages/turns undead and demons	—

Spell	School	Lvl	Type	Effect	Upgrade
jumping	Escape	1	untargeted	Jump to a chosen nearby square	Range scales with rank
haste self	Escape	3	untargeted	Temporary fast movement	Blessed: longer duration
invisibility	Escape	4	untargeted	Become invisible	—
levitation	Escape	4	untargeted	Float over pits and water	Blessed: longer duration
teleport away	Escape	6	aimed	Teleports target away	—
knock	Matter	1	aimed	Opens doors, picks locks	—
wizard lock	Matter	2	aimed	Closes and locks a door	—
dig	Matter	5	ray	Digs through walls, rock, floor	—
polymorph	Matter	6	aimed	Polymorphs target	—
cancellation	Matter	7	aimed	Removes magical properties	—

The to-hit chance of most rays (sleep, magic missile, finger of death, and the unskilled forms of cone of cold and fireball) also scales with rank, even when the spell's behavior doesn't otherwise change.



Bestiary Tables

Every monster you might meet. Grouped by ASCII symbol so you can flip to the right page mid-game. **Lvl** is the base monster level. **Spd** is movement rate (12 is normal player speed). **AC** is armor class (lower is better). **MR%** is the percentage chance the monster resists your spells and magic attacks. **Attacks** lists each attack's mode, damage dice, and side effect; multiple attacks separated by • are made per turn. **Notes** folds in the most tactically-relevant trait flags (flies, sees-invis, regenerates, poisonous-corpse, etc.) alongside specific heads-ups for monsters that deserve one.

Ants and insects a

Insects, often in groups. The soldier ant is the early game's infamous killer: its poison sting can two-shot a low-level hero. Killer bees swarm; the queen bee in a beehive room is tough on her own.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
giant ant	brown	2	18	3	0	bite 1d4	
killer bee	yellow	1	18	-1	0	sting 1d3 poison	flies, poisonous-corpse, pois-res. Stings carry poison; a pack can wipe out an unprepared early hero.
soldier ant	blue	3	18	3	0	bite 2d4 • sting 3d4 poison	poisonous-corpse, pois-res. Poison sting. The most lethal a you'll meet in the early dungeon.
fire ant	red	3	18	3	10	bite 2d4 • bite 2d4 fire	fire-res.
giant beetle	black	5	6	4	0	bite 3d6	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
queen bee	magenta	9	24	-4	0	sting 1d8 poison	flies, poisonous-corpse, pois-res.

Blobs b

Slow, mindless, immune to a lot. Don't melee an acid blob with bare hands or a metal weapon you care about: the passive acid corrodes both. Gelatinous cubes paralyse on touch.

All blobs are mindless, sleep-resistant, and poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
acid blob	green	1	3	8	0	passive 1d8 acid	amorphous, acid-res, ston-res. Passive acid damage — punching one corrodes your gloves.
quivering blob	white	5	1	8	0	touch 1d8	
gelatinous cube	cyan	6	6	8	0	touch 2d4 paralyse · passive 1d4 paralyse	fire-res, cold-res, shock-res, acid-res, ston-res. Slow but paralyse on touch. Don't melee without free-action.

Cockatrices c

Medieval bestiary creature: a chicken with a serpent's tail whose touch turns flesh to stone. Carry a lizard corpse, fight gloved, and never wield a cockatrice corpse as a weapon unless your role explicitly resists stoning. See Petrification.

All cockatrices are poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
chickatrice	brown	4	4	8	30	bite 1d2 · touch petrify · passive petrify	ston-res. A small cockatrice. Same petrify rules apply.
cockatrice	yellow	5	6	6	30	bite 1d3 · touch petrify · passive petrify	ston-res. Touch petrifies. Always carry a lizard corpse.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
pyrolisk	red	6	6	6	30	gaze 2d6 fire · bite 1d6	fire-res.

Dogs and canines d

Wild canines hunt in packs. Domestic ones can be tamed by feeding (see Making Friends). Werejackals and werewolves can give lycanthropy.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
jackal	brown	0	12	7	0	bite 1d2	The first thing that ever killed you.
fox	red	0	15	7	0	bite 1d3	
coyote	brown	1	12	7	0	bite 1d4	
werejackal	brown	2	12	7	10	bite 1d4 lyc	regenerates, poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
little dog	white	2	18	6	0	bite 1d6	tameable. Guaranteed Cave-man/Ranger/Samurai starting pet.
dingo	yellow	4	16	5	0	bite 1d6	tameable.
dog	white	4	16	5	0	bite 1d6	
large dog	white	6	15	4	0	bite 2d4	
wolf	gray	5	12	4	0	bite 2d4	regenerates, poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
werewolf	gray	5	12	4	20	bite 2d6 lyc	
winter wolf cub	cyan	5	12	4	0	bite 1d8 · breath 1d6 cold	
warg	black	7	12	4	0	bite 2d6	cold-res.
winter wolf	cyan	7	12	4	20	bite 2d6 · breath 2d6 cold	
hell hound pup	red	7	12	4	20	bite 2d6 · breath 2d6 fire	fire-res.
hell hound	red	12	14	2	20	bite 3d6 · breath 3d6 fire	fire-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Cerberus	red	12	10	2	20	bite 3d6 · bite 3d6 · bite 3d6	fire-res. Three-headed hellhound. Only present in custom builds; not in the default game.

Eyes and spheres e

The floating eye's passive paralysis gaze is the single most famous newbie killer in the game: never melee one without free action, blindness, or a ranged attack. Once it's dead, eat the corpse: it grants intrinsic telepathy.

All eyes and spheres fly. All except *floating eye* also are mindless.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
gas spore	gray	1	3	10	0	death-burst 4d6	
floating eye	blue	2	1	9	10	passive 0d70 paralyse	amphibious. (no mindless) Passive gaze paralyzes on melee if you and the eye can both see each other. Use ranged, or wear a blindfold or towel to break sight. Corpse grants telepathy.
freezing sphere	white	6	13	4	0	explode 4d6 cold	cold-res.
flaming sphere	red	6	13	4	0	explode 4d6 fire	fire-res.
shocking sphere	bright-blue	6	13	4	0	explode 4d6 shock	shock-res.

Felines f

Cats. Kittens are common starting pets (Wizards always start with one; Valkyries and Tourists roll 50/50 between kitten and little dog). Wild felines (jaguar, lynx, panther, tiger, displacer beast) are hostile by default; you'd need a charm-monster spell, scroll of taming, or magic flute to flip them, and the wild rows aren't really "early-game" creatures.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
kitten	white	2	18	6	0	bite 1d6	tameable. Common Valkyrie/Wizard/Tourist starting pet.
housecat	white	4	16	5	0	bite 1d6	tameable.
jaguar	brown	4	15	6	0	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · bite 1d8	
lynx	cyan	5	15	6	0	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · bite 1d10	
panther	black	5	15	6	0	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6 · bite 1d10	
large cat	white	6	15	4	0	bite 2d4	tameable.
tiger	yellow	6	12	6	0	claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 · bite 1d10	
displacer beast	blue	12	12	-	0	claw 4d4 · claw 4d4 · bite 2d10	

Gremlins g

At night, their touch strips a random intrinsic (fire resistance, telepathy, etc.). In water or fountains they split into more gremlins. Kill them on dry land, ideally during daylight.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
gremlin	green	5	12	2	25	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6 · bite 1d4 · claw curse	swims, poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, pois-res.
gargoyle	brown	6	10	-4	0	claw 2d6 · claw 2d6 · bite 2d4	ston-res.
winged gargoyle	magenta	9	15	-2	0	claw 3d6 · claw 3d6 · bite 3d4	flies, ston-res.

Humanoids h

Dwarves and similar. Dwarves carry better-than-average loot (weapons, armor, pick-axes) and can wreck low-level heroes with that loot.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
hobbit	green	1	9	10	0	weapon 1d6	
dwarf	red	2	6	10	10	weapon 1d8	tunnels.
bugbear	brown	3	9	5	0	weapon 2d4	
dwarf lord	blue	4	6	10	10	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4	tunnels.
dwarf king	magenta	6	6	10	20	weapon 2d6 · weapon 2d6	tunnels.
mind flayer	bright- magenta	9	12	5	90	weapon 1d4 · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int	flies, sees-invis. Tentacle attacks drain Int; if Int hits 3 you die. Wear any helmet (blocks 7/8 of tentacles) or kill from range.
master mind flayer	bright- magenta	13	12	0	90	weapon 1d8 · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int · tentacle 2d1 drain-Int	flies, sees-invis. Five tentacles per turn. Catastrophic adjacent without a helmet. Any helmet blocks 7/8 of tentacles.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%Attacks	Notes
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Imps and minor demons i

Annoying small fry. Imps mostly insult you and miss; quasits drain Dexter-ity. None individually scary.

All imps and minor demons follow you up and down stairs. All except *imp* are poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%Attacks	Notes
manes	red	1	3	7	0	claw 1d3 · claw 1d3 · bite 1d4 sleep-res. No corpse.
homunculus	green	2	12	6	10	bite 1d3 sleep flies, poisonous-corpse, sleep-res.
imp	red	3	12	2	20	claw 1d4 regenerates. (no pois-res)
lemure	brown	3	3	7	0	claw 1d3 Gehennom-only, regenerates, sleep-res. No corpse.
quasit	blue	3	15	2	20	claw 1d2 drain-Dx · claw 1d2 drain-Dx · bite 1d4 regenerates.
tengu	cyan	6	13	5	30	bite 1d7 teleports, teleport-control.

Jellies j

Stationary or near-stationary. The blue jelly’s passive cold and the spotted jelly’s passive acid bite even when you hit them.

All jellies are amorphous and mindless.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%Attacks	Notes
blue jelly	blue	4	0	8	10	passive 0d6 cold corpse: cold + poison resistance.
spotted jelly	green	5	0	8	10	passive 0d6 acid corpse: temp acid + stone resistance.
ochre jelly	brown	6	3	8	20	engulf 3d6 acid · passive 3d6 acid corpse: temp acid + stone resistance.

Kobolds k

Weak early-game fodder. Most are poisonous to eat — leave the corpses unless you have poison resistance.

All kobolds have poisonous corpses and are poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
kobold	brown	0	6	10	0	weapon 1d4	
large kobold	red	1	6	10	0	weapon 1d6	
kobold lord	magenta	2	6	10	0	weapon 2d4	
kobold shaman	bright-blue	2	6	6	10	cast spell	

Leprechauns l

Steals gold and teleports away. The fix is to carry no gold near them, or to kill from range. The corpse drops the gold back.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
leprechaun	green	5	15	8	20	claw 1d2 steal-gold	teleports. Steals gold and teleports away. Carry no gold near them.

Mimics m

Disguised as items, walls, or fountains. Common in shops and zoos. The giveaway is the wrong object on the wrong square.

All mimics are amorphous, hide, and are acid-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
small mimic	brown	7	3	7	0	claw 3d4	
large mimic	red	8	3	7	10	claw 3d4 sticky	
giant mimic	magenta	9	3	7	20	claw 3d6 sticky · claw 3d6 sticky	

Nymphs n

Steals one item and teleports away. The cure is to engage from range, block her path with pets, or wear an amulet of life saving and steal the item back from her corpse later.

All nymphs teleport.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
wood nymph	green	3	12	9	20	claw steal-item · claw seduce	
water nymph	blue	3	12	9	20	claw steal-item · claw seduce	swims.
mountain nymph	brown	3	12	9	20	claw steal-item · claw seduce	

Orcs o

Pack hunters with mediocre loot but real numbers. The Mines are full of them; bring a chokepoint.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
goblin	gray	0	6	10	0	weapon 1d4	
hobgoblin	brown	1	9	10	0	weapon 1d6	
orc	red	1	9	10	0	weapon 1d8	pois-res.
hill orc	yellow	2	9	10	0	weapon 1d6	pois-res.
Mordor orc	blue	3	5	10	0	weapon 1d6	pois-res.
Uruk-hai	black	3	7	10	0	weapon 1d8	pois-res.
orc shaman	bright-blue	3	9	5	10	spell	pois-res.
orc-captain	magenta	5	5	10	0	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4	pois-res. Hits hard. Drops decent loot.

Piercers p

Clings to the ceiling and drops on you when you walk under. Hits hard for its level; you can't avoid the drop without flying or a clear ceiling.

All piercers hide.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
rock piercer	gray	3	1	3	0	bite 2d6	
iron piercer	cyan	5	1	0	0	bite 3d6	
glass piercer	white	7	1	0	0	bite 4d6	acid-res.

Quadrupeds q

Mixed bag. Rothes are early-game wreckers (three attacks per turn). Mumakil are slow but hit for 4d12 and shrug off blows.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
rothe	brown	2	9	7	0	claw 1d3 · bite 1d3 · bite 1d8	
mumak	gray	5	9	0	0	butt 4d12 · bite 2d6	
leocrotta	red	6	18	4	10	claw 2d6 · bite 2d6 · claw 2d6	
wumpus	cyan	8	3	2	10	bite 3d6	clings.
titanother	gray	12	12	6	0	claw 2d8	
baluchitherium	gray	14	12	5	0	claw 5d4 · claw 5d4	
mastodon	black	20	12	5	0	butt 4d8 · butt 4d8	

Rodents r

Mostly nuisance fodder. Giant rats are common in the early dungeon; their corpses are safe food.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
sewer rat	brown	0	12	7	0	bite 1d3	
giant rat	brown	1	10	7	0	bite 1d3	
rabid rat	brown	2	12	6	0	bite 2d4 drain-Co	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
wererat	brown	2	12	6	10	bite 1d4 lyc	regenerates, poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
rock mole	gray	3	3	0	20	bite 1d6	tunnels, eats metal. Will chew through your bag of gold or unattended weapons.
woodchuck	brown	3	3	0	20	bite 1d6	swims, tunnels.

Arachnids and centipedes s

Includes scorpions and centipedes. Many have poison stings. Spider-class monsters are common as the source of poisonous-corpse food poisoning.

All arachnids and centipedes are poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
cave spider	gray	1	12	3	0	bite 1d2	hides.
centipede	yellow	2	4	3	0	bite 1d3 poison	hides.
giant spider	magenta	5	15	4	0	bite 2d4 poison	poisonous-corpse.
scorpion	red	5	15	3	0	claw 1d2 · claw 1d2 · sting 1d4 poison	hides, poisonous-corpse.
Scorpius	magenta	15	12	10	0	claw 2d6 · claw 2d6 steal-amulet · sting 1d4 disease	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, ston-res.

Trappers and lurkers t

Stationary engulfers that look like a piece of dungeon. Stepping into one starts a swallow attack you can't easily escape. Identify with ; (farlook) before walking into obvious-trap squares.

All trappers and lurkers hide and follow you up and down stairs.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
lurker above	gray	10	3	3	0	engulf 1d6 wrap · engulf 2d6	flies.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
trapper	green	12	3	3	0	engulf 1d8 wrap · engulf 2d8	

Unicorns and horses u

There are two equine u-class creatures. **Horses** (pony, horse, warhorse) spawn hostile in the wild but can be tamed, saddled, and ridden; the Knight starts on a saddled pony.

Unicorns (white, gray, black for Lawful, Neutral, Chaotic) are powerful kickers, peaceful when your alignment matches theirs and hostile otherwise. Killing a co-aligned unicorn is a –5 Luck penalty (the game tells you “You feel guilty...”). Killing a cross-aligned one has no Luck consequence either way. If you don’t want the fight, throw any gem — even worthless glass — to pacify a hostile unicorn at no cost; throwing real gems also adjusts your Luck (see Luck and Fortune). A killed unicorn drops its horn.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
pony	brown	3	16	6	0	kick 1d6 · bite 1d2	tameable. Knight’s starting steed.
white unicorn	white	4	24	2	70	butt 1d12 · kick 1d6	pois-res.
gray unicorn	gray	4	24	2	70	butt 1d12 · kick 1d6	pois-res.
black unicorn	black	4	24	2	70	butt 1d12 · kick 1d6	pois-res.
horse	brown	5	20	5	0	kick 1d8 · bite 1d3	tameable.
warhorse	brown	7	24	4	0	kick 1d10 · bite 1d4	tameable.

Vortices v

Engulfing elemental clouds. Different colors deal different damage types: blinding sand, cold, shock (which also drains Pw), and fire. Only the fog cloud is slow; the rest move at speed 20-22 and will close on you.

All vortices fly, are mindless, and leave no corpse.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
fog cloud	gray	3	1	0	0	engulf 1d6	amorphous.
dust vortex	brown	4	20	2	30	engulf 2d8 blind	
ice vortex	cyan	5	20	2	30	engulf 1d6 cold	
energy vortex	bright-blue	6	20	2	30	engulf 1d6 shock · engulf 2d6 drain-Pw · passive 0d4 shock	
steam vortex	blue	7	22	2	30	engulf 1d8 fire	
fire vortex	yellow	8	22	2	30	engulf 1d10 fire · passive 0d4 fire	

Worms w

Long worms become a maze of tail segments as they grow. Purple worms swallow you whole and digest. Don't get cornered.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
baby long worm	brown	5	3	5	0	bite 1d4	
baby purple worm	magenta	8	3	5	0	bite 1d6	
long worm	brown	9	3	5	10	bite 2d4	drops a worm tooth.
purple worm	magenta	15	9	6	20	bite 2d8 · engulf 1d10 digest	

Xans and fantastic insects x

Grid bugs are trivial; xans, the bigger relatives, sting your legs and cut your carrying capacity.

All xans and fantastic insects are poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
grid bug	magenta	0	12	9	0	bite 1d1 shock	shock-res.
xan	red	7	18	-4	0	sting 1d4 leg-wound	flies, poisonous-corpse.

Lights y

Yellow light bursts on contact and blinds you for 10d20 turns. Black light bursts and hallucinates you for 10d12 turns. See Light Bursts.

All lights fly and are amorphous and mindless.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
yellow light	yellow	3	15	0	0	explode 10d20 blind	
black light	black	5	15	0	0	explode 10d12 hallu	sees-invis.

Zruties z

Slavic folklore — a hairy wild man of the woods. One species, one role here: a nasty mid-game brute. Good XP if you can handle the three-attack flurry.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
zruty	brown	9	8	3	0	claw 3d4 · claw 3d4 · bite 3d6	

Angelic beings A

Powerful late-game spellcasters with weapons. Astral-Plane Angels guard each High Priest — see The Ascension Run.

All angelic beings follow you up and down stairs. All except *Aleax* also fly. All except *couatl* also see invisible.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
couatl	green	8	10	5	30	bite 2d4 poison · bite 1d3 · hug 2d4 wrap	pois-res. (no sees-invis, no corpse)
Aleax	yellow	10	8	0	30	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6 · kick 1d4	(no flies)

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Angel	white	14	10	-4	55	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6 · claw 1d4 · spell 2d6 magic	
ki-rin	yellow	16	18	-5	90	kick 2d4 · kick 2d4 · butt 3d6 · spell 2d6 spell	
Archon	magenta	19	16	-6	80	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4 · gaze 2d6 blind · claw 1d8 · spell 4d6 spell	regenerates.

Bats and birds B

Erratic flyers, mostly nuisance. Vampire bats drain Strength with a poisoned bite (poison resistance blocks it).

All bats and birds fly.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
bat	brown	0	22	8	0	bite 1d4	
giant bat	red	2	22	7	0	bite 1d6	
raven	black	4	20	6	0	bite 1d6 · claw 1d6 blind	
vampire bat	black	5	20	6	0	bite 1d6 · bite drain-Str	regenerates, poisonous-corpse, sleep-res, pois-res.

Centaurus C

Half-horse archers with strong physical attacks. Forest centaurs wield bows; plains and mountain centaurs wield crossbows. They shoot at range.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
plains centaur	brown	4	18	4	0	weapon 1d6 · kick 1d6	
forest centaur	green	5	18	3	10	weapon 1d8 · kick 1d6	

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
mountain centaur	cyan	6	20	2	10	weapon 1d10 · kick 1d6 · kick 1d6	

Dragons D

Each adult dragon breathes its element type. Reflection bounces the ranged breath back. **Babies don't breathe** — they're just biters until they grow up. Adults are the source of dragon scale mail. See Dragon Scale Mail.

All except *Chromatic Dragon* also fly.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
baby gray dragon	gray	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby gold dragon	yellow	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby silver dragon	bright-cyan	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby red dragon	red	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby white dragon	white	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby orange dragon	orange	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby black dragon	black	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby blue dragon	blue	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
baby green dragon	green	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	poisonous-corpse.
baby yellow dragon	yellow	12	9	2	10	bite 2d6	
gray dragon	gray	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 magic · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Anti-magic breath. Magic resistance helps; reflection doesn't.
gold dragon	yellow	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 fire · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Fire breath. Drops gold-colored scales (light source).

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
silver dragon	bright-cyan	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 cold · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Cold breath plus reflection scales: your reflection target.
red dragon	red	15	9	-1	20	breath 6d6 fire · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Cone of fire. Get fire resistance before you meet one.
white dragon	white	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 cold · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Cone of cold. Cold resistance.
orange dragon	orange	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d25 sleep · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Sleep ray. Sleep resistance trivialises.
black dragon	black	15	9	-1	20	breath 1d255 disint · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Disintegration breath. Disint resistance OR reflection.
blue dragon	blue	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 shock · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Cone of lightning. Shock resistance.
green dragon	green	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 poison · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis, poisonous-corpse. Poison breath; poison resistance is enough.
yellow dragon	yellow	15	9	-1	20	breath 4d6 acid · bite 3d8 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d4	sees-invis. Acid breath; rare.
Chromatic Dragon	magenta	16	12	0	30	breath 6d6 rnd-breath · spell spell · claw 2d8 steal-amulet · bite 4d8 · bite 4d8 · sting 1d6	sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, follows stairs. (no flies)
Ixoth	red	15	12	-1	20	breath 8d6 fire · bite 4d8 · spell spell · claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 steal-amulet	sees-invis, follows stairs.

Elementals E

Air engulfs and suffocates, fire deals fire damage, water drowns if you're adjacent in water, earth is slow but tough.

All except *stalker* also are mindless.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
stalker	white	8	12	3	0	claw 4d4	flies, sees-invis, follows stairs. (no mindless)
air elemental	cyan	8	36	2	30	engulf 1d10	flies.
fire elemental	yellow	8	12	2	30	claw 3d6 fire · passive 0d4 fire	flies.
earth elemental	brown	8	6	2	30	claw 4d6	fire-res, cold-res, pois-res, ston-res.
water elemental	blue	8	5	2	30	claw 5d6	swims, amphibious, pois-res, ston-res.

Fungi and molds F

Stationary. Lichen corpses never rot — keep one in your pack as iron rations. Brown, green, and red molds bite back on melee with elemental passive damage (cold, acid, fire). Yellow mold stuns on passive contact; violet fungus has an active touch attack with sticking.

All fungi and molds are mindless.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
lichen	bright-green	0	1	9	0	touch sticky	
brown mold	brown	1	0	9	0	passive 0d6 cold	cold-res, pois-res.
yellow mold	yellow	1	0	9	0	passive 0d4 stun	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
green mold	green	1	0	9	0	passive 0d4 acid	acid-res, ston-res.
red mold	red	1	0	9	0	passive 0d4 fire	fire-res, pois-res.
shrieker	magenta	3	1	7	0	—	pois-res.
violet fungus	magenta	3	1	7	0	touch 1d4 · touch sticky	pois-res.

Gnomes G

Mines residents. Gnomish PCs find most of them peaceful. The gnome lord and gnomish wizard are real threats; the gnome king is rare but dangerous.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
gnome	brown	1	6	10	4	weapon 1d6	
gnome lord	blue	3	8	10	4	weapon 1d8	
gnomish wizard	bright-blue	3	10	4	10	cast spell	
gnome king	magenta	5	10	10	20	weapon 2d6	

Giant humanoids H

Boulder throwers. Storm / fire / frost giants match the dragon elements; titans cast spells. Eating a true giant's corpse raises Strength; the ettin and minotaur don't count as giants for this purpose.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
giant	red	6	6	0	0	weapon 2d10	
stone giant	gray	6	6	0	0	weapon 2d10	
hill giant	cyan	8	10	6	0	weapon 2d8	
fire giant	yellow	9	12	4	5	weapon 2d10	fire-res. Throws boulders.
frost giant	white	10	12	3	10	weapon 2d12	cold-res. Throws boulders.
ettin	brown	10	12	3	0	weapon 2d8 · weapon 3d6	
storm giant	blue	16	12	3	10	weapon 2d12	shock-res. Throws boulders for big damage.
titan	magenta	16	18	-3	70	weapon 2d8 · spell spell	flies. Tough humanoid with magic missiles. Casts spells.
minotaur	brown	15	15	6	0	claw 3d10 · claw 3d10 · butt 2d8	Two claws plus a butt. Heavy hitter; roams the Gehennom mazes.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Cyclops	gray	18	12	0	0	weapon 4d8 · weapon 4d8 · claw 2d6 steal-amulet	follows stairs, ston-res. Healer quest nemesis. Throws boulders.
Lord Surtur	magenta	15	12	2	50	weapon 2d10 · weapon 2d10 · claw 2d6 steal-amulet	follows stairs, fire-res, ston-res. Valkyrie quest nemesis.

Jabberwocks J

The monster from Lewis Carroll’s *Jabberwocky* (“O frabjous day! Callooh! Callay!”). Tough, hits hard, and moves at player baseline speed: you can’t simply walk away. Free XP if you’re set up for the fight; lethal if you walk into one early. Vorpall Blade was made for beheading it.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
jabberwock	orange	15	12	-2	50	bite 2d10 · bite 2d10 · claw 2d10 · claw 2d10	flies. Powerful; baseline speed. Free XP if you’re set up.

Keystone Kops K

Police force triggered by stealing from shops or hurting shopkeepers. Mostly weak individually but they swarm — and dead Kops respawn: each fallen Kop has a 1-in-5 chance to come back near the down-stairs and a 1-in-5 chance to come back at a random location, so killing them isn’t a stable solution. Get away or genocide them instead.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Keystone Kop	blue	1	6	10	10	weapon 1d4	
Kop Sergeant	blue	2	8	10	10	weapon 1d6	
Kop Lieutenant	cyan	3	10	10	20	weapon 1d8	
Kop Kaptain	magenta	4	12	10	20	weapon 2d6	

Liches L

Skeletal spellcasters. The arch-lich can cast touch of death; master and arch-liches both require magic resistance to survive their spell barrages.

All lichs regenerate, leave no corpse, and are undead, cold-resistant, sleep-resistant, and poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
lich	brown	11	6	0	30	touch 1d10 cold · spell spell	
demilich	red	14	9	-2	60	touch 3d4 cold · spell spell	
master lich	magenta	17	9	-4	90	touch 3d6 cold · spell spell	fire-res. Draws from the wizard spell list. Disperse or kill from afar.
arch-lich	magenta	25	9	-6	90	touch 5d6 cold · spell spell	fire-res, shock-res. End-game tier. Casts touch of death; magic resistance mandatory.

Mummies M

Mindless undead. Wand and scroll of undead turning shred them.

All mummies are mindless undead and leave no corpse.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
kobold mummy	brown	3	8	6	20	claw 1d4	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
gnome mummy	red	4	10	6	20	claw 1d6	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
orc mummy	gray	5	10	5	20	claw 1d6	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
dwarf mummy	red	5	10	5	20	claw 1d6	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
elf mummy	green	6	12	4	30	claw 2d4	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
human mummy	gray	6	12	4	30	claw 2d4 · claw 2d4	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
ettin mummy	blue	7	12	4	30	claw 2d6 · claw 2d6	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
giant mummy	cyan	8	14	3	30	claw 3d4 · claw 3d4	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.

Nagas

Long serpentine bodies with ranged attacks. All nagas are poison-resistant. Black naga corpses confer poison, acid, *and* stoning resistance. That's easily the best of the four eats.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
red naga hatchling	red	3	10	6	0	bite 1d4	fire-res.
black naga hatchling	black	3	10	6	0	bite 1d4	acid-res, ston-res.
golden naga hatchling	yellow	3	10	6	0	bite 1d4	
guardian naga hatchling	green	3	10	6	0	bite 1d4	
red naga	red	6	12	4	0	bite 2d4 · breath 2d6 fire	fire-res.
black naga	black	8	14	2	10	bite 2d6 · spit acid	acid-res, ston-res.
golden naga	yellow	10	14	2	70	bite 2d6 · cast spell 4d6	
guardian naga	green	12	16	0	50	spit 1d6 poison · bite 1d6 paralyze · touch · hug 2d4 wrap	poisonous-corpse. Lawful PCs may find them peaceful.

Ogres

Big melee brutes that wield weapons. Drop decent weapons and armor.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
ogre	brown	5	10	5	0	weapon 2d5	
ogre lord	red	7	12	3	30	weapon 2d6	

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%Attacks	Notes
ogre king	magenta	9	14	4	60	weapon 3d5

Puddings and oozes P

Brown and black puddings split when you hit them with an iron or metal melee weapon. Brown puddings **rot** your wood/leather/cloth/bone armor on bite; black puddings **corrode** your metal armor on bite *and* corrode your wielded metal weapon on the passive return-hit. Gray ooze **rusts** metal armor but doesn't split. Fire-kill puddings so they don't multiply, or pick a chokepoint.

Green slime is a Gehennom-only exception: doesn't split, leaves a glob, and one touch starts a 10-turn countdown to becoming one yourself. Fight at range, burn yourself with fire to clear it, or wear an **amulet of unchanging** (blocks and aborts the transformation). Prayer doesn't work in Gehennom, so don't rely on it. See *Delayed Deaths* for the full cure list.

All puddings and oozes are amorphous, mindless, cold-resistant, poison-resistant, acid-resistant, and petrification-resistant. All except *gray ooze* also are shock-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%Attacks	Notes
gray ooze	gray	3	1	8	0	bite 2d8 rust
brown pudding	brown	5	3	8	0	bite decay
green slime	green	6	6	6	0	touch 1d4 slime · passive slime
black pudding	black	10	6	6	0	bite 3d8 corrode · passive corrode

Quantum mechanics Q

The **Q** class is two creatures, both with random claw effects. The **quantum mechanic** teleports you on a hit: the annoyance is the lost position more than the damage, but in dangerous neighbourhoods a random teleport CAN kill. The **genetic engineer** polymorphs you: unless you have

Unchanging or magic resistance, one claw and you become something else. See The Genetic Engineer for the full treatment.

Both species also teleport themselves at random, and both leave poisonous corpses.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
quantum mechanic	cyan	7	12	3	10	claw 1d4 teleport	Self-teleports. Corpse toggles intrinsic Fast.
genetic engineer	green	12	12	3	10	claw 1d4 polymorph	Self-teleports. Corpse triggers polyself.

Rust monsters and disenchanters R

Rust monsters rust iron equipment on touch. Disenchanters drain enchantment from your armor when they hit you, and drain enchantment from your weapon when you hit them (passive counterattack). Either way, strip irreplaceable kit before engaging, and switch to silver or non-iron weapons against the rust monster.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
rust monster	brown	5	18	2	0	touch rust · touch rust · passive rust	swims. Touch rusts iron. Strip armor before engaging or use silver.
disenchanter	blue	12	12	-	0	claw 4d4 disenchant · passive disenchant	Gehennom-only. Active drains armor; passive drains weapon when you melee it.

Snakes S

Mostly poisonous. The pit viper and the cobra are the dangerous ones; garter snakes are fodder.

All snakes swim. All except *python* also hide.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
garter snake	green	1	8	8	0	bite 1d2	
snake	brown	4	15	3	0	bite 1d6 poison	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
water moccasin	red	4	15	3	0	bite 1d6 poison	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
python	magenta	6	3	5	0	bite 1d4 · touch · hug 1d4 wrap · hug 2d4	(no hides)
pit viper	blue	6	15	2	0	bite 1d4 poison · bite 1d4 poison	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
cobra	blue	6	18	2	0	bite 2d4 poison · spit blind	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.

Trolls T

Regenerates from corpses on a timer. Three reliable ways to keep a troll dead: **eat the corpse** before it revives; **kill it with Trollsbane wielded** (the artifact disables the revive timer); or **stone it** so it leaves a statue instead of a corpse. A troll left behind on an old level will be alive when you come back.

All trolls regenerate and follow you up and down stairs.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
troll	brown	7	12	4	0	weapon 4d2 · claw 4d2 · bite 2d6	
ice troll	white	9	10	2	20	weapon 2d6 · claw 2d6 cold · bite 2d6	cold-res.
rock troll	cyan	9	12	0	0	weapon 3d6 · claw 2d8 · bite 2d6	
water troll	blue	11	14	4	40	weapon 2d8 · claw 2d8 · bite 2d6	swims.
Olog-hai	magenta	13	12	-4	0	weapon 3d6 · claw 2d8 · bite 2d6	

Umbur hulks u

Confusion gaze. Don't melee without some way to dodge the gaze — blindness defeats it (the gaze requires mutual sight); free action does *not* (it covers paralysis, holding, and sleep, never confusion). The confusion stacks and wrecks navigation, and confused spellbook study garbles the spell.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
umber hulk	brown	9	6	2	25	claw 3d4 · claw 3d4 · bite 2d5 · gaze confuse	tunnels. Confusion gaze. Hard to navigate around. Hits hard too.

Vampires v

Drains XL on bite. Shapeshifts to bat or cloud. Vlad the Impaler is the boss of Vlad's Tower.

All vampires fly, regenerate, are undead, follow you up and down stairs, and shapeshift.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
vampire	red	10	12	1	25	claw 1d6 · bite 1d6 drain-XL	
vampire lord	blue	12	14	0	50	claw 1d8 · bite 1d8 drain-XL	
Vlad the Impaler	magenta	28	26	-6	80	weapon 2d10 · bite 1d12 drain-XL	Vampire boss in Vlad's Tower. Has the Candelabrum.

Wraiths w

Drains XL on touch. The wraith corpse, however, **gives** a level when eaten: one of the best food items in the game. Always eat a wraith corpse if you can.

All wraiths are undead and follow you up and down stairs.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
barrow wight	gray	3	12	5	5	weapon drain-XL · spell spell · claw 1d4 · touch 1d4 cold	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
wraith	black	6	12	4	15	touch 1d6 drain-XL	flies.
Nazgul	magenta	13	12	0	25	weapon 1d4 drain-XL · breath 2d25 sleep	sees-invis.

Xorns X

D&D's three-armed, three-eyed creatures from the Elemental Plane of Earth. They **phase through walls** (no rubble, no dig) and **eat metal items off the floor** — including the orcish dagger you were about to pick up. Their claws and bite are physical only, so worn armor and wielded weapons aren't directly at risk, but they hit hard for their level. The corpse grants temporary stoning resistance.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
xorn	brown	8	9	-2	20	claw 1d3 · claw 1d3 · claw 1d3 · bite 4d6	fire-res, cold-res, ston-res.

Apelike creatures Y

Apes and great apes mostly; sasquatches are fast. Carnivore corpses are safe food.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
monkey	gray	2	12	6	0	claw steal-item · bite 1d3	
ape	brown	4	12	6	0	claw 1d3 · claw 1d3 · bite 1d6	
owlbear	brown	5	12	5	0	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6 · hug 2d8	
yeti	white	5	15	6	0	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6 · bite 1d4	cold-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
carnivorous ape	black	6	12	6	0	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · hug 1d8	
sasquatch	gray	7	15	6	0	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6 · kick 1d8	sees-invis.

Zombies Z

Slow undead. Easy to kite. **Zombies never leave corpses on death**, so eating is a non-issue, but undead-turning effects (scroll, spell of turn undead, wand of undead turning) deal heavy damage to the whole class. The **skeleton** doesn't generate randomly: it only appears from a skeleton trap or a fixed placement (e.g., Vlad's Tower). Big zombie populations live in morgues.

All zombies are mindless and undead.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
kobold zombie	brown	0	6	10	0	claw 1d4	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
gnome zombie	brown	1	6	10	0	claw 1d5	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
orc zombie	gray	2	6	9	0	claw 1d6	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
dwarf zombie	red	2	6	9	0	claw 1d6	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
elf zombie	green	3	6	9	0	claw 1d7	follows stairs.
human zombie	white	4	6	8	0	claw 1d8	follows stairs.
ettin zombie	blue	6	8	6	0	claw 1d10 · claw 1d10	follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
ghoul	black	3	6	10	0	claw 1d2 paralyze · claw 1d3	poisonous-corpse, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.
giant zombie	cyan	8	8	6	0	claw 2d8 · claw 2d8	follows stairs, cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
skeleton	white	12	8	4	0	weapon 2d6 · touch 1d6 slow	cold-res, sleep-res, pois-res, ston-res.

Humans and elves @

The catch-all @ class: shopkeepers, priests, watchmen, role nemeses, quest leaders, soldiers, ninja, doppelgangers, weres, Medusa, Croesus, the Wizard of Yendor, and the player. Most start peaceful; the ones that don't are very dangerous. (Kops are *not* in this class — they're K.)

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
human	white	0	12	10	0	weapon 1d6	
wererat	brown	2	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	regenerates, poisonous-corpse.
werejackal	red	2	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	regenerates, poisonous-corpse.
werewolf	orange	5	12	10	20	weapon 2d4	regenerates, poisonous-corpse.
elf	white	0	12	10	2	weapon 1d8	sees-invis.
Woodland-elf	green	4	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	sees-invis.
Green-elf	bright-green	5	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	sees-invis.
Grey-elf	gray	6	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	sees-invis.
elf-lord	bright-blue	8	12	10	20	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4	sees-invis.
Elvenking	magenta	9	12	10	25	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4	sees-invis.
doppelganger	white	9	12	5	20	weapon 1d12	shapeshifter.
shopkeeper	white	12	16	0	50	weapon 4d4 · weapon 4d4	starts peaceful. Don't anger one.
guard	blue	12	12	10	40	weapon 4d10	starts peaceful.
prisoner	white	12	12	10	0	weapon 1d6	starts peaceful.
Oracle	bright-blue	12	0	0	50	passive 0d4 magic	starts peaceful.
priest	white	12	12	10	50	weapon 4d10 · kick 1d4 · spell cleric	starts peaceful. Temple defenders. Convert their altars or sacrifice on them.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
high priest	white	25	15	7	70	weapon 4d10 · kick 2d8 · spell 2d8 cleric · spell 2d8 cleric	sees-invis. Endgame altar guardian. Don't fight one head-on.
soldier	gray	6	10	10	0	weapon 1d8	follows stairs.
sergeant	red	8	10	10	5	weapon 2d6	follows stairs.
nurse	white	11	6	0	0	claw 2d6 heal	
lieutenant	green	10	10	10	15	weapon 3d4 · weapon 3d4	follows stairs.
captain	blue	12	10	10	15	weapon 4d4 · weapon 4d4	follows stairs.
watchman	gray	6	10	10	0	weapon 1d8	follows stairs, starts peaceful.
watch captain	green	10	10	10	15	weapon 3d4 · weapon 3d4	follows stairs, starts peaceful.
Medusa	bright-green	20	12	2	50	weapon 2d4 · claw 1d8 · gaze petrify · bite 1d6 poison	flies, swims, amphibious, poisonous-corpse.
Wizard of Yendor	bright-magenta	30	12	-8	100	claw 2d12 steal-amulet · spell spell	flies, regenerates, sees-invis, fire-res, poison-res. Covetous: teleports to you in late Gehennom and on the planes. The final boss.
Croesus	magenta	20	15	0	40	weapon 4d10	sees-invis, follows stairs. Vault guardian on Fort Ludios. Wields a two-handed sword and hoards gold, gems, and magic items off the floor.
Charon	white	76	18	-5	120	weapon 1d8 · touch 1d8 paralyse	sees-invis, starts peaceful.
archeologist	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	tunnels.
barbarian	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	
caveman	white	10	12	10	0	weapon 2d4	
healer	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6	
knight	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	
monk	white	10	12	10	2	claw 1d8 · kick 1d8	

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
priest	white	10	12	10	2	weapon 1d6 · spell cleric	Temple defenders. Convert their altars or sacrifice on them.
ranger	white	10	12	10	2	weapon 1d4	
rogue	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	
samurai	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d8 · weapon 1d8	
tourist	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	
valkyrie	white	10	12	10	1	weapon 1d8 · weapon 1d8	
wizard	white	10	12	10	3	weapon 1d6 · spell spell	
Lord Carnarvon	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · spell 4d8 spell	tunnels, starts peaceful. Archeologist quest leader.
Pelias	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · weapon 4d10	starts peaceful.
Shaman Karnov	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · spell 2d8 cleric	starts peaceful.
Hippocrates	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 1d6 · spell 3d8 cleric · spell 3d8 cleric	starts peaceful. Healer quest leader.
King Arthur	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · weapon 4d10	starts peaceful. Knight quest leader. Holds Excalibur if you didn't get it.
Grand Master	black	25	15	0	90	claw 4d10 · kick 2d8 · spell 2d8 cleric · spell 2d8 cleric	sees-invis, starts peaceful. Monk quest leader.
Arch Priest	white	25	15	7	90	weapon 4d10 · kick 2d8 · spell 2d8 cleric · spell 2d8 cleric	sees-invis, starts peaceful. Priest quest leader.
Orion	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · spell 4d8 spell	swims, amphibious, sees-invis, starts peaceful. Ranger quest leader. Bow user.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Master of Thieves	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · weapon 2d6 · claw 2d4 steal-amulet	starts peaceful. Rogue quest leader; also Tourist quest nemesis.
Lord Sato	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · weapon 4d10	starts peaceful.
Twoflower	white	20	15	10	90	weapon 4d10	starts peaceful. Tourist quest leader.
Norn	magenta	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · weapon 4d10	starts peaceful, cold-res. Valkyrie quest leader.
Neferet the Green	green	20	15	0	90	weapon 4d10 · spell 2d8 spell · spell 2d8 spell	starts peaceful. Wizard quest leader.
Thoth Amon	magenta	16	12	0	10	weapon 1d6 · spell spell · spell spell · claw 1d4 steal-amulet	follows stairs.
Master Kaen	magenta	25	12	- 10	10	claw 16d2 · claw 16d2 · spell cleric · claw 1d4 steal-amulet	sees-invis, follows stairs.
Master Assassin	magenta	15	12	0	30	weapon 2d6 poison · weapon 2d8 · claw 2d6 steal-amulet	follows stairs. Rogue quest nemesis.
Ashikaga Takauji	magenta	15	12	0	40	weapon 2d6 · weapon 2d6 · claw 2d6 steal-amulet	follows stairs. Samurai quest nemesis.
Dark One	black	15	12	0	80	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6 · claw 1d4 steal-amulet · spell spell	follows stairs.
student	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d6	tunnels, starts peaceful.
chieftain	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d6	starts peaceful.
neanderthal	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 2d4	starts peaceful.
attendant	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d6	starts peaceful.
page	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	starts peaceful.
abbot	white	5	12	10	20	claw 8d2 · kick 3d2 stun · spell cleric	starts peaceful.
acolyte	white	5	12	10	20	weapon 1d6 · spell cleric	starts peaceful.
hunter	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d4	sees-invis, starts peaceful.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
thug	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d6 · weapon 1d6	starts peaceful.
ninja	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d8 · weapon 1d8	
roshi	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d8 · weapon 1d8	starts peaceful.
guide	white	5	12	10	20	weapon 1d6 · spell spell	starts peaceful.
warrior	white	5	12	10	10	weapon 1d8 · weapon 1d8	starts peaceful.
apprentice	white	5	12	10	30	weapon 1d6 · spell spell	starts peaceful.

Major demons &

Major demons. Most can gate in reinforcements (a single barbed devil in your face can become five). Silver weapons and Demonbane do extra damage. Demon lords can be bribed with gold to leave.

They all follow you up and down stairs.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
water demon	blue	8	12	-4	30	weapon 1d3 · claw 1d3 · bite 1d3	swims, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
amorous demon	gray	6	12	0	70	seduction (see Seduction)	flies, poisonous-corpse, demonic. Displays as succubus or incubus by the demon's own randomly-assigned gender.
horned devil	brown	6	9	-5	50	weapon 1d4 · claw 1d4 · bite 2d3 · sting 1d3	poisonous-corpse, demonic.
erinyes	red	7	12	2	30	weapon 2d4 Str-drain	fire-res, pois-res. Variable attacks; can be amplified by alignment abuse.
barbed devil	red	8	12	0	35	claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 sticky · sting 3d4	poisonous-corpse, demonic.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
marilith	red	7	12	-6	80	weapon 2d4 · weapon 2d4 · claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 · claw 2d4	sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
vrock	green	8	12	0	50	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · claw 1d8 · claw 1d8 · bite 1d6	poisonous-corpse, demonic.
hezrou	green	9	6	-2	55	claw 1d3 · claw 1d3 · bite 4d4	poisonous-corpse, demonic.
bone devil	gray	9	15	-1	40	weapon 3d4 · sting 2d4 drain-Str	poisonous-corpse, demonic.
ice devil	white	11	6	-4	55	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · bite 2d4 · sting 3d4 cold · touch 1d1 slow	sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
nalfeshnee	red	11	9	-1	65	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · bite 2d4 · spell spell	poisonous-corpse, demonic.
pit fiend	red	13	6	-3	65	weapon 4d2 · weapon 4d2 · hug 2d4	sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
sandestin	gray	13	12	4	60	weapon 2d6 · weapon 2d6	shapeshifter, ston-res.
balrog	red	16	5	-2	75	weapon 8d4 · weapon 4d6	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
Juiblex	bright- green	50	3	-7	65	engulf 4d10 disease · spit 3d6 acid	flies, amphibious, amorphous, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res, acid-res, ston-res.
Yeenoghu	magenta	56	18	-5	80	weapon 3d6 · weapon 2d8 confuse · claw 1d6 paralyse · spell 2d6 magic	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.
Orcus	magenta	66	9	-6	85	weapon 3d6 · claw 3d4 · claw 3d4 · spell 8d6 spell · sting 2d4 drain-Str	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
Geryon	magenta	72	3	-3	75	claw 3d6 · claw 3d6 · sting 2d4 drain-Str	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.
Dispater	magenta	78	15	-2	80	weapon 4d6 · spell 6d6 spell	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.
Baalzebub	magenta	89	9	-5	85	bite 2d6 drain-Str · gaze 2d6 stun	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.
Asmodeus	magenta	105	12	-7	90	claw 4d4 · spell 6d6 cold	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, cold-res, pois-res.
Demogorgon	magenta	106	15	-8	95	spell 8d6 spell · sting 1d4 drain-XL · claw 1d6 disease · claw 1d6 disease	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic, fire-res, pois-res.
Death	hi_overflow	100	12	-5	100	touch 8d8 death · touch 8d8 death	flies, regenerates, sees-invis, teleport-control. Rider of the Apocalypse. Vanquish three to ascend.
Pestilence	hi_overflow	100	12	-5	100	touch 8d8 pestilence · touch 8d8 pestilence	flies, regenerates, sees-invis, teleport-control. Rider; spreads disease.
Famine	hi_overflow	100	12	-5	100	touch 8d8 famine · touch 8d8 famine	flies, regenerates, sees-invis, teleport-control. Rider; drains nutrition to starvation.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
mail daemon	bright-blue	56	24	10	127	—	flies, swims, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, starts peaceful, fire-res, cold-res, sleep-res, shock-res, pois-res, ston-res. Delivers in-game mail. Don't attack one — they don't fight back.
djinni	yellow	7	12	4	30	weapon 2d8	flies, poisonous-corpse, pois-res, ston-res.
Minion of Huhetotl	orange	16	12	-2	75	weapon 8d4 · weapon 4d6 · spell · claw 2d6 · steal-amulet	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.
Nalzok	orange	16	12	-2	85	weapon 8d4 · weapon 4d6 · spell · claw 2d6 · steal-amulet	flies, sees-invis, poisonous-corpse, demonic.

Golems

Mindless constructs. Wood and leather golems are early-game fodder; iron, stone, and clay golems are dangerous. The rare gold golem is a walking treasure pile.

All golems are mindless, sleep-resistant, and poison-resistant.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
straw golem	yellow	3	12	10	0	claw 1d2 · claw 1d2	cold-res.
paper golem	white	3	12	10	0	claw 1d3	cold-res.
rope golem	brown	4	9	8	0	claw 1d4 · claw 1d4 · hug 6d1	
gold golem	yellow	5	9	6	0	claw 2d3 · claw 2d3	acid-res.
leather golem	brown	6	6	6	0	claw 1d6 · claw 1d6	
wood golem	brown	7	3	4	0	claw 3d4	cold-res.
flesh golem	red	9	8	9	30	claw 2d8 · claw 2d8	fire-res, cold-res, shock-res.
clay golem	brown	11	7	7	40	claw 3d10	
stone golem	gray	14	6	5	50	claw 3d8	ston-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
glass golem	cyan	16	6	1	50	claw 2d8 · claw 2d8	acid-res.
iron golem	cyan	18	6	3	60	weapon 4d10 · breath 4d6 poison	no corpse. fire-res, cold-res, shock-res.

Sea monsters ;

Live in water. Eels and the kraken wrap you and drag you under to drown: instadeath without magical breathing. Stay off the water-adjacent square unless you have it.

All sea monsters swim and are amphibious.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
jellyfish	blue	3	3	6	0	sting 3d3 drain-Str	poisonous-corpse, pois-res.
piranha	red	5	18	4	0	bite 2d6 · bite 2d6	
shark	gray	7	12	2	0	bite 5d6	
giant eel	cyan	5	9	-1	0	bite 3d6 · touch wrap	
electric eel	bright-blue	7	10	-3	0	bite 4d6 shock · touch wrap	shock-res.
kraken	red	20	3	6	0	claw 2d4 · claw 2d4 · hug 2d6 wrap · bite 5d4	

Lizards :

Mostly harmless. **Lizard corpses cure petrification and never rot.** Carry one at all times — this is the standard answer to cockatrices and Medusa.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
newt	yellow	0	6	8	0	bite 1d2	swims, amphibious.
gecko	green	1	6	8	0	bite 1d3	
iguana	brown	2	6	7	0	bite 1d4	
baby crocodile	brown	3	6	7	0	bite 1d4	swims, amphibious.
lizard	green	5	6	6	10	bite 1d6	ston-res.

Name	Color	Lvl	Spd	AC	MR%	Attacks	Notes
chameleon	brown	6	5	6	10	bite 4d2	shapeshifter.
crocodile	brown	6	9	5	0	bite 4d2 · claw 1d12	swims, amphibious.
salamander	orange	8	12	-1	0	weapon 2d8 · touch 1d6 fire · hug 2d6 · hug 3d6 fire	poisonous-corpse, follows stairs, fire-res, sleep-res.



What Changed Since Last Time

If you're an experienced traveler returning after some time away, the 5.0 of the Mazes (NetHack 5.0.0, released May 2, 2026) includes several notable changes from 3.6.x, the last widely-played version before this one. (NetHack 3.7 was a long-running development branch and never shipped as a numbered public release; 3.6.x is the natural comparison point.) The most significant:

- **Themed rooms** are now a regular feature of dungeon generation. You'll encounter rooms with specific monster or item themes that didn't exist before.
- **Four new monster species**: the displacer beast, genetic engineer, gold dragon, and baby gold dragon now roam the Mazes.
- **The helm of caution** is a new piece of armor that grants warning. The helm of brilliance now always appears as a "crystal helmet" rather than a randomized appearance.
- **Chain lightning** is a new level 2 attack spell. Shock damage spreads from the caster in all directions and chains from one monster to the next, so it scales with the density of the room rather than the caster's aim.
- **Spellbooks** can be applied to check how worn they are.
- **Mind flayers** no longer wipe your map or identifications (the old "amnesia" effect on tentacle hit). They still drain Intelligence and have a separate chance to forget memorized spells and weapon-skill experience.
- **Unicorn horns** no longer restore lost attributes. This is a major change. In previous editions, the unicorn horn was a cure-all; now you'll need other solutions.
- **Dragon scale mail** now provides two extrinsic resistances instead of one. This makes it even more desirable.
- **Bags of holding** no longer destroy their contents on explosion. Items are scattered on the floor instead, which is bad but not catastrophic.

- **Loadstones** now resist knockback from combat attacks (the new knockback mechanic). A niche use if you can keep one uncursed.
- **Sacrifice** for artifact generation now requires a minimum sacrifice value.
- **Priest donations** are now randomized. The old fixed $400 \times \text{XL}$ formula is gone. The priest rolls a baseline between 150 and 250 ($\times \text{XL}$), and offering the worst-case ceiling of $500 \times \text{XL}$ guarantees protection. Offering too little when you could afford more sets a “Cheapskate” flag on that priest that permanently inflates future baselines.
- **Artifact effects** have been broadened. Several previously flavour-only artifacts now have real tactical edges. The most notable: **Snickersnee** now grants one free polearm-style reach attack per turn (“Shkinng!”) even on foot. **Sunsword** gains a #invoke blinding ray that works on any monster, not just undead — a 5-Pw on-demand Camera flash. **Trolls-bane** regenerates while wielded, a real lifeline for an early character. **Amulet of flying** confers flight on your steed as well as you, turning warhorses into water-crossing cavalry.
- **Gehennom** levels are more varied and interesting.
- **Medusa’s Island** now has four possible layouts.
- **Special levels** can now generate mirrored (flipped), so don’t rely on fixed maps.
- **New conducts** are tracked: pauper, petless, permadeaf, and Sokoban (no cheating).
- **Touch of death** has been reworked: instead of an instant kill, an unre-sisted hit now deals heavy damage and drains max HP. Magic resistance still fully blocks the spell.
- **Black dragon scale mail** now grants drain resistance in addition to disintegration resistance: a second extrinsic that was historically hard to find outside artifacts.
- **Green dragon scale mail** now grants sickness immunity.
- **New wish sources:** Vlad’s throne is guaranteed, and the Amulet of Yendor grants a wish on pickup. Either a magic lamp or magic marker is guaranteed in Orcus Town.
- **Charm monster** is now level 5 (was 3). **Sleep** is now level 3 (was 1). **Confuse monster** is now level 1 (was 2).
- **Cursed wands** may explode when used to engrave.
- **Monsters** can now use containers and unlock chests.

- **Valkyries** no longer start with a long sword. They start with a spear, making the Excalibur strategy less immediate.
- **Excalibur** fountain dipping is much harder for non-Knights: 1/30 chance per dip instead of the Knight's 1/6.
- **New amulets:** the amulet of flying grants flight, and the amulet of guarding provides +2 AC and +2 MC.
- **Minetown** has a 1/7 chance of generating as Orcish Town, with no shops and no priest.
- **Blessed potions of polymorph** now grant controlled polymorph, eliminating the need for polymorph control when using blessed potions.
- **Gehennom** has hot ground that can shatter dropped potions. Teleportation is now blocked only while a demon lord is present, not permanently.
- **Wand of speed monster** no longer grants permanent speed when self-zapped; use potions of speed instead.
- **Supply chests** now appear on the dungeon levels above the Oracle (about a 2-in-3 chance per level, placed in one random ordinary room), containing useful early-game items like healing potions and enchant scrolls.
- **Pets** can gain resistances from eating corpses, and dead pets can be revived by praying at a co-aligned altar while standing on their corpse.
- **Sink dipping (potions)** is new: pour potions down a sink and the message identifies the potion type without consuming a scroll.
- **Demonbane** is now a silver mace (was a long sword) and is the guaranteed first sacrifice gift for Priests.
- **Two-handed weapons** get a 50% increase to the strength damage bonus, making them more competitive with dual-wielding.
- **HP regeneration** uses a new formula: (experience level + Constitution)% chance per turn. The regeneration intrinsic now heals 1 HP unconditionally every turn on top of natural regen.
- **Covetous monsters** (demon lords, liches) now warp to either upstairs or downstairs when fleeing to heal, not always upstairs.
- **Alchemy** is nerfed: diluted potion stacks only alchemize 2 potions instead of the whole stack. Wearing an alchemy smock reduces the random blast chance to 1/30.
- **Glass items** (crystal ball, crystal plate mail) now crack in stages instead of instantly shattering, and can be made crackproof.

- **Candle light radius** now uses a square root formula: more candles in a stack give more light than before.
- **The Castle** no longer generates master lichs or arch-liches at level creation, making it significantly less dangerous on arrival.
- **Corpses, tins, and eggs** from intrinsic-granting monsters now have higher shop prices, making price identification of tins and eggs possible.
- **Monsters** no longer drop food items as death drops (except their own corpse), reducing food availability in the early game.
- **Shopkeepers** can now remove pits and webs around them, nerfing the classic pit-pinning kill setup. Walking into a peaceful shopkeeper now auto-pays any debts before the inventory prompt.



What to Lean Into

A few 5.0 changes have tactical implications worth pulling out:

Gold dragon scale mail is a light source. Its innate 2-square radius lets you skip the lamp and free that inventory slot.

A blessed potion of polymorph is now a self-contained controlled polymorph. No ring of polymorph control required: blessing the potion grants control for that one transformation. Single-use polymorph strategies (iron golem form for extreme AC, bat form to scout, pick something with a good intrinsic) are now accessible without needing to find or wish for the ring first. The ring is still useful for ongoing polymorphing, but for a single planned transformation, one blessed potion does the same job.

Vampire polymorph cycles between forms. A polymorphed vampire can `#monster` to switch between vampire, bat, and fog cloud. Fog passes through doors, bat flies, vampire fights — plan routes by form rather than direction.

What to Watch Out For

Sacrificing weak corpses no longer grinds Luck. If your current Luck exceeds the sacrificed monster's difficulty, you gain zero. A luckstone handles maintenance; sacrifice mid-tier monsters when you want to push higher.

Cleared but not cleaned levels lose loot. Monsters now loot unlocked containers and animate corpse piles. Lock your stash and don't haul speculative corpses through caster-heavy floors.

Gehennom shatters potions. Hot ground breaks any potion you drop. Carry, don't stash.



You descend the stairs...



Acknowledgements

NetHack has been played, cursed at, loved, and documented since 1987. The game itself is the work of the NetHack DevTeam, a loose collective of developers who have maintained one of the longest-running continuously developed open source projects in existence. But the documentation, the strategy, the collected wisdom about how to actually survive the thing, that came from the players.

In the early days, knowledge spread through Usenet, specifically the newsgroup **rec.games.roguelike.nethack** (RGRN). Thousands of players posted questions, argued about strategy, and slowly assembled a shared body of knowledge about a game that refused to explain itself. This was before wikis, before Reddit, before Discord. If you wanted to know whether a cockatrice corpse could be wielded as a weapon, you searched the RGRN archives and hoped someone had asked before you. Someone usually had.

RGRN gave the community its vocabulary. A **YASD** (*Yet Another Stupid Death*) is the post you make after dying to something you should have known better than to do. A **YAFAP** (*Yet Another First Ascension Post*) is the post you make when you finally win. Both traditions persist today, in the wiki, on Reddit, in Discord.

Out of those conversations came the first spoiler files: plain-text catalogs of every item, every monster, every interaction. Written by hand, cross-referenced against the source code, and shared freely.

This guide stands on their work. Specifically:

Kevin Hugo compiled the first comprehensive spoiler set for NetHack 3.2.2, covering every item class, monster stat, spell formula, and score calculation in methodical detail. **Dylan O'Donnell** updated the entire set for 3.4.3, correcting, expanding, and maintaining the files over several years. Together, the Hugo/O'Donnell spoilers became the definitive reference: 38 files covering potions, scrolls, wands, rings, amulets, tools, weapons, armor, artifacts, food, monsters, spells, and more. The item data tables throughout Parts

Four and Five of this guide are verified against their work. Published under BSD-like terms.

Paul Waterman wrote the WCST NetHack Spoilers (at Wheaton College in 1991), a single sprawling document that covered the entire game in a conversational, opinionated voice. Where Hugo and O'Donnell wrote reference manuals, the WCST was a travel guide. It told you not just what things did but what to do about them. It was the original inspiration for the tone and structure of this guide, though no text has been copied from it.

Kate Nepveu maintained steelpips.org, the web archive that preserved the Hugo/O'Donnell spoilers, the RGRN community articles, and her own excellent guides (including the Elbereth FAQ cited in our traps chapter). Without Kate's patient archival work, much of this material might have disappeared when Usenet faded.

The following **RGRN community authors** contributed articles, FAQs, and guides that informed specific sections of this guide:

David Damerell wrote the Object Identification FAQ. **Kieron Dunbar** wrote the wand identification guide. **Trevor Powell** compiled the Instadeath Spoiler. **Arien Malec** wrote the Medusa guide. **Matthew Lahut** wrote the prayer guide. **Boudewijn Waijers** mapped all eight Sokoban variants. **Steven Bush** calculated spellbook reading success rates. **Gregory Bond** documented shopkeeper pricing formulas. **Dion Nicolaas** cataloged the conducts. **David Goldfarb** wrote the air elemental FAQ. **Hojita Discordia** documented experience-value calculations.

And many others: Ray Chason, Pat Rankin, Geoduck, Topi Linkala, Geoffrey Eadon, Roger Broadbent, Sebastian Haas, Jukka Lahtinen, and the countless anonymous posters on RGRN who asked "has anyone tried..." and then reported back.

The NetHack Wiki has been an indispensable reference for this guide. Founded as "WikiHack" by Sgeo in 2005, it migrated to its own domain in 2010 and now contains over five thousand articles documenting every corner of the game. Its creators and maintainers include Pasi Kallinen, Drew Streib, Alex Smith, Shawn Moore, George Koehler, Tjr, ZeroOne, and Ray Chason. The wiki's NetHack 5.0.0 page is the community's living changelog and was a major reference for the 5.0 update of this guide.

The public servers where most NetHack is played today are nethack.alt.org (the longest-running public NetHack server, run by M. Drew Streib and Pasi Kallinen) and hardfought.org (run by K2, which also hosts the major variants). Both are free to play and log every ascension; the cause-of-death and ascension statistics cited throughout this guide come from their public records (see NAO's top types of deaths).

The r/nethack community on Reddit has kept NetHack discussion alive for a new generation of players. Its moderators over the years have maintained a welcoming space where veterans and newcomers trade advice, share ascension stories, and argue about optimal wish choices. The community's collective knowledge, passed along in thousands of threads, has informed the practical advice throughout this guide.

Above all, this guide exists because the game itself exists. **NetHack** has been developed since 1987 by the NetHack DevTeam, founded by Mike Stephenson, Izchak Miller, and Janet Walz. Izchak Miller passed away in 1994; the shopkeeper who bears his name in the Mines is a small measure of how much his work meant. The source lives at github.com/NetHack/NetHack.

The game itself descends from earlier roguelikes. **Hack** was written by Jay Fenlason in 1982 as a class project at Lincoln-Sudbury Regional High School, drawing on Toy and Wichman's *Rogue* (1980), and extended by Andries Brouwer through the mid-1980s. NetHack forked from Brouwer's Hack in 1987. Many of the most distinctive NetHack monsters — including the **grid bug**, the orthogonal-only critter whose name puns on both “insect” and “software bug” living on a character-cell grid (with a likely nod to the bugs in the 1982 film *Tron*) — were already in Hack before NetHack inherited them. The dungeon is older than the game.

The development was not always continuous. After version 3.4.3 in December 2003, the DevTeam went quiet (not absent, but silent) for twelve years. The dungeon was frozen. New players descended into the same unchanging corridors that had been killing people since 2003, writing new spoilers about a fixed game, dying in the same newly-documented ways. That the accumulated community wisdom from those twelve silent years remained useful, that the game was deep enough to sustain a decade of fresh analysis without adding a line of new code, tells you something about what kind of artifact NetHack is. Version 3.6 arrived in December 2015, and active development has continued since.

The current team, including Michael Allison, Ken Arromdee, David Cohrs, Jessie Collet, Kevin Hugo, Pasi Kallinen, Ken Lorber, Dean Luick, Patric Mueller, Pat Rankin, Derek S. Ray, Alex Smith, Mike Stephenson, Janet Walz, Paul Winner, Bart House, and Warwick Allison, has maintained and extended the game across nearly four decades. Everything in these pages is downstream of their work.

This is what a community looks like over decades. People writing things down so that others don't have to die the same stupid death. It's generous, it's nerdy, and it's one of the best things about NetHack.

All data in this guide has been verified against the current game source code. Any errors are ours alone.



A Traveler's Companion to the Mazes of Menace 5.0 Launch Edition, compiled by David Bau.

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